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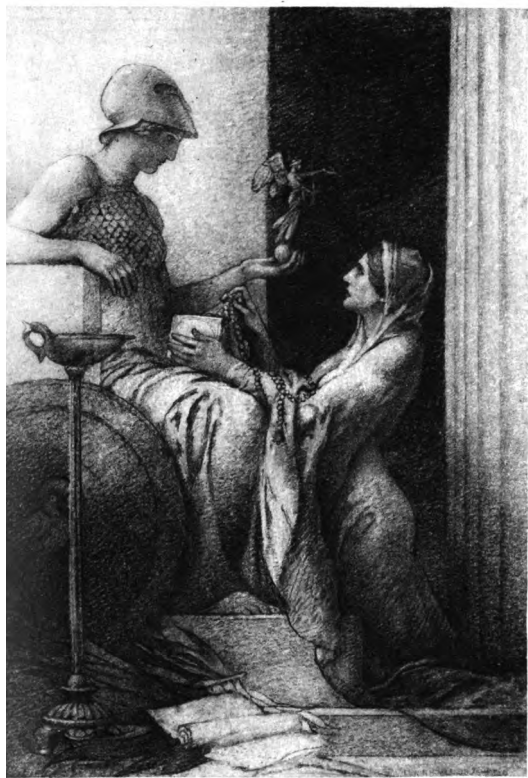




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THE
ROMANCE

of the ROSE
by W LORRIS

& J CLOPINEL
ENGLISHED

by F SELLIS

VOL TWO

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**THE
TEMPLE
CLASSICS**



THE ROMANCE OF THE ROSE

**Englished by
F. S. ELLIS**



**DAME
RICHESSSE**

SUMMARY OF CHAPTERS IN VOLUME II

Reason now abandons the Lover, leaving him all disconsolate, and he determines to seek the friend who had ere this given him comfort and advice. Suddenly, however, his friend appears and inquires the cause of his grief and desolation. He tells how that Fair-Welcome is imprisoned for no other crime than that he had helped him to snatch a kiss from the Rose. Hereupon his friend at considerable length instructs him how he may by various arts corrupt and deceive the gaolers who guard Fair-Welcome, and set him at liberty.

Cap. XLIII.
F. 7527-8096.

43.

The Lover recoils, horrified and shocked, at the loose code of morality propounded by his friend. Never, he exclaims, will he be guilty of hypocrisy and deception, but is anxious to be permitted to defy Evil-Tongue face to face. His friend assures him that this would be the extreme of folly; Evil-Tongue would overwhelm Fair-Welcome, and his grief and misery would be more profound than that which fell upon Charlemagne when Roland lost his life at Roncesvalles through the treachery of Genelon. But, exclaims the Lover, I should like to hang

Cap. XLIV.
F. 8097-8266.

Evil-Tongue. To what purpose? says his friend, since it were much easier to overcome him by ruse and deceit. But, says the Lover, can you not point out some better mode of taking the castle? Well, yes, says the friend, there is the path of Mad-Largess, constructed by Free-Giving. He who treads this path in the company of Richesse will certainly gain entry to the fort, but she will desert him there, and it is Poverty who will be his associate on the return journey.

Cap. XLV.
F. 8267-8374.

The friend then holds discourse on the hardships and miseries of poverty. But Poverty it is that reveals to a man the true friend who is ever ready to succour him in his distress.

Cap. XLVI.
F. 8375-8712.

The true friend gives to him whom he loves all that he hath, himself and his goods, nay, he will consent to be imprisoned or given in pledge to supply his friend's needs. Above all things is poverty to be dreaded, and Solomon's proverbs thereon are quoted to enforce the argument. But, says the friend, if you are rich, and desire to win the hearts of dames and damosels, be careful to be ready with pretty presents, fruits, ribbons, and small gifts, which do not embarrass your purse, according to the counsel of Ovid. But after all, he continues, this was needless in those good days when folk lived simply. The natural fruits of the earth supplied their wants, they drank of the water of the brook, and sheepskins sufficed for clothing, while the hollows of

the rocks, and bowers formed of the branches of trees, afforded them all the shelter they required.

When the people of the Golden Age would take their rest, they looked for no more than a couch of moss or leaves, for they enjoyed a climate of perpetual spring, and men and women lived a life of peace and love. Jealousy was unknown, for all men were equal, unembarrassed by kings, judges, or rulers of any sort. Marriage, among other evils, was not yet devised.

C. XLVII.
F. 8713-8772.

To illustrate the evils that ensued on the institution of marriage, the author draws a picture of the domestic tyranny endured by a woman cursed with a jealous husband, who reproaches her for permitting and encouraging the attentions of other men.

Cap.
XLVIII.
F. 8773-8848.

The jealous husband continues his tirade against his wife and against women generally. If women are fair, all men follow them; if ill-favoured, they are ready to throw themselves at those who will have them. He relates the story of Lucretia.

Cap. XLIX.
F. 8849-8967.

The story of Lucretia concluded. But alas! he exclaims, how many women are there in all the world to be compared with Penelope and Lucretia? An honest woman, he declares, is more rare than a phoenix, a white crow, or a black swan. He relates the history of Abelard

Cap. L.
F. 8968-9307.

and Heloïse, and pursues his invective against women and marriage. As well, he says, might one praise a dunghill for its beauty, beholding it overlaid with a rich silken coverlet, as admire a woman tricked out with jewels and finery. Beauty is the mortal enemy of Chastity; and Ugliness, who by nature is her servant, hates and detests her.

C. LI.
F.9308-9696.

The jealous husband continues his accusations against his wife, and heaps insults and reproaches on all women, quoting Virgil, Juvenal, Ovid, and King Solomon to support his argument.

C. LII.
F.9697-9842.

The enraged husband ends his complaints by seizing his wife by the hair of her head and laying violent hands on her person, until the neighbours, alarmed by her cries, rush in to separate them. Think you, says the friend, that there can be any love betwixt such a pair as I have described to you? Then he contrasts the relative positions of a man and woman before and after marriage. She was then the mistress, now is she the slave. The ancients, says the author, who enjoyed simple lives, knew no such vexations, but all lived peaceably and happily together. None desired to leave the places of their birth.

C. LIII.
F.9843-9948.

Till Jason built a ship and went forth in quest of the Golden Fleece. Ere this, crime was unknown upon the earth. But when Poverty arrived she brought her son Theft with her, and then were born Avarice and Covetousness and

other evils, so that men deemed it needful to set over them some one to do justice and punish malefactors.

So they chose from among themselves a strong and sturdy peasant, whom they agreed to call their king, and who should be allowed to live by the labour of others, but who, in his turn, swore to defend them. Then the malefactors grew too strong for the king, and he had to appoint sergeants and bailiffs, and to impose taxes for their sustenance. Gold and silver was coined into money, and arms were forged.

C. LIV.

F. 9949-
10,358.

Love was once free, but now women sell themselves for gold. The friend concludes by counselling the Lover never to oppose a woman's will if he would please her, for women believe that they know everything by nature, as surely as a cat knows how to catch mice without instruction or teaching. When the friend has finished his discourse, Sweet-Speech and Sweet-Thought reappear, but alas! they are unaccompanied by Sweet-Looks.

The Lover takes leave of his friend, and wanders awhile in the garden. But he is cast down by the advice given him by his friend, that he shall keep clear of the castle. He bends his steps towards it, however, in the hope of delivering Fair-Welcome. If he should find its walls no stronger than a well-baked cake he would attack it. But for the present he thinks it advisable to keep at a safe distance.

Cap. LV.

F. 10,359-
10,398.

C. LVI.
F. 10,399-
10,662.

The Lover turns towards the path of Much-Giving, the entry to which he finds guarded by a fair dame named Richesse, who disclaims his acquaintance, and forbids him entrance to her domain. At the same time that she draws an enticing picture of the delights and pleasures enjoyed by those who find their way thither, she warns him on the other hand that her votaries fall into the toils of Poverty, who in her turn introduces them to Hunger, of whom she draws a terrible picture. Hunger's dwelling is described as being situated in the farthest region of Scotland. Ceres, the Goddess of Plenty, and Triptolemus, the God of Agriculture, never visit that inhospitable spot. Hunger is the servant of Poverty, and the mother of Theft.

Dismissed scornfully by Richesse, the Lover wanders about the garden, soliloquising on his resolution to be faithful to his vow.

Cap. LVII.
F. 10,663-
10,764.

The God of Love appears, and demands how he has been keeping his commandments. He confesses that he has been tempted to despair, but declares his repentance. His master pardons him, and desires that he will recapitulate the articles of his creed, both as to things forbidden and commanded.

Cap. LVIII.
F. 10,765-
10,806.

The Lover recites his creed in a summary of ten lines to his master's full satisfaction, who then questions his liegeman on the state of his mind, his hopes and fears, and asks where are the Rose and Fair-Welcome. The former, he

replies, is lost to him for the present, and the latter imprisoned. The God bids him be of good cheer, and declares that he will summon his barons to lay siege to the castle.

The God of Love summons his barons to assemble in parliament under his banner. They include Dame Idleness, Nobleness of Heart, Richesse, Franchise, Pity, Largess, Courage, Honour, Courtesy, Delight, Simplicity, Company, Surety, Pleasure, Gallantry, Beauty, Youth, Humility, Patience, Hide-Well, Constrained-Abstinence, and False-Seeming.

Cap. LIX.
F 10,087-
10,864.

The God harangues his followers, and urges them to combat. He tells them that he has lost his servants Tibullus, Gallus, Catullus, and Ovid. But his servant William Lorris must not be allowed to perish, for he is not only one of his most faithful adherents, but is engaged in writing the "Romance of the Rose," which will instruct men fully in the art of love, and this will be carried on and completed at a later date by Jean Clopinel of Meun-sur-Loire. The barons of the host declare that, with the exception of Richesse, they are all ready and anxious for the fray, and explain their plan of attack. Constrained-Abstinence and False-Seeming will deal with Evil-Tongue; Courtesy and Largess will make account of the Duenna who mounts guard over Fair-Welcome; Pleasure and Hide-Well will attack Shame; Courage and Safety will overcome Fear; while Franchise and Pity will

Cap. LX.
F. 10,865-
11,312.
C. 5811
(correspond-
ing with l.
11,061 of F.)
-6060.

make naught of Danger ; but they ask that they may have the aid of Venus.

The God of Love replies that the Goddess Venus, his mother, is not under his command, but that he owes to her respect and reverence. He further explains wherein lies the difference between the service due to him and to his mother. This explanation affords us a clear view of the distinction made by the poets of the Middle Ages between the sentiment inspired by Venus, the Goddess of sensual pleasure, and that inspired by her son, who ruled the hearts of men. Oftentimes it haps that Venus and her son use their influence in concert, but as often also they act independently.

Richesse having refused to take part in the siege, or aid the Lover, since he is not numbered among her friends, Cupid declares that he will avenge himself upon her by reducing to poverty the rich men who fall into his snares. He much objects to the presence of False-Seeming in his host, but the barons declare that it is absolutely necessary to ensure the success of their enterprise.

Cap. LXI.

F. 11,313-

11,576.

C.6061-6324.

The God agrees to his remaining among the host, but proposes that he shall declare at full who and what he is. To this False-Seeming makes demur, on the ground that if he discovers himself his revelation will bring down upon him the wrath of his companions, but at the command of Love he speaks out. He avows that he is the son of Fraud by Hypocrisy ; he makes

his dwelling alike in the cloister and in the world. He appears sometimes in religious, sometimes in secular habit, but it is not by his habit that he may be known. He proclaims himself capable of any wickedness that may suit his purpose. The God of Love interrupts his discourse by asking: Who is this impudent and unblushing devil? Is religion to be looked for among the laity? Most assuredly, replies False-Seeming. Because a man does not wear a religious habit that is no reason that he leads an evil life. He then begins a denunciation of the brethren of the mendicant orders, of whom the secular clergy were jealous to a degree, on account of the special privileges they enjoyed. False-Seeming declares, moreover, that he has as many different shapes as Proteus himself.

He knows well how to change his disguise. Now is he a knight, now a monk, now a prelate, now a canon, or whatever other character pleases him. He now holds forth as a preaching friar, and describes how the powers accorded to him by the Pope in that capacity enable him to gain the confidence of the people, and set at nought the secular clergy. He makes a general attack on the mendicants, following the arguments of William of S. Amour, who wrote in the twelfth century in defence of the University of Paris, when it denounced the Begging Friars. At the request of the God of Love he undertakes to specify what people may reasonably gain a livelihood by mendicancy.

Cap. LXII.
F. 11,577-
11,984;
C. 6325-6714.

and declares her intention of so instructing Fair-Welcome that he may avenge her. [But it seems strange that while her complaint is against men, her instructions tend to teach her pupil how he may overcome the opposite sex.]

Cap.
LXXII.
F. 13,599-
13,765.

The Duenna relates the history of her amours, and draws a picture of the follies of women.

Cap.
LXXIII.
F. 13,766-
14,444.

She relates the stories of Dido and Æneas, Phillis and Demophoon, Paris and CEnone, and Jason and Medea, and then proceeds to disclose the wiles used by some women to entrap men, and describes the various adventitious aids for waning beauty. Incidentally occurs here the mode in which a lady should comport herself at table, of which Chaucer has made such effective use in his description of the Prioress. The picture drawn by the author of a certain phase of mediæval life is vivid indeed. He censures the folly of husbands who watch their wives too narrowly.

Cap.
LXXIV.
F. 14,445-
14,542.

This is illustrated by a humorous version of the story of Vulcan, Mars, and Venus. The Duenna then proceeds to give her views on the relations between men and women as ordained by Nature, but interfered with by human laws and regulations.

Cap.
LXXV.
F. 14,543-
15,307.

Examples are adduced of the teachings of Nature alike to birds in the woods, fish in the river, and all other creatures unsubdued by man.

Though they may be constrained and confined for a time, they will, if they get the chance, take up their freedom of action. It is equally futile to keep watch over the freedom of women. The worthy dame relates her own infatuation with a lover who treated her most cruelly. She ends by recommending Fair-Welcome to profit by the experience her tale affords. He asks her whether she cannot now admit the Lover without Jealousy being aware thereof. She replies that she can conceal him in such a manner that it would be easier to find an ant's egg in a truss of straw than for Jealousy to discover him. She consents to admit the Lover, who promises her many a fair gift for her complaisance.

THE ROMANCE OF THE ROSE

XLIII

Herein is told how Reason left
The 'wildered Lover all bereft
Of comfort, but straightway a Friend,
He finds, whose words his woes amend. 7610

WHEN Reason heard my words she went **Reason**
Her ways and left me worn and spent **departs**
With grief, till of my friend I thought,
And, pain and trouble scorning, sought
To find him, but, by God's hand led,
He came, beheld my woe, and said:

The Friend.

Fair friend, I pray you say amain
What misery doth your soul enchain;
For all too plainly writ, your pale
And careworn visage tells a tale 7620
Of new-born grief. Say then, what news?

The Lover.

God help me! gloom my soul bedews.

The Friend.

A friend's Speak on.
advice

The Lover.

And straightway every word
I told him, as you erst have heard ;
It needs not to retread that sod.

The Friend.

Exclaimed he : By the Body of God !
Rude Danger you have clean dismissed,
And the sweet Rosebud safely kissed,
And now Fair-Welcome's prisonment
A dagger through your heart hath sent !
If he account him yours so far
As win for you in love's sweet war
A kiss, no gaol will hold his feet.
Unless you have desire to cheat
Yourself of good success, let cheer
Wake in your face, and cast forth fear ;
Fair-Welcome will, for your dear sake,
Whate'er it cost, the dungeon break,
Wherein for love of you he lies.

7630

The Lover.

Alas ! his cruel enemies
Are strong ; but saving Evil-Tongue,
Who vile suspicion raised among
His minions, none had noticed me
Approach the longed-for Rosebud tree.
Had not that villain raised alarm,
Believe I well that little harm

7640

From Shame and Fear had I received,
 And e'en o'er Danger had achieved
 A triumph and been safe. All three
 Past doubt had left me tranquilly;
 Had not those reptiles raised their heads
 From slumbering on their drowsy beds,
 Whom this base wretch to help him called,
 When he beheld Fair-Welcome palled
 With fear, as Jealousy cried out
 (The old crone makes a fearful rout)
 That she was overcome with dread :
 I stayed me not, but thenceward fled
 In haste.

How to
 free Fair-
 Welcome

7650

Forthwith was raised a tower,
 Where lies Fair-Welcome 'neath their power
 A prisoner. Friend, to thee I fly
 For aid : O help me ere I die.

7661

Then spake the friend, and sagely gave
 Advice, with kindly voice and suave :

The Friend.

Dear friend, give not yourself to grief,
 But let sweet love be still your chief
 Delight, and let the God of Love
 Your loyal service have, above
 All else both night and day ; be free
 And frank with him whate'er may be ;
 For perjured word or thought unkind
 From you would well-nigh wreck his mind,
 Since he your homage hath received ;
 Truth's self is he, and ne'er deceived

7670

4 THE ROMANCE OF THE ROSE

Follow Love's behests A loyal heart. I counsel you
Truly and faithfully to do
All his commandments ; for the wight
Who in his service finds delight
Shall ne'er repent him, though distress
Be his through Fortune's fickleness.

7680

And would you serve him as you ought,
Then must unendingly your thought
Be given to him, and folly great
Were yours if you should prove ingrate.

Moreover, Love your heart doth hold
In leash, and you were overbold
Should you forsake him.

Lend quick ear

To friendly counselling ; forbear,
At least some little while, to go
Anigh the tower, and let none know
Your presence, or by sight or sound,
If you should dare to tread that ground,
Before the storm has died away
Which round your head of late made play.
Have special care you are not seen,
More often than you erst have been,
Beneath the walls or near the gate ;
And if you are by chance or fate
Led thither, let no creature wot
You heed one bit Fair-Welcome's lot.
But should you spy him from afar,
At crenelet or window bar,
Regard his form with eye discreet,
Though your heart die his glance to meet.

7690

7700

And if he see you, great delight
 He'll feel, yet all precautions dight,
 Nor, save in secret, dare to make
 A finger signal, or to shake
 His head; and should he see you speak
 To those about, at once he'll seek
 To close the shutter and espy
 Your form both long and lovingly
 Athwart the chinks, unless from thence
 He's torn by brutal violence.

Deceivers
 must be
 deceived

7710

Have special care that near the spot
 Vile Evil-Tongue perceive you not;
 Salute him, if you chance to meet,
 Politely, but in nowise greet
 His glance with anger or despite—
 With such an one 'twere ill to fight.
 A wise man ne'er displays his wrath,
 But hides it 'neath his vest's broad-cloth,
 For fair and good it is a cheat
 With tools he fashions to entreat,
 And every liege of Love should do
 Thuswise, who hath the wit thereto.

7720

To Evil-Tongue and all his race
 'Tis well to show a pleasant face,
 Although they'd turn you inside out,
 Offer (so sweetly that no doubt
 His mind can have) your body and soul
 To serve him.

7730

If you first the goal
 Would reach, in racing with a sharp,
 Sing him a tune that suits his harp.

6 | THE ROMANCE OF THE ROSE

Evil-Tongue To trap a rascal is no sin,
deserves And well one does to snare him in
hanging His proper net.

A caitiff-wretch
 Is Evil-Tongue ; although you stretch
 Him till in half he falls, there still
 A wretch remains, that style ne'er will 7740
 Be lost to him. No other name
 Ought he to bear, for nought of shame
 Hath he men's good repute to steal,
 Causing deep wounds no balm can heal.
 Better were he on gibbet strung
 Than half the wretched creatures hung
 For filching dirty pence. The thieves
 Who steal a farmer's golden sheaves,
 Or rob a clothes-line, being ta'en
 Red hand, the law makes pay again 7750
 Four times the worth. But Evil-Tongue
 So spreads his injuries among
 All people, that, the harm once done,
 A good name cannot back be won
 From him to salve the wound, or stay
 The poisonous flood for many a day.

One needs this miscreant to appease,
 As men must sometimes, on their knees,
 Touch with their lips a hand that well
 Deserves the cleansing fires of hell. 7760
 Wherefore should not the wretch be sent
 To Tarsus, where he might invent
 Lies that no lovers need to fear ?
 'Twere well from off the earth to clear
 So vile a scoundrel.

Evil-Tongue

And all his cursèd crew are sprung
 From Satan, and of Heaven despised,
 Therefore are men right well advised
 By every guile to cheat the cheat,
 His cozenage and lies to beat
 With greater lies, and e'en caress
 And trick the knave with treacherousness,
 Fooling the fellow to his bent
 With fulsome praise and compliment,
 Silencing thus the yelping hound
 Till fair and clear the road be found.

Jealousy
 to be
 flattered

7770

Before all else your care should be
 To lull to false security
 This slanderer, by persuading him
 That you are reft of power to nimme
 Or steal the Rose he lives to guard;
 That done, the pathway lies unbarred.

7780

Treat in likewise the hag on watch
 (God grant hell's fiend her soul may catch),
 And flatter also Jealousy
 (May she of God accursèd be),
 To still her rancorous, spiteful heart,
 That joy of others makes to smart
 With sour disdain, such venomèd spleen
 And greed within her rage, I ween;
 For sure it is, though many taste
 Of happiness, it nought need waste.
 It is as though a lantern's light
 One grudged to other men anight;

7790

8 THE ROMANCE OF THE ROSE

Gaolers Though thousands light thereat, no less
must be The holder sees its radiantness.
bribed The simile is plain enough
 For all but minds ill-bred and rough.

But should these villain folk demand
 Some service, lend a ready hand 7800
 Thereto, for gentle courtesy
 Is soothing, yet let men not see
 That you but make-believe the while,
 With after purpose to beguile
 Their watchfulness ; pursue this rule,
 And many a foe may you befool.

Whoso would see his foeman drowned
 Or hanged should lovingly around
 His neck embrace him, if he nought
 Can otherwise be lightly brought 7810
 Beneath his will ; but wherefore thus
 Explain a thing so obvious ?
 These foes so subtle are and keen,
 That open war would simply mean
 Your good cause lost.

Then next, with care,
 For other gaolers gifts prepare,
 If you can reach them ; seek to learn
 What bribes will best their kindness earn :
 A hat, or wicker bandelet,
 With gay fresh-gathered flowers beset, 7820
 A brodered purse, a simple veil,
 Some pretty trinkets, which, if frail
 And little worth, are ne'ertheless
 Of dainty taste and comeliness,

Prudence
in gifts

For e'en though presents be despised,
No lover who is well advised
Will bring down ruin on his head
By gifts inordinate, but, led
By prudence, know how so to give,
That hate may die and goodwill live. 7830
And then lament you that love's pain
You fear is labour spent in vain.
And if your slender purse affords
Sparse gifts, let plenteous honied words
And promises their place supply,
And dream of payment—by-and-by ;
But swear with such effrontery,
That none can doubt you'll faithful be.
Humbly demand their kindly aid ;
And even while your suit is made, 7840
Adown your cheeks let streamlets flow,
Therefrom great benefit will grow
To your design. Weep—would you please
These gaolers—on your bended knees,
Hands clasped together, eyelids wet
With tears enough to wear and fret
Your face with seams, which, seeing fall
So freely, must their hearts recall
To pity.

But if nought to weep
Your eyes incline, 'tis well to steep 7850
The lids with moisture from the tongue ;
Or surer still, they may be stung
With garlic or fresh onion juice ;
Effectively will that unloose
Of scalding tears a plenteous rain,
As grief might do, or poignant pain.

Tears Thuswise have lovers often done,
some- And thereby many a conflict won
times Beneath Love's banner, knowing well
useful O'er women's hearts to cast a spell
 In suchwise, that they tenderly
 Loosen the bonds they hold them by.

7860

But many a caitiff wretch hath shown
 Moist eyes whose heart hath never known
 True love, and damsels oft have fared
 But ill, by treacherous weeping snared.

E'en gaolers' hearts may sometimes be
 Softened by tears, unless they see
 They are but false, for they'll resent
 It rudely if a trick they scent ;
 Then may you vainly beg and pray,
 Fast closed you'll find each entry way.
 But if you fail to come to speech
 Through those who watch, you yet may reach
 Your object through a trusty friend,
 Or otherwise effect your end
 By means of an impassioned letter,
 But doing so 'tis vastly better
 To set thereon a feignèd name,
 Call her, Fair sir, or him, Sweet dame,
 With hope more fully to conceal
 The secrets hid beneath the seal.
 For many a rascal thief hath read
 A lover's letters, and ill sped
 The plot thereby, all labour lost
 And hopes and aspirations crossed.

7870

7880

THE ROMANCE OF THE ROSE 11

Employ not children, great the chance
 Will be they fail through ignorance,
 And sorry messengers they make
 Through trifling, idling, or mistake.
 They oft miscarry, or will show
 Your missive wheresoe'er they go,
 And bungle, not through lack of sense
 Alone, but inexperience.
 You must with great discretion choose
 Your messengers, unless you'd lose
 The fruit of all your pains, and see
 Your intrigue common property.

Children
 had
 messen-
 gers

7890

These gaolers you will surely find
 Of heart so piteous, sweet and kind,
 That, once your money they have ta'en,
 Your faithful friends will they remain.
 E'en as the sparrow-hawk is sure
 To flutter to the well-known lure
 At morn, or eve, or any hour,
 So surely gifts possess the power
 The surliest gaolers to appease
 So far, that freely as they please
 May lovers use them ; once made tame
 With vails, their service they may claim.

7900

7910

But should they hold their heads so high
 That they regard disdainfully
 Your sighs and tears, your gifts and prayers,
 Seeing through all your best-laid snares,
 And treat your courtesy with lewd
 Unseemly acts and voicing rude,

Devices Answer their scoffs with courtesy,
should be And leave them in their fat to fry.
varied Believe me, never autumn cheese
 Was made more speedily than these 7920
 Good folk will bite their nails. Right soon
 They'll come to seek some gift or boon,
 And merrily your plot will go ;
 You'll gather, though you cease to sow.

Rude churlish hearts are often filled
 With arrogance, and though one spilled
 Buckets of tears thereon, the more
 Their gentle kindness you implore,
 The harder will they grow ; but leave
 Them all alone, nor seem to grieve 7930
 One jot, and suddenly their pride
 And insolence is cast aside,
 For nought doth more such hearts impress,
 Than proud and studied scornfulness.

The mariner who steers his bark
 Through unknown seas, when night falls dark
 Regardeth not one only star
 To guide his course, nor would he far
 Entrust his ship with one poor sail,
 But try what others might avail 7940
 'Mid storm and tempest. Even so
 He that with Love would hunting go
 Must follow, not a single track,
 But now pursue, and now fall back,
 If Love's full joyance he would taste.
 I warrant me I need not waste

My time in glossing this, past doubt
Or question doth the sense stand out.

Words
cost little

'Twere well these gaolers then to ply
With prayers ; he little risks thereby 7950

Who spends his words, e'en though they be
Cast back with scorn and contumely ;
And if they're crowned with good success,
They pave the path to happiness.

One of two things 'tis plain must hap,
Either success one's prayers will cap,
Or of their object must they fail ;

And if 'tis so, small cause to wail
A lover hath, for all the cost

Is but that he his time hath lost. 7960

Nor need one fear lest he hath made
The gaolers wroth because he prayed
Their kindness ; that will rather please

Their dignity when they at ease
Shall muse thereon. Rude boors aye feel

Strange satisfaction when appeal

Is made to them ; within themselves

They think what most important elves

They needs must be—how grand ! how
great !

That thus are folk importunate 7970

For their goodwill.

They must refuse,

Or grant your prayer, or make excuse.

If all goes well, you then succeed ;

If ill, why then you do but need

Comfort to take, and try again.

If, failing, you conceal your pain,

14 THE ROMANCE OF THE ROSE

Affect
indiffer-
ence

By far the better chance have you
 Later to press your suit anew.
 But look you, be not so unwise
 By any means to ope the eyes 7980
 Of those you bribe to your intent
 Of gaining, through their means, your bent.
 To win the Rosebud make it seem
 That love platonic is your dream,
 For rest assured, beyond all doubt,
 That were your purpose once found out,
 Your chance were lost ; but if with skill
 Your snare be laid, at last it will
 Debauch their hearts, and you will see
 They're traitors all. If cleverly 7990
 You treat them, then you need not fear
 But what they'll lend a willing ear
 To your entreaties. But I yet
 Give counsel that you never let
 Your prayers be made too freely if
 They seem immovable and stiff ;
 For if they yield not, then they cry
 Aloud to vaunt their probity.
 But if as traitors they behave,
 They're mum, and silent as the grave. 8000

These gaoler folk are all alike :
 Although unbending as a pike
 They show themselves, if no advance
 You make towards them, likely chance
 It is you'll find they may be bought
 (Offering themselves) for next to nought.
 But sometimes dolts with gifts and praise
 Ill timed, the pride of gaolers raise

In suchwise that, their avarice
Excited, they exalt the price
Of Roses.

Use gold
sparingly

These rich dullards dream
To gain advantage, but extreme
Of damage do themselves. Much gold
They pay for that which else were sold
At vilest price. 'Twere much the best
If each awhile forbore request
To such-like scum, right cheaply then
Were bought and sold these gaoler men.
If only suitors would arrange

Among themselves that no exchange
Of gifts go on or prayers be made
To watch-dogs, then ere long were
stayed

Traffic in roses, which must die
If none were found to bribe or buy.
Assuredly I love not well
Men who abase themselves to sell
Their faith for filthy lucre, and
Not willingly would set my hand
To such-like business. Yet delay
Must you avoid, and smooth the way
Through them for that you're bent to do,
Setting the nets to win for you
The game you follow.

Should you stay,
Rivals may gather day by day,
Not one or two, but many a score,
Aye, and perchance some hundreds more
In two-and-fifty weeks, till last
You'll find your chances spent and past.

Heed not An honourable man doth ne'er
 scorn A woman leave to crave a share 8040
 In his affections ; doth he wait
 For that, his self-esteem's too great.
 But whosoe'er would fain attack
 A damsel's heart, although no lack
 He finds at first of haughty scorn
 (Which needs must patiently be borne),
 If only he will wisely steer
 His bark, the rocks and sands he'll clear
 At last.

From this advice a page
 You well may take if you engage 8050
 With watch-dogs ; but attempt them not
 If they ill-humoured be or hot
 With anger.

When they're light of heart
 Approach them, but if they should smart
 'Neath grievance, keep away, unless
 You choose to brave the bitterness
 They feel if Jealousy perchance
 Mistreat them to despite your chance.

But if you with consummate art
 Can get these tiresome folk apart, 8060
 Safe from intrusion of all men,
 Fair-Welcome might break prison then,
 Where he, in suffering drear, for you,
 Lies now, close kept as hawk in mew,
 And aid you with Fair-Seeming's power,
 As well he knows to do ; your hour
 Will then be ripe to pluck the Rose.

And if rude Danger should oppose

Your deed, and Shame and Fear should
wake

And feign defence—though all aquake 8070

With will, while struggling, to give way,
Then will you understand their play.

If tremulous Fear turn deadly pale,

Shame flush bright red, while 'neath him fail

Rude Danger's knees, and all the three

Shriek and lament them woefully,

Care not for them an empty shuck,

But grasp the Rose and thank your luck,

Showing yourself a man of nerve

When place and good occasion serve, 8080

For nothing gives them more delight

Than to be vanquished in a fight

By major force.

At different times

Their moods will vary e'en as climes

And seasons change; if you appealed

Their will, they ne'er would dare to yield

That which they love to give by force,

But feign their joy to be the source

Of bitterest grief, although they sighed

And longed for that which lips denied. 8090

It is, forsooth, their full intent

To gain the end they most resent;

And disappointment were intense,

To say the truth, if their defence

Succeeded, and all unappeased

Would be their wrath, while wondrous

pleased

They vaunted them of their escape.

But if resistance take the shape

Reluct-
ance
often
feigned

Neglect Of unfeigned hate, and they defend
not The castle vigorously, then lend
sympathy An ear to Prudence and give in,
 With hope that later you may win
 The fort ; crave pardon and await
 Till those three spies that militate
 Against you disappear, and leave
 Fair-Welcome with you, free to weave
 New plans and schemes.

8100

A cheery face

Should you assume, endued with grace
 And grave demeanour.

Heed the while

Fair-Welcome ; if he seem to smile,
 Smile too ; or if you note his mien
 For solemn, then be solemn seen
 Likewise ; if he a guileless air
 Affect, your countenance should wear
 The same sweet innocence—each way
 Or mood he shows throughout the day
 'Tis yours to counterfeit ; if bright
 His visage be, show then a light
 And merry heart ; if he be sad,
 Then look as though some grievance
 had

8110

8120

Fast hold on you ; let that thing fire
 Your heart whereto he hath desire ;
 And if some other thing he blame,
 Declare abhorrence of the same
 With vigour ; or if he should praise
 Or this or that, cease not to raise
 Your voice in laud thereof. Thus do,
 And throughly will he trust in you.

Praise of
reticence

Think you a gracious dame forsooth
Cares for a hare-brained, half-fledged youth 8130

Who, like an idiot, half the night

Singeth the pleasure and delight

He hath, through her kind grace,
enjoyed,

And how her love for him destroyed

Her peace? With reason might she
dread

'Twould bring down scandal on her
head:

Love passages are quickly known

When all around the streets they're
thrown

In balladings unheedingly,

Who such man loves, a fool is she.

8140

Whene'er a wise man takes a fool

For mistress, 'tis a golden rule

Folly alone to talk with her:

As well might he on empty air

Expend wise words and rarest wit,

They nought will profit him one bit.

Whoso would win a woman's love

Should ne'er converse with her above

Her small intelligence, for she

Will straightway deem her man to be

8150

A fox, a cozener, or a cheat;

And deeming kindest words deceit,

Will leave his loving care and go

To seek some other, and right low

Perchance may fall—from out the heap

She's bound to pick some scabious sheep.

Courtesy She'll brood fierce passion in her breast,
indis- E'en as a wild she-wolf possessed
pensable By madness, who with rage accurst
 From all he-wolves picks out the worst. 8160

 And if Fair-Welcome comes your
 way,
 And you with him at chess should
 play,
 Or dice, or tables, or what not,
 Let him aye find that he hath got
 Advantage of you ; when you lose,
 Laugh heartily, and ne'er refuse
 To play again, thereat will he
 Rejoice him most contentedly.
 Praise his behaviour, manners, dress,
 His manly port and nobleness ; 8170
 And let his comfort be your care,
 Offering a settle, stool, or chair.
 Saith Ovid : If a speck of dust
 You see fall on your love you must
 Remove it, though 'twere next to naught.
 So, if his costly cloak hath caught
 The ground, uplift it.

 Do forsooth
 Whate'er may please the gentle youth.
 And if but carefully you move
 By my instructions, you shall prove 8180
 Them fire-tried gold, and ne'er be left
 In evil case, of love bereft,
 But be fulfilled of that desire
 Towards which your heart and soul
 aspire.

XLIV

Herein the Lover tells how he
 Misdoubts his triple enemy,
 But hopeth still beneath the brand
 To bring them of stern Justice' hand.

The Lover.

DEEM you, fair friend, I've changed my wit? The
Lover's
indigna-
tion
 No man, save some base hypocrite,
 8190
 Would do such loathsome work; shall I
 Put hand to such-like devilry?
 Think you I'd strain and bend each nerve
 These villain folk to please and serve?
 Except Fair-Welcome, slaves forsooth
 Are they, to honour lost and truth.
 Do you this fatal counsel give,
 Which following, I should basely live
 A scoundrel? Whensoever across
 Such folk I come I boldly toss
 8200
 My gauntlet at them.

Suffer first

That I this Evil-Tongue accurst
 Defy, ere cozenage or deceit
 I use, his schemes to overwit,
 Demanding boldly he abate
 The storm that he hath raised of hate
 And slander, or by heaven shall he
 Suffer assault and battery.
 Or if he love not that I take
 Vengeance, he then amends must make; 8210
 Or lastly, if he will, a judge
 Shall hear my plaint, and salve my grudge.

The Friend.

**Trick-
sters
must be
tricked** Fair friend ! fair friend ! right good were this
 Against an open foe, ywis,
 But Evil-Tongue is too occult
 And sly for war, and poor result
 You'd have with him ; whene'er some carl
 Or dame he'd injure, with a snarl
 Behind their backs he speaks. His base
 And traitorous head may God disgrace ! 8220
 Most poisonous is he when most fair
 He shows, and in his heart doth bear
 Cruel deception hid beneath
 The smile that's born of lips and teeth,
 Not of the heart. Ne'er for a friend
 A traitor takes me, nor expend
 I love on him ; and if perchance
 His treachery fall to Treason's lance,
 For lack of time and means whereby
 To venge oneself more honourably, 8230
 'Tis his desert, and small regret
 Were mine whatever fate he met.
 If you 'gainst Evil-Tongue should plead,
 Dream you by such means you'd succeed
 To stay his prattling lies ?
 You'd find,
 Alas ! you could in no wise bind
 The slanderous wretch. Although you brought
 A hundred witnesses, they nought
 Could stay his cackle ; more thy proof,
 The more he'd talk, and less behoof 8240
 You'd gain therefor. More widely known
 Would be the slander, though 'twere shown

All false. For whosoe'er doth try
 To wipe out shame, or kill a lie
 By Justice' help, will find no jot
 Hath he decreased foul Slander's blot.
 The man who hath an ill deed done,
 I swear, 'fore God, is not the one
 To purge it. To anticipate
 Amends from one who's reprobate
 Were fond and foolish. E'en should he
 Offer amends, 'twould wiser be
 To grant free pardon.

Vain to
 contra-
 dict lies

8250

If so rash
 You were as join with him in clash
 Of arms, by all the saints, I vow,
 You'd shortly see Fair-Welcome bow
 'Neath heavy manacles, and swung
 Over a furnace, or else flung
 Within a swirling tide and drowned,
 Or in a dungeon's depths profound
 Buried from sight for evermore :
 Then were your heart more sick and sore
 Than Charlemagne's when Roland died
 At Roncesvalles through the pride
 And treachery of Genelon,
 Whom Satan had set seal upon.

8260

The Lover.

Nay, nay, thereto I've no desire,
 I wish the knave may feed hell-fire !
 Good Lord ! my wrath grows hot as
 pepper,
 How gladly would I hang the leper !

8270.

The Friend.

Another path Fair friend, 'twere well to curb your haste.
 Instead of hanging, you may taste
 A deeper vengeance; not for you
 Is it the hangman's work to do.
 A traitor foul 'tis fair to cheat
 With treason—hear me, I entreat.

The Lover.

Kind friend, in you will I confide
 Alone, nor turn my heart aside.
 And if you will but point the way
 Of most effect by which to lay
 Siege to the castle, gladly hear
 Will I, whilst you the plan make clear. 8280

The Friend.

I know a pleasant path and sure,
 Though somewhat dangerous to poor
 And needy men. To take the fort
 There is a plan both safe and short
 (Though in it hath no lot or part
 My doctrine, that revolts your heart)
 By which you may the walls displace,
 Shaking each stone from tower to base, 8290
 While gates and doors will open fly,
 Swung on their hinges suddenly.
 All those who guard it would allow
 Themselves beneath your yoke to bow
 As prisoners, while no single word
 Were spoken, nor a finger stirred.

The plan that hath this magic touch
 Mad-Largess thought of, and Give-Much
 It hight, but many a man, I ween,
 In following it hath ruined been.
 I know the route right well, for I
 But two days since returned thereby :
 In summer's heat and winter's rage,
 Thither I've made my pilgrimage.

The path
 of riches

8300

Leave Largess on the right, and turn
 Off to the left, beside a burn;
 So far as carrieth a cross-bow,
 Follow the beaten path and go
 Straight on, the road you scarce can lose,
 And ere you much have worn your shoes,
 You'll see the towers and turrets shiver,
 As aspens in a wind-flaw quiver,
 And every portal open fly,
 While guards fall dead all suddenly :
 Nor are these walls more hard to break
 Than 'tis a well-baked Christmas cake
 To cut in equal parts of four,
 While fewer soldiers for the stour
 You'll need than erst great Charlemagne
 Led forth to conquer wide Almaine.

8320

Along this path, which well I know,
 No needy man hath power to go.
 Alone, he can in nowise fare,
 Nor other poor man lead him there.
 But if perchance he find a guide
 Who hath himself aforetime tried

Riches The route, he soon shall know it well
 and As I do, who in youth-tide fell
 poverty Therein. And you shall likewise learn
 Its ways, if you have lust to turn 8330
 Your footsteps thither, seen that you
 Command such wealth as may pursue
 Unbounded Largess, but to me
 That path is barred by Poverty.
 My patrimony I dispersed;
 And now, in heavy debt immersed,
 Without one penny to restore
 To creditors I filched of yore,
 I best had hang or drown myself.
 Quoth she: If you are bare of pelf, 8340
 Hither return no more.

Richesse

Alone can gain for you ingress,
 But from her guidance, as I trow,
 Much ill and little good doth grow;
 In going will she use much care
 To please you, but her pains will spare
 To help you back, and if your way
 You make therein, through night and day
 You there must bide, until you be
 Thrust thence by stern-hand Poverty, 8350
 Who oft on lovers brings distress.
 Within remaineth Mad-Largess,
 Who hath no thought except of play
 And riot through the livelong day,
 And scattereth coin around as she
 Possessed thereof a granary.
 No count she keepeth, doubting never
 But what her wealth will dure for ever.

XLV

How Poverty doth make her plea
 To Dame Richesse most ruefully, 8860
 Who listeth not her piteous word,
 But turns away as nought she heard.

ALAS! drear Poverty must be
 The shamefaced spouse of Misery;
 Her heart with sore affliction bruised,
 Her eyes with scalding tears suffused,
 While answering her sad plaint is heard
 No sweet response, no pitying word,
 To heal the wounds that tear her heart.
 Her wretched fate it is to smart 8870
 With blame for every worthy deed,
 How great soe'er her grief and need.
 O ne'er consort with Poverty,
 For nothing than her grip can be
 More direful, as those find who get
 Entangled in the coils of debt,
 Through scattering wide in youthful days
 Their substance, for old age oft pays
 A heavy score, and many have stood
 Therethrough beneath the gallows' wood. 8880
 What pains untold those wretches know
 Who driven by Poverty must go
 Hither and thither to obtain
 The little ease whereof they're fain!
 The lover nowise should forget
 That Poverty doth sorely let
 And hinder love, as Ovid saith:
 With poor men love scant pastureth.

The
 miseries
 of poverty

A spend-
thrift
pictured

Poverty weds a man to hate,
Maddens and makes him desperate,
Until well-nigh he's reft of sense.
Alas! fair friend, experience
Hath taught me this; too well have I
Tried it and found its misery
In proper person: I have known
What 'tis neath Poverty to groan,
And therefore can set forth to you,
As scarce another man could do,
The vengeance it hath in store;
Therefrom, God guard you evermore!
Fair friend, that you may suffer ne'er
The woes it hath been mine to bear,
List well the fair advice I give,
And, warned by my example, live
A joyous life.

8890

8400

In days long past,
Among a merry crew was cast
My lot, and I the foremost shone
(As he who ne'er would be out-done)
Among a hundred, whilst that I
Scattered my substance recklessly,
As, all unheeded, sped along
Sweet amorous days, 'mid wine and song,
Esteemed of lordly wealth by all:
Alack! from wealth to need, my fall
Was lightly wrought by Mad-Largess,
Whose hand hath plunged me in distress
To that degree that meat and drink
I oft-times lack, and tread the brink
Of dire starvation. Weed and shoes!
Alas! my needs their state excuse;

8410

8420

And worst of all, my friends are gone,
 Grim Poverty hath spared not one.
 Ah yes! dear friend, when Fortune spent
 Her spite on me, my friends all went,
 Nay, all went not, one still remained,
 Whereof my woe-worn heart was fained.

Friends
 flee
 poverty

When Fortune chose my goods to take,
 Poverty followed in her wake :
 I lie—nought Fortune took from me,
 All that she took most certainly 8480
 Was hers ; for had those friends been mine,
 I had not seen them all decline
 Acquaintance when she left ; thus she
 In nowise acted wrongfully,
 For hers were they, and, like a fool,
 I thought I'd bought them, and could rule
 Their hearts as they were mine. Alas !
 All suddenly beheld I pass
 Those worthy friends, whene'er they found
 That of my coin, bright, smooth, and round, 8440
 No piece remained. Each well-known face
 Departed with a wry grimace
 Soon as a-top of Fortune's wheel
 My head they saw not, but my heel.
 An ingrate were I should I scold
 Her who hath shown me good untold
 And undeserved.

She now, forsooth,
 With tender care and loving ruth
 Hath on mine eyes bestowed a calm
 And perfect vision ; gentle balm 8450
 Hath she prepared to salve my sight
 And if some twenty friends took flight

A faithful friend When Poverty arrived, I now,
 Unless I lie, can see, I trow,
 Four hundred and a half. Ne'er lynx
 (Whose piercing eyesight never blinks)
 Could see more clear. In my disgrace
 Kind Fortune hath revealed the face
 Of perfect love in one dear friend
 Through Poverty. I ne'er had kenned 8460
 His sweet and gentle tenderness
 Had he not spied my deep distress;
 But forthwith busy haste he made
 To bring me kindly help and aid,
 And proffered without hope of gain
 His all, my woe-worn heart to fain.

XLVI

The Friend the Lover doth remind
 That one man only did he find
 Faithful in poverty, but he
 Gave all he had, unstintingly. 8470

I COME, dear friend, quoth he, to make
 An offering free, for friendship's sake,
 Alike of life and goods, fear not
 To share with me in common lot.
 How much then? Nay, no part, but all,
 If for the whole your need doth call.

Of Fortune's gifts, the entire sum
 With me weighs not one worthless plum
 As 'gainst a friend, nor e'en would I
 To you those precious gifts deny 8480

Friend-
ship
unfeigned

Kind nature gave me: since the day
That first we met, not once astray
Have gone our hearts, but many a proof
Have had that, like the web with woof,
Are they conjoined in friendship true,
And proof alone assurance due
Affordeth of a friendship's worth.
If all that I possess on earth
You deigned to take, my heart would be
Grateful to you exceedingly,
So powerful are the cords that bind
Two men whose bodies hold one mind.
For I, quoth he, to heal your woe
To prison, light of heart, would go
As borrow, pawn, or hostage plight,
While all my goods were sold outright
For your behoof.

8490

But this dear friend
Permitted not his work to end
With offering, but would take no rest
Until he generously had pressed
His having on me, who, for shame,
Stood silently, as one who'd blame
Himself, yet dares not ope his lips
To tell the wretchedness that grips
His inmost heart, but tries to hide
The poverty that like a tide
O'erwhelms him, and with cheerful face
Would fain conceal his dire disgrace.

8500

Far different is the case, I doubt,
With monkish mendicants, those stout

8510

Of And thriving blades, the begging friars,
 begging Who show themselves as rough as briars
 friars In open street, but love to win,
 With oily tongues, their way within
 The goodmen's houses whom they cheat
 With lying words, while drink and meat
 They batten on; and though they sing
 Their poverty, they're gathering
 Fat livelihood, and many a heap
 Of deniers have they dolven deep
 Beneath the earth.

8520

Much more could I
 Relate of this fraternity,
 But thereby should from bad to worse
 Be thrust, and fear their spiteful curse,
 For none these hypocrites, forsooth,
 So hate as those who speak the truth.

Alas then! I must count me mad
 That such blind confidence I had
 In treacherous friends, from whom I got
 No help, but all alone to rot
 Was left, rejected and despised
 Of all the crowd which erst had prized
 My friendship mightily. Alone
 You stood my friend when all were gone,
 Your heart with mine fast intertwined,
 And both, please God, shall stand combined
 In constant love.

8530

But out, alas!
 One day our mortal forms must pass
 From this terrestrial life, and we
 Forego each other's company,

8540

When comes the last and dreadful day,
 And all our bodies 'neath the sway
 Of death must fall ; but even then
 Death, nought, dear friend, can snatch from
 men

Friend-
 ship
 outlasts
 death

Except their bodies and recall
 To earth their substance corporal.

Death's iron hand will seize us both
 Ere long, however much we're loth
 To meet him.

 Rarely doth Death take
 Two friends together, yet I make
 No question if I first am ta'en,
 I still shall in your heart remain
 Embalmed ; or if 'tis yours to die
 Before me, rest assured that I
 Shall keep your memory green.

8550

E'en so

The records of past ages show
 How bitterly great Theseus grieved
 When Peirithous from him was reived
 By death, and sought his friend in hell.

But Poverty is far more fell
 And cruel than grim Death : to soul
 And body both it bringeth dole,
 Without the respite of an hour,
 And urgeth men to actions dour,
 Of murder, theft, and perjury,
 And whatso other vice may be
 Wherewith man's race is pesterèd,
 While oftentimes doth Death bestead

8560

Beware Men in their woes, which, howso great
of poverty They be, his hand will dissipate. 8570
 And therefore, dear companion, now
 Remember Solomon, whose brow
 Of old bore Israel's diadem,
 And left us many an apophthegm,
 Whereof one saith : Beware, my son,
 Of poverty whilst living on
 The earth : and in another breath
 He furthereth this good word, and saith :
 Better it is, by far, to die
 Than live on earth in poverty, 8580
 Since, against those who own them poor,
 Their very brethren shut the door ;
 And of poor caitiffs speaking still,
 Whose lot it is to bear the ill
 Of indigence, he shows how they
 In woeful wise wear through their day.
 Scarce can a man's estate be worse
 Than when stark bare he finds his purse ;
 For those who on the laws have writ
 Declare the indigent unfit 8590
 To testify as witnesses ;
 And in the statute book it says,
 That poor, impoverished men must lie
 In the same bed with infamy.

Of beauty, poverty is bare ;
 But I with full assurance dare
 Affirm, that if good store of gold,
 And jewels rich, your coffers hold,
 Then may you have fair hope to gain
 Such wealth of roses as may fain 8600

Presents
avail
much

Your heart : they ne'er shall be fast closed
Against you, if you're well disposed
To lavish gifts, as you have been
Profuse of promises, I ween.
It needs not to be over-rich,
But have a care you do not stitch
Your purse too closely ; give with care
Such presents as, though choice and fair,
Are small of cost and leave you still
Some coin to line your purse, for ill
You'd surely fare if you were left
Penniless ; of all wealth bereft
But little sympathy you'd find,
While many a one would mock behind
His back at him who, like a fool,
Let fond desire o'er reason rule,
Paying the favours that he got
With ruin of his life, God wot.

8610

In my esteem there's nought more sweet
Than some belovèd face to greet
With pretty presents choicely set
In dainty cloth or wicker net :
Sweet figs, or gooseberries or cherries,
Black bramble fruit, or huckleberries,
A luscious peach with velvet skin,
Or rosy, smooth-faced nectarine,
Berries of service tree or lote,
Or medlars soft with russet coat,
Dark plums or grapes with silvery bloom,
Or strawberries, which through all the room
Cast fragrance, almonds, hard of shell,
But whose sweet kernel payeth well

8620

8630

Gifts The pains to force it, or the rud
more than Rich mulberries which fair Thisbe's blood
words Distained : and if perchance you are
 Compelled to buy them, say from far
 Your pains have brought them, though they come
 From nearest market ; mingle some
 Sweet flowers with fruits, fair roses pink
 And white, and violets, and pervinke 8640
 Of sapphire hue, and other flowers
 That gladden spring and summer hours.

A dainty gift will often reach
 Rough hearts and modify rude speech.
 And if perchance some ill men know
 Concerning you, they'll be more slow
 To blurt it forth. Oft gifts have made
 Heroes of those who in the shade
 Had lain without them. Delicate meats
 And wines have often won fat seats 8650
 For prebendaries. How men live
 Matters but little if they give
 Freely, for oft a handsome gift
 Hath had the power to fill a rift
 In honesty or virtue, and
 While praise the giver gains, a band
 'Twill put on the receiver, who
 His freedom thereby sells to you,
 And soul and body puts to price,
 Drawn on thereto by avarice. 8660
 With what word shall I finish then ?
 Good gifts are loved of Gods and men.

8214/ If you but lend a willing ear
 To that I say, you need not fear

But what the God of Love will show
 You grace and favour when you go
 To seize the fort ; whatever he
 Hath promised shall accomplished be.
 For so will Love and Venus fight
 The gaolers, that in their despite
 The Rosebud you your own may call,
 Though hemmed around by rampart wall.
 But when at last you have attained
 Your end, and heart and soul are fained
 Therewith, wise prudence it demands
 To hold the prize ; for when with hands
 And brain we painfully have wrought
 To win, experience dire hath taught
 That harder 'tis to hold. He well
 May rail at Fortune's cruel spell
 Who loses her on whom was placed
 His tenderest love, although were traced
 The cause to his misdeed. No pains
 A man should spare, when once he
 gains

Hold love
 when
 won

8670

8680

A gracious woman's love, to keep
 The treasure to himself, nor cheap
 Esteem God's gift, more specially
 If virtuous, wise, and fair she be,
 Yet lays no scheme or plot from whence
 Guerdon to seek or recompense,
 For ne'er was love yet put to price,
 Except by those in whom foul vice
 Had made its wonting. Ne'er in dames
 Who sell them have the gentle flames
 Of true love burned ; keep thou away
 From such—foul-fire doth in them play.

8690

Women But mostly women are, forsooth,
are Exacting, void of pitying ruth,
coquets 'Fore all, alas! towards those who
 prove

Loyal and faithful in their love, 8700

Ready to raven and devour

Whate'er may fall within their power.

And Juvenal hath said, I ween,

Speaking of one hight Iberine,

That sooner would she lose an eye

Than trust one man to satisfy

Her burning lusts, for like hell-fire

Raged her insatiable desire.

No woman, saith he, e'er was known

Who loved a man for love alone 8710

In suchwise that her heart were not

Mindful what goods or gold he'd got.

Judge what she is then who herself

Body and soul will sell for pelf.

Never, he saith, was woman found,

Who did not love to prove and sound

Her lover's faith by coquetry;

Although to him she subject be,

This passion is ingrained. Such is

Juvenal's sentence, but to this 8720

Exceptions bright there are, I trow,

As he, I doubt not, would allow,

While censuring women void of grace.

Yet, if the mistress that hath place

Within your soul be soft and sweet,

Faithful and gentle, then 'twere meet

True love to give for love. The kind

And courteous lover looks to find

Not beauty only in the form
 Of her towards whom his heart-strings warm, 8720
 But will those virtues rather prize
 Which live when outward beauty dies ;
 A mind enlightened with fair store
 Of art and science, and the lore
 That housewives need ; for those who know
 The worth of wit will count the show
 Of outward beauty for a thing
 Unstable, frail, and perishing
 As flowerets that bedeck the lawn,
 Faded at eve, though blown at dawn. 8740
 Fairer a woman's face, alas !
 More quickly doth her beauty pass.
 But fine intelligence and wit
 Maketh a woman helpmeet fit
 For man in suchwise, that life's end
 Will find her still the cherished friend
 Of him who loved her youth. A spouse
 Courteous and gentle should arouse
 A woman's tender love, and she,
 Mingling goodwill with courtesy, 8750
 Will see her love returned.

Mind
 more than
 beauty

If one
 Should ask if much I set upon
 The power or worth of canzonettes,
 Ballads, and songs, and rhymed motets,
 A mistress' heart to captivate,
 I needs must say, dear friend, that prate
 Is much less worth than gifts, but yet
 Such things some grateful praise beget.
 More lightly women's hearts are thrilled
 To see a good-sized purse well filled 8760

The golden age With golden chinking bezants, then
 They'll run with open arms towards men,
 For they—for better or for worse—
 Most dearly love a well-lined purse.
 Far different once was man's estate,
 But now the world's degenerate.

How pleasant were earth's simpler ways
 In our progenitors' first days!
 Old legends tell us how the fires
 Of love burned bright amongst our sires ; 8770
 No man called this or that his own,
 And lust and rapine nought were known.
 While 'dured that glorious golden age,
 No man could boast of seigniorage,
 No man affected robes of state,
 No man e'er craved for delicate
 Spiced meats, but simple woodland fruits,
 Beech mast, or nuts, or wholesome roots
 From out the earth all needs supplied ;
 While fish and flesh were left aside 8780
 As needless, 'mid the coverts wild
 Men sought kind Nature's store of mild
 And bloodless food ; the wilding vine
 Gave berries though they knew not wine,
 Apples and pears, and mulberries,
 Rich plums and chestnuts, beans and peas,
 And herbs and mushrooms from the field,
 While valleys, plains, and heights would yield
 Due sustenance from day to day.
 From ears of corn they rubbed away 8790
 The chaff betwixt their palms ; they sipped
 The brown bees' store which plenteous dripped

Simpli-
city of
life

From ancient oak-tree boles, they drank
 Clear water kneeling on the bank
 Of crystal streams, nor dreamed to dight
 Piment therein for appetite ;
 Nor longed for wine grown old in tun,
 With weary treading hardly won.
 The fruitful earth no need to ear
 Had they, it foisoned 'neath God's care. 8800
 Thus amply fed, they had no wish
 For salmons, pikes, or aught of fish.
 They sheepskins wore against the harm
 Of winter, or thence wove them warm
 And simple vesture, which no dye
 Of grain or herb e'er came anigh.
 Green broom or rushes roofed their cots,
 Or sheltered they in hillside grots
 Fenced in with boughs, or hollow oaks
 Gave shelter 'gainst rude winter's strokes. 8810

XLVII

This telleth how in days gone by
 Earth's children had no treasury
 Or store of goods, but everything
 Was common, free of prince or king.

AND when a-nights they sought their rest,
 No beds of down their bodies pressed,
 But scattered they fresh fragrant leaves,
 Or moss in heaps, or fresh cut sheaves
 Of grass or reeds, and heaven's sweet air
 Was ever soft and gentle there, 8820
 In one unvarying tide of spring,
 While tuneful birds made morning ring

Old-time With the sweet latin of their lay
 freedom That welcome cried to dawning day.
 Soft Zephyrus, and eke his wife,
 Dame Flora, queen of flowers, new life
 Gave to the meads where'er they went,
 And every verdant laund besprent
 With opening buds, which gladly her
 Worshipped as dame and verderer. 8880
 For these, to speed young lovers, go
 Across the teeming earth and sow
 Sweet flowers a-tint with varied hues,
 Which amorous swains and maidens use
 To twine amid their flowing hair
 In chaplets fragrant, fresh and fair,
 And 'tis for such they love to spread
 Gay counterpanes right well bestead
 With countless flowrets in such wise
 As seems, forsooth, to mock the skies, 8840
 With stars all gloriously beseen.

On couches thus bedecked I ween,
 From jealousy and envy free
 They mingled in felicity
 Secure, with soft embrace and kiss,
 'Neath sheltering boughs in heaven-like bliss.
 The branches joined above them made
 A fretted roof of cooling shade.
 And there right joyously they spent
 The jolly time in merriment 8850
 And carolling and amorous play,
 As simple men for whom the day
 Was ne'er too long, nor sad nor dull,
 For all the world was beautiful.

'Neath tyranny did no man wince,
 For not as yet had king or prince
 Claimed others having, but all shared
 Earth's gifts in common lot, and fared
 One as another ; none possessed,
 Therefore were none by lack distressed. 8860
 Though Ovid's saying nought they knew,
 Which none but fools would doubt for true :
 Never can love and seigniory
 Travel together, nor can they be
 In any case fit spouse and bride,
 High rule sets equal love aside.

**Seigniory
 kills love**

XLVIII

This notes how ill-bred men will cry
 "Out" on their wives through jealousy,
 Calling them names I scarce dare tell,
 As minx, jade, harlot, Jezebel. 8870

AND thus 'tis seen that strange conceit
 Of wisdom eggs fools on to treat
 Their spouses ill, to such degree
 That they misuse them brutally,
 Saying that too much time they spend
 In dancing, or too often wend
 In company with some young blade
 With whom they've assignation made,
 And ask them how they love expect
 From husbands if they dare reject 8880
 Their counsels, deeming they alone,
 Their wives, both body and goods, should own.
 Cries one : Your air is far too gay,
 And why this mincing mien, I pray ?

A Soon as I sally forth to work,
 husband's Away you start, with smile and smirk,
 woes Ready for some wild prank or game,
 Whereat your cheeks should burn for shame,
 Singing aloud like siren sleek—
 God curse you with an evil week.

8890

When business drags me far from home
 To Frisia's shores, or e'en to Rome,
 At once you mount coquettish dress,
 That leaves but little room to guess
 My lot, till neighbours talk thereon.
 And when they ask wherefore you don
 Such gay attire while I'm away,
 With brazen impudence you'll say
 In mocking tones: Oho! oho!
 'Tis that I love my husband so.

8900

But I, poor wretch, may mope and grieve,
 Who careth, whether I forge or weave,
 Or whether alive or dead am I?
 Then one would hit me in the eye
 With bladder reft from goat or sheep,
 And all the world but holds me cheap.
 Because to beat you I've forborne,
 Whilst nought I win from you but scorn,
 You brag! though well 'tis known you lie.
 Alack! alack! a fool was I

8910

With such a pair of gloves to cramp
 My hands—but I the bit may champ.
 Alas! a fool's cap 'twas I wore
 That day when you obedience swore
 In church, and I, poor idiot, dreamed
 You'd later prove what then you seemed.

How could it be supposed that e'er
 A bold and brazen face you'd bear
 Towards the lecherous wanton wights
 Who follow loose-lived girls o' nights? 8920
 For whom, I ask, do you prepare
 The chestnuts I'm not asked to share?
 'Twould seem indeed that you are fain
 Of me as shield against the rain,
 And pose you as a ring-dove simple
 And soft, beneath your modest wimple.
 But how about that ample cloak
 'Neath which fine gallants know to poke
 Themselves in tête-à-tête? I swear,
 Except for shame and kindness 'twere, 8920
 I'd not for bezants four of gold,
 Your trouncing, well deserved, withhold,
 But use my stick to bate your pride,
 Which sorely hath my patience tried.
 For know that vastly 'tis to me
 Displeasing that you decked should be
 To join in carol, song, or dance,
 Without my leave and countenance.

A wanton
wife

XLIX

The jealous husband scolds his wife,
 Remonstrates, blames her course of life; 8940
 And setteth forth his dire distress
 At that he calls her wantonness.

MOREOVER, nought can I conceal
 The righteous anger that I feel
 When Robichon, with head-gear green,
 Aye ready at your beck is seen.

**The wife
threat-
ened** Is there some land that he and you
Should share, and hence this fine ado?
You sit and list his fluting tales
With heads close set till daylight fails; 8950
My blood nigh boils with rage to see
You carry on so shamelessly.

I swear 'fore God, who lieth never,
That either you your friendship sever
With him, or else from forth my door
You go with face of blackamoor,
For, help me God, unless you chase
From out your heart all track and trace
Of this loose love, your features I
Will beat and batter till you cry 8960
For mercy, and agree to drop
That cackle I'm resolved to stop.
Alone, you ne'er the public way
Shall tread, but serve me night and day
At home, made sure with iron-chained hands.
Think you a woman e'er commands
Her husband's love who gads about
With dangling men, week in, week out?
And if they follow you, 'tis plain
That you encourage them amain, 8970
For they'd not dare to make pretence
Of love, but for your impudence.
The devil's prompting 'twas that made
Me marry such a wanton jade.

Ha! would I'd Theophrastus read
Ere, like a fool, I thrust my head
In wedlock's noose: No man, saith he,
Who's blest with fair sagacity

Will take a wife, or poor or rich,
 As goddess fair, or like a witch
 Bewrinkled—he hath writ the whole
 Within his book hight “Aureole,”
 Which treats of marriage: Ha! he cries,
 Man’s life is filled with miseries,
 Troubles, and ills, on every side,
 Induced by the insensate pride
 Of women, their demands and plaints
 Such trouble cause as life attaints
 With miseries manifold; alack!
 Hard task hath he who striveth back
 To call them to a decent sense
 Of modesty and reverence.

8980 **Marital
miseries**

8990

Whoso will take one indigent
 To wife, must wonder not if spent
 His substance be in gowns and shoes;
 And if a wealthy wife one choose,
 He need not marvel if disdain
 She showeth towards him, or if vain
 And proud she prove, and not a fly
 She valueth his authority,
 And further, will perhaps engage
 To vilify his lineage;
 Till he to madness will be stung,
 Through clack of her unbridled tongue.

9000

Or is she fair? At once a cloud
 Of suitors round her footsteps crowd,
 Hustle and bustle, push, dispute,
 While each one strives to press his suit,
 And find out what may please her best,
 Here anxious prayer, there love confessed,

9010

48 THE ROMANCE OF THE ROSE

Penelope They loiter round, and strange it were
and If no man conquest made of her,
Lucretia For when on every side a fort
 Is pressed, resistance is but short.

If plain she be, she'll welcome all :
 And when a tower prepares to fall,
 And those within its gates betray,
 Who shall defend it or upstay ?
 For if with all the world he fights,
 A man would scarce dare sleep o' nights, 9020
 And after all were said and done,
 By first assault the prize were won.

The best of wives who lived in Greece,
 Penelope, alas ! small peace
 Enjoyed—yet saved her fame at last.
 Lucretia, she whose name hath passed
 Into a proverb, was seduced
 Through brutal force, by Tarquin used
 Most shamefully, and then she killed
 Herself, with grief and horror filled. 9030
 Nowise, as Titus Livius saith,
 Could sire or husband save from death
 This matron chaste ; whate'er they said,
 Herself she boldly poignarded
 Before their eyes.

To calm her grief
 They spake wise words, but no relief
 She took therefrom, e'en though her spouse
 Avowed that she her marriage vows
 Had straightly kept, and nothing blamed
 Her for the deed which so had shamed 9040

Her spirit, but declared that she
Lived spotless in her chastity.

No sin
without
consent

For though the body may endure
Befoulment forced, the soul is pure,
And never sin hath body shent,
When lacked thereto the heart's consent.

But she, disdainful of her life
Through grief, snatched suddenly a knife
From out her bosom's folds, then cried
To those who, weeping, stood beside 9050
Her couch: Fair sirs, though nobly ye
Declare me innocent to be
In this foul deed which I deplore,
Lucrece forgives it not, nor more
Can lift her face to meet the shame
She suffers, though absolved from blame.

L

How fair Lucrece, through wrath she bare
At heart, her noble bosom tare
With murderous knife, and death did win
In face of husband, sire, and kin. 9060

THEN through her heart, with anguish filled,
She drove the cruel steel and spilled
Her life blood, but her friends charged first,
To venge her on her foe accurat.
From this example, through all time,
It is that whose such foul crime
Commits, is doomed the death to die.
Proud Tarquin and his family

Wives Were straightway driven forth from Rome,
chosen Dying in exile, and no home 9070
blindly Found kingship there again. Alas!
 Through all the world one now might pass,
 But no Penelope in Greece
 Discover, nor in Rome Lucrece,
 Nor such-like women elsewhere:
 Seek not—your pains ye well may spare.

In pagan days too well 'tis known
 That women many a time have thrown
 Themselves at men who sought them not,
 As many a one doth now, God wot! 9080

Those who in wedlock would engage,
 A custom have which neither sage
 Nor good I reckon, but bizarre
 And strange in each particular,
 And oft I marvel what should press
 Men on to such fond foolishness.

What man soe'er would buy a horse
 Examines him, in common course,
 With greatest pains, and carefully
 Notes each defect that meets his eye. 9090
 But women skilfully conceal
 All faults from those with whom they deal,
 And nought men know of good or ill:
 Concerning those they wed until
 The knot is tied, but that once done,
 Good Lord! such pranks 'neath heaven's high sun
 They play, as show all plain and clear
 Their inborn vice; nought then they fear,

But let the wretched dupe perceive
That nought his folly can retrieve ;
Repentance comes alas ! too late.
Nay, even though a kindly fate
Procure for him a wife both good
And gentle, in all likelihood,
Unless a fool, will he repent
His folly ere a year be spent.

Good
9100 women
are rare

A virtuous woman ! Nay, I swear
By good St. Denis, that's more rare
Than is a phoenix.

Thus hath said
Valerius : Whosoe'er will wed 9110
Or love a woman finds much pain.
And many troubles, while his gain
Is nought. More rare than phoenix ? Nay
'Twere apter simile to say
Rarer by far than snow-white crow,
How fine soe'er their bodies show.

But natheless am I free to say
(Lest that the women of to-day
Should count me neither just nor fair),
I've no intention to declare 9120
All womankind alike, but eyes
Of lynx the man need have who tries
So fair a bird on earth to find
As any one of womankind
Who's faultless—secular or nun—
Black swans are commoner 'neath the sun.
Such birds on earth are sparsely sown,
As lightly may, pardee, be known.

Juvenal's
sayings

And Juvenal supporteth this.

He saith : If e'er thy luck it is
To find an honest woman, go
Straight to the temple, fall alow
To Jupiter on bended knees,
And Goddess Juno strive to please
With sacrificial cow, whose horns
A film of precious gold adorns.
For never while thou liv'st will be
A rarer sight vouchsafed to thee.
Valerius moreover saith :

9180

(Sans shame for that he uttereth)

9140

That either at home or over-sea
Would one affect the company
Of vicious women, they are found
Plenty as bees when swarms fly round.
What deem you then shall be the fate
Of such a fool ? 'Twere desperate—
He who a branch so frail doth choose
To trust, shall soul and body lose.

Valerius, when 'twas plainly seen
That young Rufinus, who had been
His friend from youth, would bend the knee
To Hymen, cried : What's come to thee
In name of all the Gods ! dost set
Thy foot within the treacherous net
Designing women spread for men ?
And Juvenal these words wrote when
Young Postumus would take a wife :
'Twere better far to end thy life !
Doth no man now stout halters sell ?
Or can'st thou nowhere find a well

9150

9160

To drown thee in, or dizzy height **Abelard**
 From whence thou may'st take headlong flight? **and**
 Were not swift exit better far **Heloise**
 Than all thy happiness to mar
 By wedlock's chains?

Phoroneus, who
 The use of laws first taught unto
 The Greeks, when lying on his bed
 A-dying, to his brother said,
 The young Leontius: Brother dear,
 Calm were my death could I but hear 9170
 Thee promise that thou ne'er wilt take
 A wife—this vow I prithee make.
 And when Leontius sought the why,
 He spake him thuswise: Verily,
 Cruel experience all have found
 Whose feet within the snares are bound
 Of marriage, and if thou a wife
 Shouldst take—alas! woe worth thy life!

Likewise did Heloise entreat
 (The abbess of the Paraclete) 9180
 Her lover Peter Abelard,
 That he would utterly discard
 All thought of marriage from his mind.

This lady, noble and refined,
 Of genius bright and learning great,
 Loving, and loved with passionate
 Strong love, implored him not to wed,
 And many a well-wrought reason sped
 To him in letters, where she showed
 That hard and troublous is the code 9190

Heloise Of marriage, howsoever true
refused Are those who bind themselves thereto ;
marriage For not alone had she in books
 Studied, but all the closest nooks
 Of woman's heart explored, and she
 Love's throes had suffered bitterly.
 Therefore she begged they might atwain,
 Though dying each for each, remain,
 Bound by no bonds but those of love,
 Whose gentle ties are strong above 9200
 All marriage laws, yet frank and free
 Leave lovers—in sweet amity—
 To follow learning, and she said,
 Moreover, that long absence bred
 'Twixt lovers unexpressed delight,
 Most poignant when they're lost to sight.

But Peter, as himself hath writ
 In burning letters, so was smit
 With passion, that nought else would
 serve

Till Heloise he drew to swerve 9210
 From her sage counsel, and thence fell
 On him mischance most dire to tell ;
 For little more their course was run
 Ere she at Argenteuil as nun
 Was close immured, while he was reft
 Of manhood by his foes, who deft
 As cruel were in his despite,
 Seizing him as he lay one night
 At Paris.

After this mischance
 Saint Denis, patron saint of France, 9220

Heloise
un-
paralleled

Gave shelter to him as a monk ;
And when this bitter cup he'd drunk
Down to the dregs, an abbey meet
He founded, hight the Paraclete,
For Heloise, and there with good
Success she ruled the sisterhood.
Her love-lorn story hath she told
In letters which she penned with bold
Unshamed assurance ; therein she
Declares monk Abelard to be
Her lord and master ; and some say
These far-famed letters but betray
Delirious love. When first the dress
She donned of abbess, her distress
Broke forth in these wild words :

9230

If he

Who rules Rome's Empire courteously
Deigned to demand that I, as wife,
To him would dedicate my life,
In proud estate, I should reply :
Much rather would I live and die
Thy mistress, wrapped in shame pro-
found,

9240

Than empress of the world be crowned.
But never since that day till now
Hath such a woman lived, I trow.

I doubt not 'twas her reading wide
Had taught her wisely to decide
All questions wherein woman's heart
Is bound to bear so great a part,
And so when love she felt disturb
Her soul, she knew his power to curb ;

9250

A wife's deckings And had her lover Abelard
 Listened to her, he had not marred
 His life through marriage ties, but well
 Had passed his days in learned cell.

Marriage is but an evil bond :
 Help me, St. Julian, who so fond
 Hast been of aiding travellers,
 And Leonard, saint whom prisoners
 Invoke to give them timely aid
 When they repentant are ; I made 9260
 Worse bargain when I took a wife
 Than if I had, to end my life,
 A halter bought, for chose I one
 So fine and fair to look upon
 That through her coquetry I'm dead.
 But, Son of Mary ! by my head,
 What comes of all this bravery ?
 What benefit accrues to me
 From costly gowns and quaint-cut gear,
 Your flirting tricks and mincing cheer ? 9270
 The more with wasteful train you sweep
 The ground, the more my flesh doth creep
 With rage, and when I see you clad
 Thus foolishly it drives me mad.
 What profits it, I ask again,
 That you should take such toiling pain
 To pleasure others, while to me
 It brings but grief and misery ?
 If I attempt some sportive play
 With you, 'tis always in the way, 9280
 For this vile muffling up prevents
 And baffles all my fond intents.

And then as cold as clay you turn,
 And all my efforts fail to earn
 Your kind accord ; you do but shake
 And twist your legs and thighs, and make
 Awkward excuses, till I see
 Most clearly that my gallantry
 You find distasteful.

A hus-
 band's
 grievance

When abed
 I seek with you to lay my head, 9290
 As worthy spouse should do at night,
 My dues to claim, my debt to quite,
 Your dizenments you cast aside,
 And both for head and neck provide
 White shrouds of linen, and from view
 Hide ribbons, red and green and blue,
 While all your robes of tissues fair
 And costly on a rail in air
 Are hung all night.

I pray you, tell
 What use such things are but to sell 9300
 Or pawn ? and if so be you do
 Nor one nor t'other with them, you
 May then expect such storms to break
 Around your head as cause you shake
 With terror : if your trash annoy
 Me day-long through, and nought of joy
 Gives me at night, what benefit
 Or pleasure do I gain from it
 More than a truss of river sedge,
 Unless it be to sell or pledge ? 9310

And for yourself—to make an end—
 If you have witting to attend

Beauty To reason, know that nought you gain
needs Of credit through behaviour vain
not art And frivolous, nor do you one bit
 Better your looks, poor foolish chit.

And if some man should quote a throng
 Of mouldy saws to prove me wrong,
 And show the folly of my words,
 Saying: Fine feathers make fine birds, 9320
 And that good garniture sits well
 Alike on dame and damosel;
 I should not trouble to reply
 At length, but simply say: You lie.

For all the beauty of fair things,
 Whether it be delightful spring's
 Sweet fleur-de-lis, as white as milk,
 Roses, or violets, or silk,
 Or other tissues fair (as I
 Have read in many a book) doth lie 9330
 Within themselves, and not in those
 Who wear them.

Happy she who knows
 That all the choicest things 'neath heaven
 Can ne'er improve, but oft may leaven
 The beauty Nature gives.

The heart
 In this same quality hath part.

To make my meaning stand out clear:
 Suppose a dunghill disappear
 From sight beneath a coverlet
 Of silk, with fragrant flowers beset 9340
 Of brightest hues, 'twould still remain
 A dunghill, and would stink amain

E'en as before it was bedeckt.

Fair
deckings
vain

And if some dotard should affect
To say that, though all foul within,
Fair is the dungheap for its skin
Of silk and flowers, in same-like way
As ladies who themselves array
To help their beauty, and conceal
Their ugliness, I could but feel
Amazed, nor dare to make reply,
Except I said that probably
Such strange delusion must arise
From some wild vision of the eyes,
Which see alone the outward show,
And ne'er the heart's vagaries know,
By seeming-sweet imaginings
Led to forget the depth of things
In suchwise that they nought can see
How to distinguish verity
From falsehood, nor with ease unknit
A fallacy, through lack of wit.

9850

9860

But if they had the eyes of lynx,
Men would not find a jade or minx
Better because she chanced to wear
Rich mantles trimmed around with rare
And fine Siberian marten fur,
Nor think one atom more of her
For heaps of diamonds and laces,
Set off with mincing airs and graces,
Nor frillings, furbelows, and stays,
Arranged a dozen different ways,
Nor hats with gayest flowers bedeckt.

9870

None could be fairer in respect

Chas- Of form than Alcibiades,
tity's evil Whose beauteous shape perforce must
plight please

All who beheld it, so the hand
 Of Nature had in seeming planned
 A godlike man, but who within
 Should look would find him foul with
 sin.

9380

And thus hath great Boethius said,
 Whose wit was with fair virtue wed.
 And he doth Aristotle call
 To witness, as a man whom all
 Put faith in, forasmuch as he
 Declares a lynx may clearly see
 Whate'er he will, right through and
 through.

Past doubt it must be owned for true
 That Beauty is to Chastity
 In nowise friendly, as we see
 In many a legend, tale and song
 Related, but unending wrong
 Will do to her. War to the death
 They wage so long as each draws breath,
 And neither one will yield a foot,
 Striving the other to uproot:
 But all unequal is the fight,
 And, whether in assault or flight,
 Cold Chastity is overcome,
 And lastly falling, worn and glum,
 Throws down her arms. E'en Ugliness,
 Her handmaid, seeing her distress,
 Forbears to help her, but doth strive
 The damsel forth her house to drive,

9390

9400

LI

Beauty and Ugliness assail
 Fair Chastity with such avail,
 That they subject her to their dame,
 Who loves to put chaste maids to shame.

AND followeth her with ponderous mace,
 Uplifted, round about the place 9410
 So fiercely, that 'twould seem as though
 Her mistress she must overthrow
 Within an hour.

Ugliness
turns
traitor

O frail and weak
 Is Chastity when both sides seek
 Her death, and none appear to aid
 Or help her; then, of all afraid,
 She takes to flight.

If under oath
 She were to fight, she yet were loth,
 Knowing so little of the way
 Of combat, to contest the day 9420
 Alone, for scarcely could she hope
 With friend and foe alike to cope.

Alas! for traitorous Ugliness,
 Whose duty 'twas and business
 Frail Chastity to guard. I ween
 Could she have hidden her between
 Her skin and smock, she surely ought
 Have popped her there as quick as thought.
 Beauty, moreover, is to blame,
 For Chastity may justly claim 9430
 Her love and reverence, and her peace
 She ought to make with her, and cease

Cumæan
Sibyl's
saying

From bickering strife, nor only so,
But 'neath her rule should bend alow.
If she but wise and courteous were,
With gentle kindliness she'd bear
Herself towards her, all despite
Foregone, for so doth Virgil write
Within the Æneid's sixth book :
(The word Cumæan Sibyl took),
That whoso chastely lives may well
Hope to escape the nether hell.
But swear I by the Lord who made
The heavens, that when some saucy jade
Doth impudently set about
To paint her face, and trick her out
In finery, 'tis plain that she
Makes war on saintly Chastity.
Alas ! Poor Chastity hath got,
I fear me, many a foe red-hot
In convent cell and abbey cloister,
Who would not hesitate to hoist her
Over their walls ; they should be built
Right high—'twould inmates save from
guilt.

9440

9450

Homage to Venus all dames pay,
And daintily their forms array
To draw on those by whom they're seen
About the ways with mincing mien,
And round them wanton glances fling,
Men to incite to dallying.
All equally they set their snares,
Whether at dances, or when prayers
Call them to church, and safe and sure
It is to say that such allure

9460

They'd ne'er affect, except with wish
 Immodest, vile, and devilish,
 To dazzle foolish men, and draw
 Them on to break God's holy law.

God's
 creation
 perfect

But those who look with equal eye
 Will see that women woefully 9470

Put God to shame, when in their fits
 Of folly, so beside their wits

Are they as not to be content
 With fairness such as God hath sent,

But each one on her head must set
 Fine gear with many a gay floweret

Of silk or gold adorned, whene'er
 She marches forth to take the air.

Alas! the silly fool succeeds
 Only in proving that she needs 9480

Good sense and modesty, when thus
 She strives to make her beauteous

With foolish gewgaws (which e'en less
 Of worth than her poor self possess),

Beyond the point that God saw good,
 As though He had not understood

His handicraft, but such a whelp
 As she must needs consult for help

To perfect that His hand begun.

So, from all creatures 'neath the sun 9490
 That God created, she doth ask

Assistance in her foolish task,
 Metals and minerals, and flowers,

O'er which she idly wasteth hours.

But for that matter, truth to speak,
 Men oft are foolish, vain, and weak

Simple As women are, for they likewise
vesture Oft seek the beauty to despise
enough That God hath given them, and bedeck
 With chains and chaplets head and neck 9500
 That His right hand hath wrought: despite
 We do His wisdom when delight
 We take to render yet more fair
 His matchless work, as those who dare
 Find fault with it. Away, I cry,
 With all such vain frivolity,
 I ask alone for raiment meet,
 To shield from summer's scorching heat
 And winter's frost. By God's help sped,
 Can I protect my limbs and head 9510
 Against rude tempest, wind and rain,
 With cloth and woollen; nowise fain
 Am I of outland squirrel fur,
 Nor love the cost such things incur.
 My wants supplied—I ask no more.

Too much, for you, I waste my store
 Of deniers on fine robes of blue
 Or scarlet, or fair tinting due
 To outland dyes, or fine brunette,
 With costly furs around beset, 9520
 Which you disport in public places,
 With leering smiles and wanton graces,
 Dragging the while your costly train
 Through dust in drought, through mud, 'neath
 rain,

Giving small thanks to God or me.

And when you lie all nakedly

In bed a-night-time, nought discreet
 You show you when I fain would greet
 Your lips or cheek with loving kiss,
 And win the while sweet nuptial bliss 9530
 With kindly word and fond caress,
 And every show of tenderness,
 But all the more I press my love
 Upon you, all the more you prove
 Recalcitrant, and quite snuff out
 My purpose with ill-tempered pout,
 Nor even show the common grace
 Of turning towards me, face to face,
 But feign you sick, and sob and sigh,
 And lie all limp and languorously. 9540
 So that at last I'm forced to beat,
 For fear of failure, glum retreat.

A hus-
 band's
 grievance

And oft I watch the day-dawn break,
 And wonder as I lie awake
 Whether you wrangle in such sort
 When you with other men disport
 And fondle, and in what way a-paid
 These rufflers are when all arrayed
 And muffled up with gallant dress
 You're dizen'd out for wantonness ; 9550
 Or if you practise such despite
 Towards them by day as me by night.
 But ne'er with gay sparks you consume
 The time, I doubt, in fret and fume,
 But dance and sing where'er you go,
 Your face all wreathed in smiles to show
 Your dazzling pearly teeth, and thus
 Through meads and gardens amorous

Women Do you, my church-wed wife, make play
will have With worthless spendthrifts, day by day, 9560
their way While I by no means am exempt
 From handling rude ; with fine contempt
 They cry : Ha ! ha ! may wolves devour
 The jealous dotard with his sour
 Curmudgeon's grin, and may his bones
 Be dragged by hounds across the stones !

By whom am I thus put to shame ?
 Baggage ! by you, who bear my name,
 Vile, common quean of ribald heart ;
 With ruffians well you play your part, 9570
 Foul bitch at heat ! base spawn of hell !
 False libertine ! curst Jezebel !
 Since thus you give yourself to crime,
 God grant a year may fill your time,
 For while you join in this wild race,
 Your lecherous life is my disgrace,
 And I through you shall surely be
 One of the base fraternity
 Of Saint Arnould accounted, and
 A member of that cuckold band, 9580
 Wherein each man must spend his life
 Who's fool enough to take a wife,
 For though one had a million eyes,
 A woman will their watch surprise.
 No guard can keep a wanton chaste,
 And though she fail Eve's fruit to taste
 At first, if she thereto hath will,
 Her purpose she'll at last fulfil.

But Juvenal of yore spake thus,
 As he were fain to comfort us : 9590

Stupration is the least offence
 Of women, saith he, for prepense
 Are they to greater crimes ; he tells
 How mothers-in-law wrought poison spells
 For daughters' husbands, and with charms,
 On those they loved not, worked dire harms
 And devilish tricks, and more of crime,
 That to set forth would waste all time.
 Whoso takes pains to peel the rind
 From woman will the harlot find,
 And taking heed will prove women all
 Fallen or ready-ripe to fall.

9600

And this advantage over men
 Have women as to will, that when
 They've settled what they're fain to do,
 They'll do it, though the world should rue,
 Or perish : none can change the heart
 Of woman, though her body smart ;
 Could one a woman's spirit quell,
 Her body might he rule as well.

9610

Now leave we that which ne'er can be ;
 But, Lord of Heaven ! give help to me !
 What can I 'gainst this ribald crew,
 Who put my life to shame and do
 Me wrongs untold ? Whatever threat
 I use against them is but met
 With laughing gibe ; if open war
 I make upon them, then they are
 Prepared to kill me. Brutal, proud,
 And strong are they, right well endowed
 For any crime ; they spurn the law,
 Nor care for me one single straw ;

9620

Hercules For in their spirits burneth bright
and The fire of youth, and maketh light
Samson And bold their hearts in such degree
 As cometh nigh insanity,
 And causeth every one of these
 To deem himself a Hercules,
 Samson or Roland; 'twixt the two
 First named, if records tell us true, 9630
 Corporal strength was equal, for
 Hercules, saith Solinus, more
 Than seven feet was of height, and this
 Exceeds all other men, ywis.
 Labours immense he undertook,
 And fearsome monsters twelve he strook
 With death, and then a thirteenth tried
 To overcome, but failed, and died
 By Dejanira's act, who sent
 To him a shirt, in which was pent 9640
 A poisonous, deadly fire, and thus
 This Hercules, so valorous
 And strong, was utterly subdued
 And conquered by vicissitude,
 Beneath a woman's treacherous hand.
 And this she did because the brand
 Of Love towards Iole had turned
 The heart of him for whom she burned.
 And Samson—he a half-score men
 Had scorned in fight as they were ten 9650
 Ripe apples while his locks grew, but
 By Delilah those locks were cut.

A sot am I these things to say,
 Which you'll repeat, when once away,

Threats
of
violence

To all the rascal friends you meet,
Who will with scorn and laughter greet
The tale you tell, and thus through you
May I win blows, nor light nor few,
My head to bruise, my legs to break,
And jelly of my back to make, 9660
Should I permit you hence to go.

But if perchance I come to know
That you have blabbed one word, I'll let
You hear of it. Unless they get
Hold of my arm and from me take
This club, such play with it I'll make
That neither neighbour, friend, nor sire,
Nor gallant, shall abate my ire.

Alas! that e'er we should have met!
'Neath what unhappy star was set 9670
My birth, that you on me should bring
Such shame, disgrace, and suffering?
But to these scoundrel villain curs,
Because they're smooth-tongued flatterers,
Do you accord full seigniory,
While I it is who ought to be
Your well-loved lord, by whom you've
been

Fed, clothed, and shod long years, I ween.
All shamelessly am I by you
Associate made with this base crew 9680
Of scurvy scoundrels, villain scum,
From whom nought else to you can come
But shame, dishonour, and disgrace;
For while they praise you to your face,
But cheaply they esteem your charms,
E'en while they revel in your arms.

Back- Before your face they all declare
biting That you're an angel, but beware !
 For when your back is turned they pull
 You all to pieces for a trull, 9690
 And laugh and jeer, and tell the mad
 And merry sportive times they've had
 With you, and throughly well such fate
 Do you deserve, when dedicate
 You are to vice, and men at will
 May have you as a common gill.

And when by all this jolly rout
 I see you mauled and pulled about,
 I frankly own, I sometimes feel
 An envy I can scarce conceal ; 9700
 But don't deceive yourself, 'tis not
 For fairness of your face, God wot !
 That men pursue you, nor for sense
 Or lively wit or eloquence
 That you display ; it is alone
 By your fine feathers that they're won,
 Your rich spun robes and jewels bright,
 Your clasps of gold, and rings that
 dight

Your fingers, all of which you got
 From me by wheedling, and a sot 9710
 Therefor I own me.

When to balls
 And dances, as your fancy calls,
 With gallants you betake yourself,
 I'm left at home upon the shelf
 As one who's drunk or mad, whilst bold
 And brave you go, bedeckt with gold,

Silver and gems, on neck and head,
Whose value might be safely said
Above five hundred pounds, and ask
That I your worthless body mask
With silks and satins to your taste,
While I may fret, and pine, and waste
(So much it wears and vexes me)
With angry spleen and jealousy.

Follies of
dress

9720

What for these orfreys do I care
With which you twist and bind your hair,
Entwined with threads of gold? and why
Must you have set in ivory
Enamelled mirrors, sprinkled o'er
With golden circlets? (Nothing more
Enrages me), and why these gems
Befitting kingly diadems,
Rubies and pearls, and sapphires fair,
Which cause you to assume an air
Of mad conceit?

9730

These costly stuffs,
And plaited furbelows and ruffs,
And cinctures to set off your waist,
With pearls bedeckt and richly chased,
And morsers and rich fastenings;
What use to me are all such things?
And wherefore, say then, do you choose
To fit your feet with gaudy shoes,
Except you have a lust to show
Your shapely legs?

9740

By St. Thibaud,
Ere yet three days are past I'll sell
This trash, and trample you pell-mell;

Plain I'll give you nothing else to wear,
gear By Body of God, but simple gear,
suffices A woollen kirtle, and a gown
 Of hempen woof to fall adown 9750
 About your heels, nought delicate,
 But coarse and rude, and in a state
 Of rags and slits, howe'er you fret ;
 And round about your waist I'll set
 A girdle, of what sort, think ye ?
 No tricked and tinselled trumpery,
 But plain white skin, undecked with
 gold,

While for your shoes shall serve my old
 Worn gaiter leggings ; soon I'll thrash
 From mind and body all this trash 9760
 Of dress and mincing ways, which draw
 You on to break the marriage law.
 No longer shall this ribald crew
 Unhindered have their will of you.

I charge you that you tell me now,
 Without a lie, from whom and how
 Did you obtain that rich silk dress
 Which at the ball you wore ? Confess !
 For well I know it was not I
 Who gave it you.

Unblushingly 9770
 You swore by God the Father and
 St. Denis, who protects this land,
 And holy Philibert, that you
 Received it from your mother, who,
 According to your tale, so well
 Loves me, that readily she'd sell

The
mother-
in-law

Her goods to spare my purse, or give
All she calls hers that I might live
Untouched by want or care. I'd see
Her burnt alive, most joyfully 9780

(The vile whoremongering old cat),
And you along with her, if that
Be not the very thing you said!
I'll surely ask her, by my head,
But no, alas! it were but vain,
Great the vexation, nought the gain;
Past doubt you've talked to one another,
Like as two marbles—child and mother,
Two bells with self-same clapper rung,
Two weeds from one vile root upsprung. 9790
Right well ye hop and step together,
Two evil birds of equal feather.

She in her youth days was as vile
As you are now, and every wile
That then she learned she taught to you,
Apt pupil for her devil's brew!
And doubt I not that she, forsooth,
Of many a dog hath proved the tooth,
And hath but ceased to trip the dance,
Because right well she knows her
chance 9800

Therein is past and gone. Her face,
Besmeared with paint, hath lost all trace
Of beauty, and the harridan
Employs her short remaining span
Of life to sell her child. Therefor
It is she comes three times or four
Each week, pretending to engage
You to set forth on pilgrimage

Personal
violence

According to the ancient use ;
But well I know she makes excuse
Thereof to trot you forth for sale
Like any nag, nor doth she fail
To snare while teaching you to snare.
Deem you that I am unaware
Of these vile tricks? I scarce restrain
My arm from laying on amain
With this good stick, until you lie
All in a heap, like pullet pie.

9810

LII

The jealous husband, all a-heat,
From scolding next proceeds to beat
His wretched wife, and robe and hair
Doth in his rage from off her tear.

9820

FORTHWITH as one whose every pore
With rage and passion boileth o'er,
His wife he seizes by the hair,
Shakes her as rudely as a bear
Is shaken by a lion, then,
E'en as it were a wild beast's den,
He drags her madly round the room,
With frantic threats of direst doom,
While to her vows of innocence
He's deaf, as one devoid of sense
Or hearing, foams, and rolls his eyes,
Regardless of the piteous cries
And shrieks with which she fills the air,
Piercing and shrill as trumpet blare,
Pours forth each brutal epithet
To which he in his wrath can set

9830

His savage tongue, till neighbours haste
To separate the fools who waste
Their days in strife, and save from death
The wife, for nought but outworn breath
Can stay the husband's rage.

Estradgement

9840

When o'er

This scene of turmoil and uproar
She thinketh, and the ballading
Her jongleur made doth loudly ring
Within her ears, imagine you
The wife more faithfully will do
Her duty towards her spouse?

Nay, nay!

She will but wish him right away
In far Roumania or at Meaux.
Nor should I very widely go
From truth were I to say she ne'er
Will love him more, although that air
She may assume: could he but fly,
And get a bird's-eye view on high
In safety, and from thence behold
What men are doing in this old
Worn world, and calmly muse thereon,
He'd see what misery he hath won,
And how his vision hath been blind
To all the ruses womenkind
Use to defend them, and to be
Safe-harboured from men's tyranny.

9850

9860

If with his wife he shares his bed,
Much risk he runneth, by my head,
For if he sleep or if he wake,
Great fear pursues him lest she take

Miseries Swift vengeance on him, and his life
of By poison cup or murderous knife. 9870
jealousy He lose, or else the victim be
 From year to year of trickery ;
 Or if indeed she's baffled quite
 Of that she loves, she takes to flight.
 Honour, and faith, and truth are spurned
 By women when their heads are turned ;
 And truth it is, beyond all doubt,
 That every woman is without
 Conscience, who either loves or hates.
 Valerius saith : She hesitates, 9880
 In such a case, at nought at all,
 Nor recketh whatsoe'er befall.

My friend, the wretched man, turned sour
 By jealousy, may wolves devour,
 Who thus, as painted to the life,
 Ill-treats and vilifies his wife,
 And o'er her gets the mastery
 With brutal hand ; nor should she be
 Supreme in rule, but each in awe
 Of other stand, as saith God's law, 9890
 Dwelling together, mate and mate ;
 But if in spirit separate
 They live, their days are past and spent
 In strife, and dead is sweet content.
 Think you a man gains woman's love
 Who sets himself as lord above
 Her will and ways ? fair love falls dead
 When signiory exalts its head
 Above affection, ne'er can dure
 Love but in hearts, free, frank, and pure. 9900

And verily, 'tis rarely seen
 With those who lovers long have been
 Ere wedlock joined them, that doth last
 Fond nuptial love, for in the past
 The lover would avow him for
 The lady's bounden servitor,
 But after marriage doth declare
 His lordship, which right hard to bear
 She finds from him who late did waive
 All right and vowed himself her slave.

Courtship
 v.
 marriage

9910

The Lover.

Her slave?

The Friend.

Past doubt.

The Lover.

And prithee why?

The Friend.

Because he willingly would fly
 At her command; if she but said:
 Dear friend, my purse; away he sped,
 Nothing could vex him, nought could tire,
 To satisfy her least desire;
 To speak, indeed, were scarce worth while,
 He read each frown, and knew each smile,
 His only thought was to obey
 Her every wish in every way.

9920

But when they're once by wedlock tied,
 This courtesy is cast aside,

Primitive
simplicity

The wheel is turned, and he who late
Before her will would fall prostrate
Doth now command, as though he might
From her claim service as of right,
Holds her in check, and makes her feel
That she from him hath no appeal;
She, who but yesterday he named
His mistress, and was nought ashamed 9930
To serve, must now serve him, alas!
And many a rude experience pass.
Ah, then she plains her evil case,
Seeing the husband doth displace
The lover, and her closest friend
To friendship puts a bitter end
By contrariety; now no more
He worships her as heretofore.
But dead is joyousness, she dare
Scarce laugh so 'whelmed is she with care. 9940
Nor knows she where to turn for aid
When on her neck he looks, afraid
Lest, as erewhile he ne'er took heed
Thereof, he now some ill may speed.
Obedience is her only choice,
For if in plaint she raise her voice,
Woe worth the day! it wakes his rage,
With threats wild war on her to wage.

My friend, the earliest men were free
From bondage, yoke, and slavery,
And peaceably they shared their good
In perfect love and brotherhood.
Nor had they freedom's joyance sold
For Araby's or Frisia's gold;

9950

And if men once that treasure lack,
 No gold on earth can win it back.
 Then no man toiled in pilgrimage,
 But lived from infancy to age
 At home, nor cared to cross the wave
 Of ocean for an outland grave.

Jason's
 journey-
 ing

9060

LIII

How Jason erstwhile ploughed the sea,
 To seek the gold-fleece bravery,
 And by the folk where'er he went,
 Was seen with fear and wonderment.

PRINCE Jason 'twas who first of all
 Built on the waves a vessel tall,
 And voyaged therein to seek the fleece
 Of gold, but Neptune deemed his peace
 Invaded, and great Triton too,
 And Doris with her daughters grew
 Alarmed, and feared themselves betrayed,
 Beholding these first men who made
 Their road across the acres they
 Had held with undisputed sway.

9070

For earth's first dwellers were content
 To stay a-land, nor ever went
 To plough the sea; enough they found
 For all their needs on solid ground.
 Where each man had what each required,
 For none as yet ambition fired.

9080

O happy men, of simple life—
 Love reigned, and all unknown was strife

Earth's Till Fraud arose, his lance in rest,
curse And Crime and Evil-Hap confessed
 Stood, foes of sweet sufficiency.
 Then Pride, who scorns to equal be
 With others, came in grand estate
 With Covetousness, and hideous Hate,
 And Envy dire, and Avarice,
 And many another foul-faced vice. 9990
 And Poverty from hell they brought,
 Who there had long-time lived, and nought
 Men knew her on the happy earth,
 Till now new-born, ah! woeful birth!
 Wherefore, alas! came she at all?
 Worst evil that can man befall.

Drear Poverty, of wit bereft,
 Led by the hand her infant, Theft,
 Who to the gibbet goes straightway,
 Seeking his mother's needs to stay. 10000
 All powerless she to take his part,
 As eke his sire, y'clept Faint-Heart;
 Nor doth for him aught good provide
 Laverna, of all thieves the guide
 And goddess, who with cloud and night
 Conceals their evil deeds, till light
 At last discovers them; and when
 They're haled before their fellow-men,
 No pitying eye doth she afford,
 Seeing around their necks the cord 10010
 Fast tied, but gaily pulls it tight
 When penitence they've made aright.

Suddenly these mad fiends accurst
 (When once they hell's dread bounds had burst),

The lust
of gain

Their hearts aflame with envious rage
 'Gainst dwellers in this golden age
 Of peace, o'erran the pleasant earth,
 Sowing ill will and murdering mirth,
 While envy, malice, spite, and hate
 They strove to spread and propagate.

10020

Longing the ruddy gold to win
 From mother earth, her very skin
 Men tore, and then for treasures stored
 Beneath her breast deep caverns bored,
 And precious stones and metals sought,
 With life and labour dearly bought.

For Avarice and Covetousness
 Torment the minds of men, and press
 Them on, e'en while they curse and ban
 Their lot, to win whate'er they can.

10080

This strives to gain, and that to keep,
 For ne'er from out his useless heap
 The miser will one denier spend
 The while he lives, but when the end
 Falls on him, to his heir it goes,
 Unless God otherwise dispose
 Thereof; and if he lost it all,
 Pity therefor need be but small.

Ere long the unhappy human race
 Corrupted grew, and every trace
 Of simple living lost, they came
 To be false tricksters, void of shame;
 The land they set about to share
 In seigniories, and here and there
 Fixed lines and limitations, but
 Thereout full many a man was shut.

10040

Kings And next they fell to war thereon,
first And each man kept whate'er he won
chosen By force and fraud, and thus the strong
Beat back the weak—if right or wrong. 10050
But if awhile they left their lands,
Arose some idle roving bands
Of rascals, who would forge within
Their dwellings, and their warnestore win.
And so among them 'twas agreed
To choose out one who might give heed
To all men's surety, and adjudge
Each plaint of fraud, misdeed, or grudge
With upright, fair, impartial voice;
So gathered they to fix their choice. 10060

(LIV)

Herein behold the manner how
Men first agreed their necks to bow
Beneath a king, and how he sware
The sceptre loyally to bear.

THEN from the host men set apart
A sturdy peasant, bold of heart,
Of mighty strength, and towering height,
Called him their lord, and gave him right
Above the rest. He stoutly sware
To guard them all with watchful care; 10070
But each of ye, quoth he, must give
Dimes of your goods that I may live.
E'en as he asked it so befell,
As ancient books and records tell,
And many a year this compact he
Fulfilled, but robbers presently.

Man's
avarice

Assembled, seeing him alone,
And fell on him with stick and stone,
With will his goods to rob and steal.
And then men met and made appeal, 10080
Each unto each, a tax to pay,
Whereby their king from disarray
To guard, and all the people vowed
From out their lands should be allowed
A fair and wide domain, and thus
Began the burden onerous
Of kings and princes, as ye see
Writ plain in many a history.
And in these scriptures are we told
The ways and works of men of old, 10090
And unto those through whom we get
Such knowledge, owe we deepest debt
Of thanks and praise.

With toil past measure

Men then began to heap up treasure,
Winning, from out the rich stored earth,
Silver and gold and stones of worth,
And soon thereof with toil they coined
Round pieces, and of metals, joined
With gems, they fairest jewels made,
Vessels, and rings; and many a blade 10100
For sword and dagger of bright steel,
And arms and axes wrought, to deal
Death blows, and well-knit coat and helm
'Neath which to fight and overwhelm
Their fellows, and then towers they placed
Around with high-built walls encased,
And cities fair, and palaces,
Wherein they looked to dwell at ease,

Wealth And crenelated castles barred
breeds With strong portcullises to guard 10110
strife The heaped up treasures they amassed ;
 For many a fearsome hour they passed,
 Lest others reft away their gains,
 The fruit of labour's toilsome pains,
 Or war, fought out with hardy hands
 O'er perilous seas in far-off lands.
 And thus did they around them heap
 Troubles and cares, which murder sleep.

Nought knew they more of soft-eyed
 peace,
 For growth of wealth but brought increase 10120
 Of woes, and things that late were free
 As sun and wind and unchained sea,
 Through avarice of wealth were set
 Apart, each strove good share to get.
 Oft one man more than twenty had,
 Which doth but shadow forth a bad
 And selfish heart.

Such cruel gluttons
 I count not worth a deuce of buttons.
 What care I if their souls possess
 Of faith and love, or more or less ? 10130
 If they betwixt them buy and sell
 Their love or hate, nor ill or well
 I count it, but 'tis damage great
 When damsels fair and delicate,
 Fitted for gentle love and true,
 Abase their souls and bodies through
 The love of gold ; a sight it is
 To tear one's heart to shreds, ywis.

Before whatever else may be,
 A gallant should full mastery
 Gain of love's science, so that ne'er
 It be his evil lot to bear
 His love's abandonment, or let
 It happen that she e'er forget
 His faithfulness. This art may gain
 A man much good unmixed with bane.

10140 **Women**
hate to be
chidden

Well shall it be with him who minds
 The counsel that herein he finds :
 Whether his flame be old or young,
 If he suspect new love hath sprung 10150
 Within her heart in preference,
 Let him beware that no offence
 He give to her by chiding, but
 To anger keep his heart's door shut,
 And nowise modulate or change
 His amorous words, lest he estrange
 Her heart still more. If in the act
 He catch her, he must blink the fact,
 As he were dull as horse or ox,
 And blind and senseless as the rocks. 10160
 And if perchance a billet-doux
 He light on, the wise thing to do
 Is not to read it, or e'en ope
 Its folds, her liaison to grope.
 Nor should he suffer aught to fire
 His heart to traverse her desire ;
 When she returns from out the street,
 Let him salute with smile as sweet
 As April morn, and even so
 Permit her where she will to go ; 10170

Heed not scandal For women hate above all things,
 That men should hold their leading strings ;
 Forget not this ; and what I next
 Relate to thee, in golden text
 Of fairest script might well be writ
 For great behoof and benefit
 Of lovers.

Whatso man would get
 Grace in a woman's heart should let
 Her go her ways, where'er she will,
 For seek to check her, and you spill 10180
 All love betwixt you, whether she
 Or spouse or mistress chance to be.
 Though 'gainst his mistress one receive
 Clear witness, let him not believe
 Or hearken it, but say to those
 Who bring the tale, they but disclose
 Their want of wit, and words they waste ;
 To tell base tales of one so chaste
 Argues a fool. Her vices e'en
 Should he let pass as though unseen 10190
 And unsuspect. For those who treat
 A woman ill, with hope the heat
 Of love to raise in her, will find
 That when again she's wooed with kind
 And loving words, 'tis like to that
 Experience that sometimes a cat
 Affords us, which men beat, then call
 To come again beneath their thrall,
 But if puss once gets loose, O rare
 And deft his skill who caught her were. 10200
 But if the lady 'tis doth trim
 Her lover's beard, 'tis not for him

**Bear with
women**

To take her wrath in evil part,
Or anywise to change his heart
Towards her ; even though she catch
Her nails within his cheek and scratch
His face till blood flow down, he should
Make no reply except with good
And kindly loving words, and say
He counted it a perfect way 10210
Of life if only he were sure
Her love for him would aye endure,
And sooner 'neath her hand would die
Than live from her sweet company
Divorced. But if 'tis he begins
The storm, and from her haply wins
Return of wrath and violence,
'Twere well, to cover the offence,
That he should lead her on to play
The game of love, ere yet away 10220
He goes from her, especially
If cursed with poverty he be ;
For lacking gold he runs the chance
She oust him from the merry dance
Of love, unless he humble him
Before her.

Poor men fain must swim
Which way a mistress wills, nor show
A spark of wrath, howe'er things go,
The while that rich men not a bean
Need take to heart disdainful mien, 10230
For insult is a luxury
Of wealthy men.

But if so be
A gallant seeketh to beguile
A second fair, yet keep the while

*

A jealous mistress His former love, and choose to make,
 While yet the first love is awake,
 Some presents to his later flame,
 Such as may please a gentle dame,
 Fair kerchief, buckle, chaplet, ring,
 Jewel or other dainty thing, 10240
 'Twere wise to hide it from the first,
 For nought could salve her rage accurst
 If she thereof became aware.
 Moreover, should he have great care
 That ne'er the two in self-same place
 Should meet, and one the other face;
 For if the former should discover
 The latter with her faithless lover,
 Never wild boar with bristles set,
 When yelping hounds are round him met, 10250
 Were fiercer; never lioness
 Who hears the hunt when cublings press
 Her teats, sprang forth more wild and mad;
 No viper when some traveller had
 Set foot upon its tail, and thus
 Alarmed it, were more venomous
 Than is a woman who beholds
 Her rival while her lover folds
 His arms around her; fire and flame
 Flash from her eyes, and scorn and
 blame 10260
 Her lips exhale, until for breath
 She pants, as one 'neath stroke of death.
 And e'en though she should ne'er surprise
 The two together, but surmise
 Alone doth move her, jealousy
 Within her heart as fire will be.

**Forswear
infidelity**

Then he unblushingly should say
 To all her questions, Nay, nay, nay,
 And oath on oath pile up of truth
 And constancy, and if forsooth 10270
 He can with blandishment and kiss
 Entice her on to amorous bliss,
 The storm is laid. But if in vain
 He plead with her, and she amain
 So presses him that he can see
 No loophole, then all hardily
 Let him avow his crime, but tell
 A subtle tale of how he fell
 A victim to the rival, who
 Assailed him, so that he could do 10280
 Nought else but yield to her—and this
 Was but his one sad lapse, ywis.
 And then a solemn oath he swears,
 That 'tis for her alone he cares,
 And if he e'er again forsake,
 Betray, or dupe her, may she take
 Such vengeance on him as she will;
 Nor shall her rival see him till
 His dying day, and rather drowned
 He'd see her than again be found 10290
 Her paramour, a creature vile
 He nameth her, whose treacherous wile
 Drew him aside, and then should he
 Enfold his mistress tenderly,
 With many a kiss and fond embrace,
 And solemn vow, that, once her
 grace
 She deigns to grant, he nevermore.
 Will vex her heart as heretofore,

Love
should be
sacred

But towards her loyally behave,
And may she as a dog or slave
To death condemn him if again
He break from her most gentle chain.
And then in love's fond war entwined
He pardon gains, soft, sweet, and kind.

10800

By no means should a lover dare
To boast new conquest if he care
To keep his mistress' love.

Vile shame

It is when gallants dare make claim,
With lying tongue, that they've deceived
Ladies, who ne'er their vows received.
Such men are curst with souls debased,
On whom 'twere idle words to waste,
For only fools and idiots flaunt
Their dreams for deeds, with empty vaunt,
In all men's ears, and he who most
Successful is, forbears to boast.
Love's habitude it is to hide
His jewels from all else beside
His closest friends, who know to keep
A silent tongue.

10810

He'll sigh and weep

10820

Most woefully if sickness seize
His mistress, and will strive to please
Her every whim, nor let her guess
How much of pain and weariness
Such work imposeth. He should sit
Beside her couch, and ere from it
He goes oft kiss her, and a tear
Let fall, the while he seeks to cheer

And comfort her. A pilgrimage
 He vows to God will He assuage
 Her malady, and lets her know
 Thereof—though nought he means to go.
 The food she loves doth he aver
 Is good, and nought besiegeth her
 With nauseous draughts, nor aught,
 ywis,

Be true in
 sickness
 10880

But what right sweet and grateful is.
 Then pleasant fictions he'll invent,
 Of how the night foregone he spent,
 Vowing that drearily it sped,
 No sweet companion in his bed
 To solace him, and how awake
 He restless lay, for her sweet sake,
 Then sleeping, dreamed that in his arms,
 Disrobed, beheld he all her charms,
 To glowing health once more restored,
 Able and willing to afford
 The joys he longs for: doubt not such
 Fair fictions will console her much.

10840

Thus have I striven in verse to tell
 How should a lover, sick or well,
 His mistress treat if he desire
 To keep alive the sacred fire
 Of ardent love, whose flame may be
 Snuffed out and quenched right easily
 By any wight, who selfish ease
 Prefers, nor troubleth him to please
 Her fancy.

10850

Framed and meddled so
 Is woman's heart that man can know

A good woman
should be
prized

Never if it be false or true,
No matter what he say or do. 10860
To hold it fast is task as vain
As though an eel from out the Seine
One should 'twixt thumb and finger grip,
Which will not fail to slide and slip
From out the grasp howe'er one try
To hold it, for so slippery
It is of skin, and eke so quick
Of movement, that its every trick
No man can fathom.

Nought I would
✓ Speak thus of all, for some both good 10370
And virtuous are, but deep regret
Is mine to own I ne'er have met
With any such, although from queen
To jade full many a one I've seen.
And wise King Solomon declared
That, as through life's dark maze he fared,
No woman e'er by him was found
Faithful and true.

If through the round
Of life you find one, tarry not,
But, joyful for your happy lot, 10380
Give Fortune thanks that you possess
One faithful love your life to bless.
If nought a woman gads about
The street, nor lovers seek her out,
She chaste remains.

Just one word more
To perfect what I've said before
Of love's fair art. Whene'er a maid,
Fair or ill-favoured, you'd invade,

Women
hate
censure

Remember this, which certainly
Will prove to women's hearts a key. 10890
Fail not upon her to impress
That 'tis her passing loveliness
And worth that takes by storm your heart—
Than this Love's quiver holds no dart
More deadly; whether old or young,
Bred in the world, or reared among
Religious sisters, pure and chaste,
Fine flattering words will run not waste.
A woman's fairness laud, and she
Will listen most contentedly. 10400
E'en though no beauty she possess,
By Nature stamped with ugliness,
Fear not, but praise her fairy face,
Her perfect form and angel grace,
And lightly she'll believe your word,
For never yet hath woman heard
Her beauty praised without delight,
Or doubted she with justice might
Be loved, however plain she were,
For gladly she believes her fair. 10410
To please their ladies gallants ought
To give full praise, and censure nought.

That man I reckon most unwise
Who rashly dares to criticise
Or disapprove a lady's ways,
For every woman thinks she plays
Her part by nature perfectly,
And interference hateth she.
E'en as a cat ne'er goes to school,
But learns by Nature's golden rule 10420

Prize highly the Rose To leap, and bound, and pounce, and spring,

So woman deems that everything
 She knows in self-same way, nor aught
 Believes she needeth to be taught,
 But acts as she is led by will,
 And right or wrong, or good or ill
 Doth, as it entereth her head,
 By foolish whim and fancy led ;
 Rarely it haps she doeth right,
 But woe betide the witless wight
 Who counsels her. 10430

This habit she
 Learned of no master, naturally
 'Twas born in her, and those who choose
 To blame or 'monish women, lose
 Their love outright.

And thus it goes,
 It seems to me, with your sweet Rose,
 Dear friend, you freely would resign
 All that you have without repine
 To win possession.

When at last
 Into your loving care hath past
 This precious gem, and happiness
 Smileth upon you and doth bless
 Your soul in perfect wise, the flower
 Kind Heaven hath placed within your
 power 10440

Guard tenderly, and you therein
 Such joy shall have as few men win,
 For though through fourteen cities ye
 Should search, you ne'er its peer shall see.

The Lover answers his friend.

'Fore Heaven, you speak good truth, I cried,		The
In all the world there's nought beside	10450	friend
To equal it, so pure, so sweet !		departs
Happy am I a friend to meet		
Whose words of wisdom so much aid		
And comfort give me ; nor afraid		
Am I to say that better far		
Your redes than those of Reason are.		

But ere my shrewd and kindly friend
 Had brought his parlance to an end,
 Sweet-Speech and Gentle-Thought, who nigh
 Had stood the while, all suddenly 10460
 Appeared in view from out their nooks,
 But with them brought they not Sweet-Looks.
 Alas ! no man on earth, I wot,
 Can give the thing he owneth not.

LV

The Lover makes no more delay,
 But leaves his friend, and seeks the way
 To where Fair-Welcome lies, for fain
 Is he to find him once again.

THEN to my friend I bade adieu,	
And with a merry heart withdrew	10470
From thence across the mead, lit up	
With daisy bright and buttercup,	
And hearkened how the echoes rang,	
With joyous notes the small fowl sang ;	

The approach to the tower
 Ah ! how my spirit with delight
 O'erflowed at such sweet sound and sight.

But one thing that my friend had said
 Lay on my heart like weight of lead,
 Which was, that I should go not near
 The tower accursed, but keep me clear 10480
 Of all the roads that led thereto,
 A thing my will rebelled to do.

Then wandering heedless I forsook
 The right-hand path, and straightway took
 The left, in hope the shortest road
 To find, for in my soul abode
 Earnest desire the goal to gain,
 Of danger careless, and of pain
 Unmindful, could I only get
 Thither ere one more strong should let 10490
 Or hinder my attempt to free
 Fair-Welcome, friend most dear to me.
 Soon as I see the stronghold break
 Before me like a baked-up cake,
 And the strong gates wide open fly,
 Then none shall stay my valiancy.
 And may the devil be within
 My belly if I fail to win
 The fortress ; for I promise you
 If once I get within near view 10500
 Thereof, Fair-Welcome shall its bounds
 O'erleap, I wage a million pounds.
 But from the fort itself I'll stay,
 For prudence' sake, some little way.

LVI

The Lover findeth Dame Richesse,
 Who guards the path with carefulness
 By which the fortress may be ta'en
 Of those who scatter golden rain.

HARD by a fountain fresh and clear
 (While musing on my Rosebud dear) 10510
 I found a sweet sequestered spot
 Where sat a dame, whom all would wot
 Of lovely form and joyous face,
 Beneath a leafy elm her place.
 A gallant stood beside the dame,
 (Of whom I wist nor rank nor name)
 But her I knew for Dame Richesse,
 By all men held of great noblesse,
 And o'er a pleasant pathway guard
 She kept, and all intrusion barred. 10520

The
 Lover
 finds
 Richesse

Soon as I saw them I inclined
 My head, and well was pleased to find
 Return thereof, but that was all
 My welcoming. In accent small
 And soft I gently asked if they
 Could to Much-Giving point the way ;
 And Richesse, speaking first, replied,
 In tones that savoured scorn and pride :

Richesse.

By the path, I hold the way.

The Lover.

The Ah! lady, God preserve, I pray, 10580
 woning of Your life, but prithee suffer me
 Richesse To wend towards that high fort I see
 Yonder, which Jealousy hath reared
 For purpose that my heart hath seared.

Richesse.

Not yet, O vassal, to that spot
 May you approach, I know you not ;
 Those only by this path can go
 Who know me, and I please to know.
 As stranger you must ten years wait
 Ere, as my friend, you pass this gate ; 10540
 Although from Paris straight one came
 Or Amiens, 'twere to me the same.
 My friends may freely enter here
 To dance and sing throughout the year,
 And live a joyous life and free,
 Whereof no sage need envious be,
 Nought passeth here but frolic play
 Wherewith to wile the time away,
 Light dances set to gleesome tunes,
 On viols, tambours, and bassoons, 10550
 Sweet songs that savour amorousness,
 And games of tables, dice and chess,
 And many another for delight
 Of merry hearts. And there are dight
 Delicious meats that never cloy,
 And soft amours fulfilled of joy.
 There loving swains with ladies sweet,
 By schemes of skilled duennas meet,

And wandering stroll 'neath shady groves
 And gardens, where they tell their loves, 10560
 Gaily attired as popinjays,
 And leisure-footed wend their ways
 Towards dulcet baths right well prepared
 For soft delight, and having shared
 This joyance, then hard by are found
 Luxurious chambers, where they, crowned
 With flower-twined chaplets, idly lie
 Within Mad-Largess' hostelry,
 Where they at every pore are bled,
 And long 'tis ere their cure is sped. 10570
 Right dearly do they pay for what
 Their host affordeth them; so hot
 And ruthless his rapacity,
 That all their goods and lands must be
 To him made o'er.

The
 home of
 Richesse

I lead men in
 That they a joyous time may win,
 But Poverty doth drive them thence,
 Naked and shivering, reft of pence.
 I guard the entry, she the gate
 Of exit: men of all estate 10580
 Accept I, ignorant and wise
 May enter, but when they arise
 To travel forth, they're paupers. Yet
 I will not say but they may get
 Permission to return (but this
 No small or light won favour is)
 If they with good provision come,
 To make with me once more their home,
 Nor that I would not many a time
 Receive them till they had no dime 10590

Scat- Of that great wealth they once possessed.
terlings But know thou, ever more distressed
fall to Are they the oftener they return
Poverty New store of bitter woe to earn,
 Till that they shun my gaze for shame
 And, taking on their heads the blame,
 Cast off their lives of misery.
 I flee from those who flee from me.
 I warn you well, ere yet you pass
 This barrier, you will cry, alas ! 10600
 When you return, for never Bear,
 Hand-led, and muzzle doomed to wear,
 Was wretcheder than you will be
 At going hence. If Poverty
 Cast you on bed of hay or straw,
 You there 'mid sighs and groans must draw
 Your breath till you of hunger die.

Hunger, who unto Poverty
 Was chamberer, by her bitterness
 Reduced her dame to dire distress, 10610
 And then corrupted her, till she
 Became the nurse of Knavery ;
 From her own breast with milk she fed
 The varlet, who no other bread
 E'er tasted. And if ye desire
 To hear of her, this caitiff dire,
 Fierce Hunger, dwells on stone-strewn ground,
 Where nought of herb or grain is found,
 A land which north of Scotland lies,
 Whose frozen atmosphere outvies 10620
 The marble's coldness. Hunger, who
 Wones where no tree or grain e'er grew,

Digs from the earth roots crude and raw,
 With pointed tooth and long-grown claw.
 But sparsely roots and herbage strow
 Those rugged rocks where wild winds
 blow.

**Hunger
 portrayed**

Should I the crone describe to you,
 My words forsooth need be but few,
 Her body long, dry-boned, and bent,
 With lack of food shows worn and spent ; 10630
 Ragged her locks ; blear eyes deep-set ;
 Face livid ; lips, so thin, they let
 Long teeth protrude ; her wrinkled skin
 Scarce hides the wretched bones wherein
 Nor sap nor marrow flows, while she
 For belly hath a cavity,
 And not more flesh, as I opine,
 Hangs on her dugs than on her chine.
 Her knees resemble jagged points
 Of rock, and all her finger joints 10640
 Rude knots deform ; such misery lean
 Holds her in grip. And ne'er, I ween,
 Doth Ceres, foison's Goddess, come
 Anigh this heaven-forgotten home ;
 Nor doth Triptolemus e'er fly
 His dragons through this sunless sky,
 For Destiny decrees that ne'er
 Shall here be joined that welcome pair.
 The fruitful Goddess could not dwell
 With Famine in her dreary hell, 10650
 For foison can in nowise be
 Allied with direful Poverty.
 But she it is, forsooth, will lead
 You on to curst estate of need

**Hunger
and
Poverty**

If you through slothfulness once get
Your feet within her close-meshed net,
And unto Poverty's dim den
A man as surely cometh when
That path he takes, as though he trod
This road, of which I guard the sod ; 10660
For men of idle life and base
Soon meet the beldame face to face.
And if you deem that well 'twill suit
Your turn to follow out the route
Towards treacherous Poverty accurst
In hope thereby the gates to burst
Of this strong fort, you easily
May fail. But Hunger, credit me,
Will be your fellow and bedmate
Soon as you fall to poor estate, 10670
For better Poverty by heart
The road knows than by parchment
chart.

And wretched Hunger doth expend
Such pains and carefulness to tend
Her dam (for though she loves her not,
Yet through her only hath she got
Wherewith to live, though she herself
Is naked, and devoid of pelf),
That ever comes she day by day,
And sits beside her in the way, 10680
And kisseth her with much misease.
Theft's ear she suddenly doth seize,
And wakes him if she sees him sleep,
Inclines her towards him in her deep
Distress, consulting how they may
By some means Hunger's pangs allay.

Faint-Heart with Hunger doth agree,
 Who of the rope thinks tremblingly,
 And on her body every hair
 Stands stiff and straight with mortal fear
 And dread, lest Theft, her child, amain
 Red-handed in the deed be ta'en.
 By this path seek then not to go,
 But find some other road, for lo!
 If you should persevere to choose
 This way, you all your wealth must lose,
 And have not served me so that I
 Should love you unreservedly.

**Richesse
 warns the
 Lover**

10690

The Lover speaks to Richesse.

Lady, I swear by God above
 That gladly would I win your love,
 And by your grace would fain essay
 Along your path to make my way,
 And rescue from his durance dire
 Fair-Welcome—grant my one desire.

10700

Richesse.

I understand, quoth she, that all
 Your store of wood both great and small
 You've sold not, but one stick kept back;
 'Tis well, and ne'er the world will lack
 Of folly till men rise above
 The thraldom known to fools as love,
 But each who in this madness lies,
 Deems himself natheless wondrous wise.

10710

The mad-
ness of
lovers

'Tis foolishness to call that life
Which is but fury, rage and strife.
Reason saw well your folly, but
To all her wisdom did you shut
Your ears, and madly you deceived
Yourself when nowise you believed
Her words. Before Dame Reason came,
No power could you from Love reclaim, 10720
And now, forsooth, you still despise
My words, since Love alone you prize.
From lovers gain I small esteem,
Meseemeth that alone they dream
Of scattering wide my goods, but whence
Can come the wealth that fools dispense,
When, slaves to Love, they play his game?
That rede you, in the devil's name!
But hence, and leave me here in peace.

The Lover.

I saw 'twere well my prayers to cease, 10730
And sadly thence betook my way.
But, though I went, with her did stay
Her friend arrayed in raiment rich.

I took a path, scarce noting which,
Across that close past all compare,
Filled with delights most heavenly fair,
The tale whereof ye erst have heard.
But now, alas! no more it stirred
Joy in my heart. I dreamed alone
What manner way might best be done 10740

That service whereto I was bound.
 Not of freewill would I be found
 False to my word and solemn oath,
 And, into crime so base, were loth
 To be betrayed. My heart was filled
 With thought of that my friend instilled
 Therein with so great care: That I
 By every mode and means should try
 To honour Evil-Tongue, nor swerve
 From his advice to please and serve
 My cruel foes.

The
 Lover's
 perplexi-
 ties

10750

Should I get aught
 Of thanks thereby? That knew I nought,
 Yet wist I not what else to do,
 Not daring to approach unto
 The enclosure, as I quickly should
 If I but wrought the thing I would.
 And thus, God knows, did I debate
 These doubts, with conscience desolate.
 For one course duty sternly bid,
 The while another thing I did,
 And so towards the course of right
 A traitor was I (though despite
 Of sore temptation up till now
 Had I been faithful), and did throw
 My lot with treason, seen I could
 No other way attain that good
 My being longed for—I who ne'er
 Ere this the cloak of leasings ware.

10760

LVII

With will to ease the Lover's grief
 Appeared to him his mighty chief, 10770
 The God of Love, who pardoned him
 That he awhile had deigned to trim
 His ear to Reason, and, quoth he,
 Unreason shalt thou henceforth be.

The
 Lover
 ques-
 tioned

WHEN Love thus clearly saw that I
 Preserved towards him my loyalty,
 (A loyalty not lightly worn,
 For by a solemn oath 'twas sworn),
 He came, smiled at my grief, and said,
 His soft hand laid upon my head : 10780
 Hast thou then followed my command ?
 And in what case dost thou now stand
 Towards that fair Rose that caused thy heart
 To writhe beneath love's bitter smart ?
 But of a truth all this he knew,
 For Gods divine whate'er men do.

Love speaks.

Quoth he : These hests I lay alone
 On faithful lovers, and on none
 Besides, hast thou all utterly
 Pursued them ? Frankly answer me. 10790

The Lover.

I know not, sire—but this I say,
 Ne'er wittingly I've gone astray.

Love.

Too fond art thou, forsooth, of change,
 And let'st thy heart too often range
 And waver, cursed with fickle doubt,
 I know thee throughly—in and out.
 The other day thou had'st the mind
 To quit my service, and unkind
 Complaints thou mad'st 'gainst Idleness,
 And blamed my yoke, and did'st confess 10800
 Thee doubtful if fair Hope might be
 Of good effect and aid to thee.
 Thou said'st 'twas but a foolish whim,
 That thou to my commands should'st trim
 Thy life, and homage paid to Reason :
 Was not then this foul act of treason ?

The folly
 of fickle-
 ness

The Lover.

Pardon ! great master, I the crime
 Confess, yet was I through the time
 Your bounden liege, and often good
 Assurance gave of trustihood, 10810
 As those should do who love thy rule.
 Reason but held me for a fool ;
 Nor failed she sorely to reprove
 My full surrender unto Love
 When held she converse with me, but
 With all her reasoning failed to cut
 The bond between us, though 'tis true
 She doubt inspired. But unto you
 I promise that no more mine ear
 I'll lend to her, should I be near 10820

Reason renounced When she her voice doth 'gainst you raise,
 Or lesser folk bestints of praise,
 For so entirely doth mine heart
 To you belong that nought shall part
 Our love, unless is torn away
 That heart from out my body—nay,
 I'm yours till death. 'Twas folly great,
 And grievous wrong 'gainst you, to prate
 With her, or list her futile speech,
 But your forgiveness I beseech ; 10830
 And whatsoe'er of penalty
 Account you well to lay on me
 I'll welcome, and will nevermore
 Listen to Reason, but your lore
 Shall be my guide for life and death ;
 In you I'll live so long as breath
 Remains to me, and nowise loss
 It were to me if Atropos
 Should cut life's thread while I engage
 In that sweet war that mortals wage 10840
 For Venus' sake, nought else doth bless
 Man's life with so great happiness.
 And those who for my death should weep,
 When thus they see me fallen to sleep
 So sweetly, might with reason cry :
 Oh well art thou thuswise to die !
 Thy death doth with that life agree,
 Thou liv'dst ere soul from flesh was free.

The God of Love speaks.

Now, by my head, thou speakest well,
 For, hearing thee, 'tis light to tell 10850

Love's
behests

That thou due homage dost to me ;
 No faithless wretch I find in thee
 Or caitiff, that would dare deny
 My service, having gained thereby
 All that he longed for. Sound and pure
 I find thy heart, therefore secure
 And safe thy vessel shalt thou bring
 To port. Thou hast full pardoning,
 Dear friend, straightway, by simple prayer,
 Of ransom free, for I will spare 10860
 Thy silver or thy gold to take,
 Nor even ask that thou should'st make
 Confession, but propose instead
 That we again take up the thread
 Of those sweet lessons that to thee
 I gave, and thou repeat to me
 The prohibitions and commands,
 In number ten, that at my hands
 Thou didst receive. If faithfully
 Thou keep'st them in thy memory, 10870
 One day thou'lt be in better case
 Than he who, dicing, casts deuce ace :
 Repeat them.

LVIII

Repeats, the Lover, word for word
 The lesson he from Cupid heard.

The Lover.

Gladly : Evil deed
 Must I forego ; no scandal speed ;

A lover's To aid and honour ladies ought
maxims To be through life my foremost thought ;
 Foul speech my lips should never soil ;
 For others' weal my strength should toil ; 10880
 Though scorning pride, tend well my dress,
 Behave with grace and gentleness ;
 With fair large heartedness to live,
 And to one love my heart to give.

Love.

I'faith, thou hast thy lesson got
 Right well, unstained by fault or blot.
 What sufferest thou ?

The Lover.

A grief so dread,
 That thereof is my heart nigh dead.

Love.

Hast thou not my three comforts ?

The Lover.

No ;

Soft-Looks, alas ! doth never show 10890
 His longed-for face, by which might be
 Assuaged my grief and misery.
 All three took flight, but two amain
 Returned, with will to ease my pain.

Love.

Is Hope not left to thee ?

The Lover.

Ah, yes !
She will not leave me comfortless,
For when within our hearts she makes
Her home, that home she ne'er forsakes.

Fair-
Welcome
must be
freed

Love.

Where is the Rose ?

The Lover.

Alas ! she's lost,
To Jealousy hath she been tost
For gold by Evil-Tongue, and nought
I see how rescue may be wrought.

10900

Love.

What of Fair-Welcome hath become ?

The Lover.

Alas ! beneath his prison dome
He weeps—my friend, whom loved I so.

Love.

Take heart, and let thy bosom glow
With hope, for by mine eyes I swear
That thou more joyously shalt fare
Than heretofore hath been thy lot.
Since thou so well my laws dost wot
And keep, I will my lieges call
To burst and break the prison wall
That holds Fair-Welcome ; soon shall he
Before thee stand, at liberty.

10910

LIX

Herein his barons, one and all,
 Doth Love to stalwart battle call
 By letter, which an envoy takes,
 Who no account of danger makes.

The **barons** **sum-** **moned** **T**HE God of Love, without or place
 Or time affixed where face to face 10920
 He'd meet his barons, letters sent
 Bidding them all to parliament;
 These he commanded, those besought,
 And all appeared, misdoubting nought,
 Ready to do whate'er they could
 To serve the end their liege lord would.
 I name them all pell-mell as I
 May rhyme them most commodiously.

Dame Idlesse first of all I name,
 Who with the largest banner came, 10930
 Then Noble-Heart, and Dame Richesse,
 Franchise, and Pity, and Largess,
 Bright Honour, Boldness, Courtesy,
 Sir Mirth and young Simplicity,
 And Glee, and Sport, and Youthfulness,
 And Joyousness, and Good-Success,
 And Gaiety, and quick Desire,
 And Beauty with her heart afire,
 Sweet Patience, and bold Confidence,
 Hide-Close, and Constrained-Abstinence, 10940
 Who near False-Seeming ever goes,
 And all his ways and wishes knows;
 And all of these their lieges brought,
 Joyous of face, of bearing haught.

Abstinence only and False-Seeming
 Looked evil, should I speak my deeming.
 Whatever air assumed those two,
 Fraud peeped from out their hearts untrue.

**False-
 Seeming
 appears**

False-Seeming was of Fraud the son,
 Hypocrisy begotten on, 10950
 That shameful traitress, foul and base,
 Who ever, 'neath Religion's face,
 Deceiveth men ; when she in view
 Appeared, his breath in gasps Love drew,

Love.

And cried : How now ! do I then dream ?
 Speak out, False-Seeming, dost thou deem
 That thou by me wert summoned here ?

The Lover.

Forced-Abstinence, who stood anear,
 Sprang forth, and seized her friend's right hand :

Constrained-Abstinence.

Quoth she, I pray you understand 10960
 That I, an't please you, hither led
 False-Seeming ; oft hath he bestead
 My need, and done me kindly act,
 Saving my life by hunger wracked.
 Let him among your lieges wait,
 Though each and all have earned his hate,
 For greatly I desire that he
 Win praise for worth and sanctity.
 He is my friend, and I his dear,
 As faithful comrades wend we here. 10970

LX

To all the host doth Love explain
 His purpose to assault and gain
 The castle, and Fair-Welcome free
 From out his bonds and slavery.

Love
 harangues
 his host

SO let it be, quoth Love ; and then
 He thus addressed his faithful men :

That we may Jealousy defeat,
 At whose fell hands our gallants meet
 Such cruel fate, I've summoned ye.
 'Tis her intention strenuously
 To hold the fort she dared to build,
 Which with distress my heart hath filled.
 A potent garrison therein
 Is set, and, ere we entry win,
 They'll fight with desperation rude,
 And great is my inquietude ;
 For there Fair-Welcome is immured,
 Whose loving kindness oft hath cured
 Our woes, and if he's rescued not
 From thence—oh, hard and evil lot !

10980

10990

Dead is Tibullus, who so well
 Knew me, that, when 'neath death he fell,
 My bow and arrows did I shiver
 In shards, and tare my goatskin quiver,
 While on his tomb my broken wings
 Fell heaped, as worn and worthless things,
 Shattered and spent, and through his death
 My gentle mother's fragrant breath

Love's
orators

Came nigh to ending. Not so great
 Her grief was at the cruel fate 11000
 Of her Adonis, when the boar
 His ivory thigh with death-wound tore.
 Nought then could comfort or assuage
 Her grief, yet fiercer did it rage
 When died Tibullus ; nought can stay
 Our tears, till time hath passed away.
 Catullus, Gallus, Ovid sweet,
 How perfectly they knew to treat
 Of Love's fair science, well bestead
 Were we of them—alas ! they're dead. 11010
 William of Lorris next regard,
 Who certainly must meet a hard
 And cruel fate through Jealousy,
 Did he not chance to find in me
 A saving hand. With loving heart
 Doth he sweet counselling impart
 To help our need, which is but right ;
 For he is mine, and I have dight
 For him the mote assembled here
 Of barons, who, despising fear, 11020
 Will save Fair-Welcome from the
 snare
 He lieth in : he doth declare
 Himself all powerless, but 'twould be
 Disgrace and injury to me
 To lose a liegeman who hath served
 Me loyally, nor ever swerved
 From duty's path. To him I owe
 Right worthy recompense, and so
 Have now invoked your mighty power
 To ruin and lay low the tower. 11030

Of Jean de Meun E'en yet will he promote my cause,
For, to deserve my grace, Love's laws
He in that fair Romance shall write,
Which he begins, and shall indite
The tale so far, before his death,
As where he to Fair-Welcome saith :
(Who, languishing, doth wear through time
In prison, though unstained by crime)
"Hear me confess that darkest fear
Invades me lest it should appear
That you forget me quite ; what woe
Untold would fall on me to know
That I had lost your friendship, then
Were I unhappiest of men. . . ."
Behold we William here expire :
Upon his tomb may sacred fire
Burn aloes, cinnamon, and myrrh,
In honour of my worshipper.

Then shall appear John Clopinel,
Joyous of heart, of body well 11050
And fairly built: at Meun shall he
Be born where Loire flows peacefully,
Who, whether he keepeth feast or fast,
Will never while his life-days last
Forget my service, but without
Envy or avarice go about
To honour me, untouched by care
How he at Reason's hands may fare,
Who all my precious balms doth scorn,
Which salve sad hearts with love o'erworn. 11060
And if it happen that he make
Some error, failure, or mistake,

(For no man woman-born may win
His way to heaven unscathed by sin)
Towards me his heart shall be so true
That, in the end, whate'er he do,
With tearful eyes and head low bent,
Sorely will he his crime repent,
And vow henceforth to keep him clear.

This fair Romance he'll hold so dear, 11070
That to its ending will he trace
The tale, God give him time and place.
When death shall snatch Dan William, then
Dan John in hand shall take the pen
When forty years are passed, and say :
(O'ercome with grief to think he may
Fair-Welcome's help and comfort lose,
Prisoned by Jealousy's vile ruse)
" If he no more may bless my sight,
O'er me will fall despair's black night ! " 11080
And every other word that he
Hath wisely said or foolishly,
Repeat, until he shall have gained
The Rose from its fair stem and fained
His heart thereby, and once more day
May dawn, and dreaming pass away ;
And every point will make so sure
And clear, that nought remains obscure.

Doubt not, if in their power it lay,
These both would lend their aid this day. 11090
But while of one the life is worn,
The other hath not yet been born,
And therefore cannot help our cause,
Or set before the world my laws ;

Love's tender care But of such moment are these things,
 That well behoves it that my wings
 I spread so soon as he the light
 Beholds, and let him hear aright
 Our judgment, else I warrant you
 That ne'er the work he'll carry through. 11100
 And lest it happed, as well might be,
 By unforeseen calamity,
 That this good Clopinel, whose birth
 We look for, ne'er should tread the
 earth,
 It were irreparable loss
 To lovers that thus fate should cross
 A man whose keen and worthy wit
 Should do their cause such benefit.
 I therefore dame Lucina prayed,
 Goddess of birth, to give her aid, 11110
 That to the world he safe might come,
 And long therein find hearth and home;
 And whensoever he weaned shall be,
 Then Jupiter, most tenderly,
 Shall take him up and give to him
 A draught from out his tuns, which brim
 With virtue twofold, this one bright,
 That, turbid, thick, and black as night;
 This one right pleasant, soft and sweet,
 That, bitter as soot or waves that beat 11120
 The ocean shore; and when in cot
 He lies, it then shall be his lot
 That I enshroud him 'neath my wings,
 And teach him such sweet carollings,
 That even in his early youth,
 With my soft science filled, forsooth,

Our songs in hall and market-place
 Shall he chant forth with tuneful grace,
 Couched in the tongue men use in
 France,

**Jealousy
 shall be
 overcome**

And all the world therewith entrance. 11180

And those who list him willingly,
 Of Love's soft woes shall never die ;
 For if they do but read aright
 The precious book his pen shall dight,
 They may therein find plainly writ
 All Love's commands, and draw from it
 Such counsels, that it well may pass
 Henceforward as the looking-glass
 For lovers, but therein no part
 Shall bear dull Reason's caitiff heart. 11140

Therefore it is of you I ask
 Good counselling to ease my task,
 Beseeching you, palm joined to palm,
 To pour on William Lorris balm
 Of comfort in his loneliness,
 Since well did he my faith confess ;
 And if for him I made no prayer,
 Yet would I ask that John might share
 Your powerful aid, that he may be
 A wise, true servant unto me. 11150

That he'll be born I dare avow
 As prophet ; and moreover now
 Pray ye for future lovers, who
 Shall learn my full commandments through
 His lore, and that by them may be
 O'ercome all-hateful Jealousy,
 And every fort she dares to raise
 They may to bare foundations raze.

Richesse Give me your counsel then, and say
despises At which points were it best to lay 11160
love The siege, that we may quickly crown
 Our work, and beat the stronghold down.

The Author.

Thus spake the God of Love ; right well
 The lords approved his words, and fell
 Straightway to counsel and debate,
 With reasoning most elaborate,
 And many a diverse word is said
 Ere yet the arguments are sped,
 And all their discords they accord ;
 Then bending low before their lord, 11170

The Barons.

Sire, they exclaimed, we all agree
 Your faithful servitors to be,
 Save Richesse, who thereto is loth,
 And sweareth by a solemn oath
 That ne'er will she attack the fort
 In any manner, way, or sort,
 With engine, axe, winged dart or sword,
 Or other arm of thrust and ward,
 But saith that all your emprise she
 Scorns and despises utterly. 11180
 Therefore in dudgeon is she gone
 From out the host till this be done,
 So much doth she the Lover hate:
 Declaring he nor rathe nor late
 Hath loved her, but her treasured gold
 Despiseth, and but cheap doth hold.

Behold the crime that he hath wrought,
 And thus her mortal hatred bought.
 She saith, the day ere yesterday
 He sought to pass along the way
 Which Too-Great-Giving is yclept,
 But, seeing he was poor, she kept
 The path against him: seen that he
 Ne'er strove to win the mastery
 Of one poor wretched penny piece
 Whereby his having to increase—
 So spake Richesse, therefore without
 Her help at once we'll set about
 Your high behest.

**Plan of
 attack**

11190

Our plan is, hence
 False-Seeming and Forced-Abstinence
 To send, with all of those who fight
 Beneath their flag, that they their might
 May spend against the postern door
 Which Evil-Tongue with many a score
 Of Normans keeps (may hell-fire burn
 These runagates), and then may earn
 Largess and Courtesy great praise
 If 'gainst the hag they take their ways,
 Who on Fair-Welcome's head doth pile
 Unheard-of woes and insults vile.

11200

11210

And then Sir Hide-Well and Delight
 Shall lightly put weak Shame to flight,
 When they their host, against her gate,
 Lead on with cries importunate.
 Surety and Courage with their train
 'Gainst trembling Fear shall march amain,
 Who never yet have known defeat;
 And Pity shall with Franchise meet

Venus' In arms 'gainst Danger. Surely then
help The fort must yield to suchlike men 11220
needed Banded together, if but they
 Their strength and valiancy display.

Above all else right well it were
 Your mother Venus should be there,
 Who understandeth better far
 Than many another how Love's war
 Is wrought and won. Without her aid
 Some error lightly might be made
 In word or deed. Let thy command
 Ensure to us her mighty hand. 11230

Love.

Venus, great lords, whom I confess
 As mother, lady, and mistress,
 I may not at my pleasure bend
 To serve my will. Yet oft-times wend
 Will she to succour me when I
 Beseech her powerful ministry,
 Fearing the while to ask too much.
 She is my mother, and as such,
 E'en from my childhood's days, a sense
 I feel of humble reverence 11240
 Towards her, for if sons no fear
 Have of their parents, they but rear
 A baleful seed-crop. Natheless we
 May ask her aid if need should be,
 And e'en though far away, she'd speed
 Hither hot-foot, nor hindrance heed.

My mother is of high renown,
 And many a fortress hath cast down
 That cost a thousand bezants, though
 Within the precincts ne'er did go
 My footsteps; often men declare
 Some conquest mine, when I no share
 Or part have had therein—no doit
 I love or value such exploit.
 Such victories in my ears but ring
 Of merchandise and bargaining.

Love not
 to be
 bought

11250

Who for a hundred pounds doth buy
 A steed, and pays it presently,
 Is of the bargain free and quit,
 As he likewise who sold him it.
 A bargain is apart from love,
 And none should guerdon seek above
 A price agreed that is to be—
 That paid, the bargainers are free.

11260

Love bought and sold is worse affair;
 For when a man his horse with care
 Hath stabled, he can sell again
 His purchase, maybe at a gain,
 If so he will, nor doth he lose
 Wholly the price, for he can use
 The skin for leather, and therefrom
 Recover somewhat of the sum
 He paid. Or if he hold it dear,
 Mount it he may, as cavalier,
 Full master of the steed is he.
 But far worse the affair must be

11270

Venus is When Venus doth a bargain make,
not mer- For, whatsoever care he take,
cenary A man may never get what's sold,
 Yet lose past all return his gold, 11280
 For tightly may the vendor keep
 The wares, and then no price were cheap,
 Nay, e'en though all he had one set
 Thereon, he might no guerdon get ;
 Whate'er he did, whate'er he said,
 It nowise could be hinderèd,
 But what the very first who can
 (Roman, Breton, or Englishman)
 Open the purse more widely may,
 The thing you paid for bear away, 11290
 Or e'en obtain it as a gift,
 If he but knows his voice to lift
 In flattering words. Account ye wise
 Merchants who deal in suchlike guise ?
 Nay, but mere fools and caitiffs they,
 Who bargains make in such a way
 That for their outlay nought remain
 Of pleasure, benefit, or gain,
 Whate'er the cost.

'Tis true that she
 Who gave me birth not usually 11800
 Dispenseth gold, for hath she more
 Of wit than thus to waste her store,
 But know ye well, that man shall yet
 Pay her, who doth his gold regret,
 When Poverty in dire distress
 Doth hold him, though of Dame Richesse
 Fast friend were he, who, when I will,
 Loseth her power to work me ill.

Love's
oath

But hear me by Saint Venus swear,
 And Saturn who engendered her, 11810
 Not through his wife, but in her sweet
 And perfect beauteousness complete.
 But yet a stronger oath I swear,
 To clench more firmly the affair.
 I swear by all the faith I owe
 My brothers, though no man doth know
 Who were their sires (for many have dared
 Avow my mother's couch they shared),
 I swear by Styx, hell's river black ;
 And if my words plain truth should lack, 11820
 May I, until a year flits o'er,
 Of luscious piment drink no more ;
 (For by the Gods it is ordained
 That no one who his lips hath stained
 With falsehood, through a year drinks wine,)
 I've sworn enough, as I opine ;
 If false, may I accursèd be,
 But I'll commit no perjury.

Dame Richesse doth desert us ! hey !
 But thereof shall she smartly pay, 11830
 Yea, dear enough, unless she arm
 Herself with sword, or piked guisarme.
 And since for me she doth not burn
 With love, whene'er I overturn
 The castle and the tower accurst,
 An evil dawn shall on her burst.
 And if some wealthy carle I net,
 I'll squeeze and twist him till I get
 Each golden mark from out his purse,
 And drain it to its very source, 11840

Poor men Till no more deniers can he show,
 true Unless within his barns they grow;
 lovers His plumes our maids will so pluck out,
 That bare he'll walk till new ones sprout,
 And make him sell his lands, unless
 He drive them off with fearlessness.

Poor men have made of me their lord,
 And though they oft can scarce afford
 To pasture me, I scorn them not,
 Nor do good men do so, I wot. 11350
 Towards them is Richesse hard and rude,
 With selfish love alone imbued;
 But poor men truer lovers are
 Than rich, whose wealth doth but debar
 True love, and, by my father's soul,
 Better is loyalty than dole.
 Ever on me their thought is spent,
 And thereof is my heart content,
 And they so doing, oft mine eye
 Looks on their service kindly; 11360
 And if instead of God of Love
 God Plutus were I, then above
 Their hopes I'd give poor lovers all
 Great wealth, for in mine ear their call
 And plaint resounds, and specially
 That of one faithful unto me;
 For if he died for love, small then
 Were Love esteemed 'mong mortal men.

The Barons of the Host.

Great sir, the Barons cried, we find
 Your speech wise, bountiful, and kind; 11370

Rich men
befooled

Well may you keep the solemn vow
 You made against rich men but now :
 We deem it nought but right and just.
 And e'en if rich men put their trust
 In you, and bow them 'neath your rules
 And laws, they will but prove them fools.
 Great lord, you shall in nowise break
 Your solemn oath, nor cease to take
 With others of the host divine
 Your wonted draughts of piment wine. 11880
 And ladies shall for rich men brew
 Such well-spiced drink, both sweet and new,
 If they within their nets but fall,
 That thence they ne'er shall 'scape at all:
 So courteously their work they'll do,
 That you need nowise trouble you.
 To triumph o'er them spare your care,
 The ladies so will speak them fair,
 That they will do your work although
 Anigh them you forbear to go. 11890
 Discourse will they right pleasant tales,
 And fool them till the daylight fails
 With many a gentle coo and bill,
 And secret clip and kiss, and fill
 The time up so with blandishments,
 That they shall work their full intents
 Upon them, and delude them so,
 That they of goods and lands shall go
 Naked as needles. Speak forth then,
 And, whether right or wrong, your men 11400
 Will your behests obey.

Great fear
 False-Seeming hath to come anear,

**False-
Seeming
accepted** And mix him in this great emprise,
For much he fears that you despise
And hate him.

We beseech, O sire,
That you abate some deal your ire,
And give consent that he may be
Accounted of the barony,
With Abstinence, his loving friend.

Love.

Thereto, quoth Love, my will I bend, 11410
Henceforth shall he be called my man,
Let him approach.

The Author.

He thither ran.

LXI

Herein the God of Love retains
False-Seeming as his man, and gains
Applause thereby, the host doth ring
With shouts to crown him Ribalds' King.

'TIS thus agreed, False-Seeming then,
That thou should'st join my loyal men,
To give our friends thy powerful aid,
And guard them lest they be betrayed. 11420
'Tis thine, so far as in thee lies,
To help them, and their enemies
To grieve and injure, thou shalt be
The King of Ribalds under me ;

'Tis thus our chapter hath decreed.
 Most surely thou in thought and deed
 Art but a rogue, a common thief,
 A villain almost past belief,
 A hundred thousand times forsworn,
 Held of all honest men in scorn ;
 Speak out I charge thee, have no fear,
 Make all thy ways and doings clear,
 And let the assembly know amain
 Where they may find thee, since they fain
 Would learn thy woning : say also
 What sign there is by which to know
 Where thou may'st commonly be found.

False-
 Seem-
 ing's de-
 claration

11480

False-Seeming.

In truth, great lord, I shift my ground
 So often that 'tis hard to say
 Where 'tis I dwell from day to day,
 And should I all my mansions name,
 Alack ! it would but bring me shame,
 For if my vile companions knew
 That I had told this thing to you,
 Good lord ! on my devoted head
 A thousand cruelties were sped.
 Their wickedness I know too well,
 And how they'd treat me should I tell
 The truth, which hate they of all things ;
 And grievous pains and sufferings
 Were put upon me, dared I say
 One word about their evil way
 Of life, or had the hardihood
 To speak of them aught else but good,

11440

11450

~~False-~~ For that 'tis wounds them to the quick,
~~Seem-~~ Excites their anger, and doth prick
~~ing's~~ Them on to vengeance.
~~fears~~

If they heard
 Their condemnation through the word
 Of holy Scripture, I'll engage
 'Twould rouse them into furious rage, 11460
 For mad are they in their despite,
 With bitter wrath and venom dight.
 And well I ken that should I bring
 Before you the most trifling thing,
 How close soe'er your court may be,
 These men would know it presently.
 But among good men none would take
 To heart whatever words I spake
 As touching them ; for if one took
 My words in evil part, 'twould look 11470
 As though his life must mingled be
 With Falsehood and Hypocrisy,
 Who gave me life and nourriture.

Love.

A fair performance to be sure,
 Cried Love, their work was on a level
 With that of nurturing the devil.
 But howsoe'er that be, straightway
 'Tis needful thou before us lay,
 Without a lie, where thou dost dwell,
 And also thou at full may'st tell 11480
 Thy way of life with nimble tongue ;
 The mischief wrought since thou wert young
 Discover, nor thy evil work,
 Now thou art with us, seek to shirk.

And if perchance it comes about
That thou receivest cuff and clout
To recompense thy deeds accurst,
I doubt they scarce will be the first.

**False-
Seem-
ing's con-
fession**

False-Seeming.

Great lord, if 'twere your pleasure I
Should shortly be condemned to die, 11490
I'd calmly lay my head upon
The block and cry: 'Tis rightly done.

The Author.

False-Seeming then delayed no more,
But, standing forth, thus spake before
The great assembly:

False-Seeming.

All and each
Of ye, O barons, list my speech:
Whoso False-Seeming would behold,
Must seek him in the cloistered fold
As much as in the open street,
And trow I ye will scarcely meet 11500
With me elsewhere, but far above
The world the convent hath my love.
In short, I much prefer to be
Where I may work most secretly;
And 'neath a simple vesture find
That I most readily may blind
Men's eyes, more secret is the way
Of holy cloister folk than lay.

Monks
good and
bad

But think ye not I would defame
Religion, or its votaries blame,
For nought it matters what they wear
By way of habit, I will spare
All faithful ones, but fain confess
I do not love them ne'ertheless.

11510

I speak of worthless monks and nuns,
Felonious and malicious ones,
Who care alone for holy dress,
And clothe their hearts with wickedness.
Good cloisterers are with pity fraught
And kindliness, and harbour nought
Of evil, far from them is pride,
And love they humbly to abide
In peace. If I with these should stay,
My cue it were false cards to play.
Their habits well could I assume,
But 'neath them should but fret and fume,
And sooner hang would than forego
My ends, whate'er my outward show.

11520

I live with rascals puffed with pride,
From out whose hearts, 'twould seem, hath
died
All virtue; schemers, whose desire
Before all else is to acquire
Honour and wrath, and therefore set
Themselves to plot how they may get
Great folks' acquaintance; men who make
Themselves bare paupers for the sake
Of Christ, and yet good meat and drink
Will pasture on, and love the chink

11530

Religious
pretenders

Of gold, and, preaching that they wish
For poverty alone, still fish 11540
With trammel-net and wide-spread seine,
In hope great worldly wealth to gain.
Religious are they not, nor good,
Yet have the shameless hardihood,
Whene'er they preach, to boldly say,
That wearing holy habits they
Must needs be holy. By my life
Their claim's not worth a wooden knife ;
That "not by robe the monk is made,"
None but a fool hath e'er gainsaid. 11550
And none to this can make reply
Although his head were shaven high
By hand of Fraud, who cuts thirteen
Thereto had given with razor keen.
But hereof dare no man discuss,
To speak one word is perilous,
For truth they turn the nether way.
And therefore in their nests I lay
My eggs, as often may be seen 11560
By those who closely look therein.
Know ye that wheresoe'er I go,
And whatso sort of face I show,
I purpose some ill deed, and that,
Even as Master Tybert cat
Of nought else dreams but rats and
mice,
So do I find my paradise
In lying, robbery, and wrong.
And though but few among the throng
Of men detect me through my dress,
Nor pierce beneath my gentleness 11570

Where Of speech, they by my works may see
 dwells My heart, unless they blinded be.
 religion? For those who do not as they say
 Deceive you howsoever they
 Array them, or whatever state
 Of life they keep, or small or great,
 Cleric or layman, squire or dame,
 Lady or quean, 'tis aye the same.

The Author.

When thus far had Fair-Seeming spoken
 His pattering by the God was broken, 11580
 Who cried aloud: (to stay his speech,
 Which seemed but vice and fraud to teach)

The God of Love.

Who art thou, shameless imp of hell?
 How dar'st thou of such miscreants tell?
 Deem'st thou religion we may find
 Where vows no monks nor friars bind?

False-Seeming.

Most surely, sire! it needeth not
 A man with sin his life should blot,
 And lose his soul in hell-fire's flare
 Because he mundane clothes doth wear; 11590
 That were a sentence hard indeed.
 Well may, beneath gay-tinted weed,
 Holy religion thrive. We've seen
 A troop of holy saints, I ween,

Saints
among
lay folk.

Women and men alike, who ne'er
Aught else but worldly garments ware,
Yet none the less were canonized;
Nay, 'twere the other way devised,
For many a saint to whom we pray,
Within the church or by the way, 11600
Fair virgins chaste, or matrons mild,
Mothers of many an angel child,
Through life in worldly clothes did hide
Their bodies and within them died,
Yet saints were they, and aye shall be.
Was not that blessed company
Of virgins who now tapers hold
Before the throne of God (all told
Eleven thousand) habited
In lay folks' robes? yet honoured 11610
Are they in every church no less
Because they lacked of convent dress.
In holy heart wakes holy thought,
Through vesture 'tis nor marred nor
wrought,
And worthy thought gives birth to deed
Of worth, for 'tis thereof the seed.

Thus of religion have I given
The pith, as 'tis ordained by heaven.

If in the fleece of Bellin ram
Sir Isegrym had made a sham 11620
To clothe him, and had gone to feed
Among the sheep in that false weed,
Suppose you he would therefore keep
From greedy ravin of the sheep?

The Church in peril I trow not, but beneath the skin
 He wore he'd suck their life-blood in
 By no means with less appetite
 Or less enjoyment and delight
 That he'd deceived them, and that they
 Still followed where he chose to stray. 11630
 Believe me, wolves no meagre few
 There are 'mong these apostles new :
 Ah ! holy Church, thou wilt be sacked
 If thus thy city be attacked
 By soldiers of thine own domain.
 Alas ! thy power is on the wane,
 For those but seek to spoil thee who
 Thou hast thy safety trusted to.
 Who is there that will guarantee
 Thee 'gainst them ? Thou wilt taken be, 11640
 Although no stroke of trepeget
 Or mangonel thou feel'st, nor yet
 Set'st banner to the wind. If thou
 No help afford, O then, I trow,
 Nought else there is but let them be.
 Though now they subject stand to thee,
 Ere long must thou before them bend
 As tributary, and descend
 To make thy peace in such a way
 As they demand, who straight will lay 11650
 Great burdens on thee, if forsooth
 The traitors, all devoid of ruth,
 Master thee not. With craft will they
 Lull thee to sleep, and while by day
 They haste to man thy walls, by night
 Deep mines their treacherous hands will
 digt.

Bethink thee otherwhere to root
The grafts to which thou look'st for
fruit.

Fraud all-
powerful

Delay thou not, but act amain—
I've said—my mouth will I refrain
From further speech thereon, lest some
My words with weariness o'ercome.

11660

My promise readily I give
From henceforth with your friends to live
In peaceful wise, if they agree
Thereto, or else I warrant me
They'll meet grim death.

They must receive

My leman too would they achieve
Their end. I am with justice named
A traitor, and have been proclaimed
By Love as common thief. Forsworn
Am I, but till mine end is worn
No man perceives it. Oft my blow
Is dealt, yet nought thereof men know ;
And should one be of it aware,
Unless he too seeks death, will spare
Resentment. Treachery is so strong,
That all the world condones its wrong.
Proteus himself, who changed his shape
Whene'er he pleased, for guile or jape,
Was less adept at fraud than I.

11670

So great is my dexterity,
That though within some town I've been
A thousand times, but little ween
The folk who meet me unaware
That oft before I've entered there.

11680

LXII

Learn how False-Seeming, traitor vile,
 Men's hearts doth readily beguile,
 When grey and black he clothes him in,
 With saintly visage pale and thin.

11690

False-
 Seem-
 ing's dis-
 guises

DISGUISES well I know to don,
 Now this one off, now that one on,
 Now knight am I, and now a monk,
 A prelate, then to canon shrunk
 Or simple clerk, or priest at mass,
 And next as master do I pass,
 Disciple, captain, forester,
 In short, whatever I prefer ;
 Sometimes a prince, sometimes a page,
 And every language I engage
 To patter ; sometimes old and grey,
 At others sprightly, young and gay,
 And now *Robert* and now *Robin*,
 Now friar, now a jacobin.

11700

I show me, company to keep
 With her from whom I joyance reap,
 (She hight *Constrained-Abstinence*)
 'Neath many a guilement and pretence,
 Her fickle fancies to fulfil,
 And work her every wish and will.
 Sometimes a woman's robe I wear,
 As matron staid or damsel fair,
 And oft assume religious dress,
 As anchorite or prioress,

11710

Friars
free of
bishops

An abbess who with life hath done,
 Or novice who would fain be nun.
 As through the world I walk about,
 I turn each credence inside out;
 And whatsoe'er may be their law,
 I take the grain and leave the straw; 11720
 For I but live to cozen folk,
 And laugh at all beneath my cloak.
 What more to tell? In suchlike way
 As serves me best I play my play.
 My mode I change unendingly;
 And ne'er my words and deeds agree,
 But through my privileges snare
 Full many a man all unaware.
 Good shrift I give when I confess
 (Laughing at prelates' helplessness) 11730
 All sinners whom I hap to meet;
 No prelate dare my work defeat,
 Saving our lord the Pope alone,
 From whom this privilege was won
 For our most holy brotherhood.
 Whatever prelate hath withstood
 Or dared to speak against my men,
 I soon have closed his mouth again.
 But out, alas! the people now
 Too well my ways and manners trow, 11740
 And nought am I received so well,
 Since ugly tales of me men tell.
 But what care I? I'm none the worse,
 With silver have I stored my purse
 And goods have heaped; so well I've
 striven,
 That foolish folk have freely given

Privileged confessors Abundance, and I lead my life
 In ease, all undisturbed by strife,
 Thanks to the easy prelates who
 Fear to say aught whate'er I do.
 Not one of them dares make essay
 Against me, or he'd roundly pay.
 And thus I live as pleaseth me
 By fraud, deceit, and trickery.

11750

Though all should once a year at least
 Confession make before a priest,
 As Scripture saith, that they may have
 A houseling good their souls to save,
 (For this our lord the Pope decrees)
 We shelve the statute as we please.
 To penitents we give advice,
 But claim exemptions which suffice,
 For many a privilege have we,
 Which cause our burdens light to be.
 On this point we nought silent are,
 But vaunt our dispensations far
 Beyond the Pope's decree ; so may
 Unto his priest each sinner say :

11760

Father, I lately have confessed
 To such an one, and he my breast
 Hath clean absolved from every sin
 That might the wrath of heaven win,
 My conscience suffers no such pain
 As pricks me to confess again.
 Herein, I pray you, make me quit,
 Nor further hold discourse of it,

11770

No matter what you say thereof,
 And you may spare to scold and scoff;
 For though a thousand oaths you swore,
 Prelate or curate now no more
 I fear; my will would you constrain,
 There's one to whom I can complain
 Forthwith, you cannot make me twin
 Confession, for new shrift of sin,
 The first doth well enough for me,
 A second would but wasted be.
 For one whose powers are full and
 wide

Indepen-
 dence of
 friars

11780

Hath all my bonds of sin untied :
 And so I warn you once again,
 That if you would my will constrain,
 I know of one will right my cause,
 Holding me free of kings and laws
 And provosts, for among them all,
 Though royal or imperial,
 Not one dare 'gainst me judgment give,
 Exempted from their rule I live.
 To my new father should I go,
 (No cubling he who hight Louveteau,)
 But friar Wolf, who doth devour
 Whate'er he will, nor can his power
 By aught be stayed or hindered, but
 If I complain, your mouth he'll shut.
 If he should catch you in his net,
 Thereout not lightly will you get
 Without disgrace and shame, unless
 He shows unwonted gentleness.
 He's not so foolish, weak or dull,
 But he can get from Rome a bull

11790

11800

Power of If so he will, and forthwith cite
friars. You 'fore the court in dread despite, 11810
 And ruin you in two short days.
 And he possesseth briefs, he says,
 Much stricter and more strong by far
 Than any common parchments are,
 Which have no power at all to touch
 More than eight persons, while his, much
 More wide and full in their intent,
 May pass when law itself is spent :
 And for your rights nought careth he,
 From law he hath immunity. 11820
 Thus all his power he'll put in force,
 Nor deign to stay or change his course
 For prayers or tears, nor any kind
 Of gift, his coffers well are lined.
 For seneschal, Sir Schemer he
 Hath got, who gathers wondrously,
 And Sir Solicitor, his brother,
 These two will outvie many another
 In piling wealth, and 'twixt the pair
 Their hoard might buy St. Peter's chair. 11830
 Now help me God and good St. James,
 If you deny my lawful claims
 (When spring toward Easter-tide hath trod)
 To have the holy body of God,
 I shall not grieve thereat, but go
 To that good man who well I know
 Will give it me, and vainly spent
 On me were threats of punishment.

Thuswise may every carl confess
 Whereso it suits his wilfulness; 11840

Friars
love
wealth

And if the priest refuse his rights,
My hand his stubbornness requites,
And soon he finds him in the lurch,
With loss of honour, goods, and church.
Whither do such confessions tend?
And who shall know the bitter end?
In suchlike case no priest can e'er
Know aught of his parishioner,
Whose soul should be his constant cure.
At nought such practice sets the pure 11850
And holy Scripture, which doth teach
Pastors to know the voice of each
Sheep of their flock. But willingly
I leave both priests and prelates free
Poor men and women to confess,
Who for most part are penniless;
But little guerdon thence were got.

The God of Love.

Why so?

False-Seeming.

Because they have it not;
Poor needy, caitiff creatures they.
The good fat sheep I bear away, 11860
And to the pastors leave the poor
Lean hungry ones, who growl therefor.
And if the prelates dare to scold,
Who in their hearts dire anger hold,
For loss of many a good fat beast
Whereon they hoped long time to feast,
I'll give them such a mortal bruise
That cross and mitre both they'll lose.

**Hypoc- Full many I make peccavi cry,
risky ram- Such mighty privilege have I.
pant**

11870

The Author.

False-Seeming here some rest would take,
But Love desires him not to break
His tale, the which he feigns to heed
With pleasure, and asks further rede.

The God of Love.

I pray thee that thou tell to me,
All shame aside, explicitly,
The varied games that thou hast played,
What tricks hast done, what mischief made.
Thy robe declares an anchorite.

False-Seeming.

That's true, but I'm a hypocrite.

11880

The God of Love.

Thou preacheest holy abstinence.

False-Seeming.

Past doubt ; but though I make pretence,
Good dishes love I, and bright wine,
As well as any grave divine.

Love.

Thou preacheest poverty also.

False-Seeming.

Wealth
before
poverty

Yes, but my bags with coin o'erflow ;
 And though I poverty pretend,
 I make of no poor man a friend.
 A hundred thousand times should I
 Prefer our good king's company. 11890
 Yea, by our Lady ! though it happed
 The poor man was with virtue capped
 In fairest wise, for when I see
 These beggars shiver wretchedly
 On dunghills, hungry, cold, and bare,
 What then ?—'tis none of my affair.
 Or if unto the Hotel-Dieu
 They're carried, what ! should I pursue
 Them thither ? ne'er with one poor groat
 They've fed my parched and hungry throat. 11900
 What can be got from one who licks
 His knife, and sounds eats, dry as sticks ?
 That man an idiot may be said
 Who fat seeks in a black dog's bed.

To visit I should much prefer
 Some sick but wealthy usurer :
 With patience would I comfort him,
 In hope some deniers to benimme,
 And when pale death steals o'er his face,
 Transport him to the burial-place. 11910
 Should some reproach me that I take
 Heed to rich men and poor forsake,
 How think you that I make reply ?
 I let a tear bedim mine eye,
 And say : Alas ! I greatly fear
 From sin the rich are far less clear

The Than are the poor, and so much more
 praise of Their souls have need of watching o'er.
 suffi- Yet true it is dire poverty
 ciency Draws men to sin as much, pardee, 11920
 As too great wealth; they both man's
 soul

Distain, and hinder from its goal.
 For Poverty and Riches are
 The two extremes, and better far
 Is plain sufficiency; between
 The two is most of virtue seen.
 And hath not wise King Solomon
 This matter well discoursed upon
 Within his book of Proverbs? it
 We find in chapter thirty writ: 11930

God in thy mercy give to me
 Nor riches nor yet poverty!
 For whensoever a man doth wrap
 His soul in wealth, 'twill surely sap
 His virtue, till at last the debt
 He owes his Maker he'll forget.
 And who with Poverty doth fight,
 How shall he keep his soul aright?

Alas! perforce he comes to be
 Befouled with theft and perjury, 11940
 Or God doth lie, for he hath said,
 By Solomon, they both are wed
 To Poverty. And dare I swear,
 Free of reproach, that no man e'er
 Hath found in any sacred book
 (At least 'twere vain in ours to look)
 That Christ and his apostles dear
 The while on earth they wandered here,

Went begging bread from door to door ;		All men
Nor they alone this thing forbore,	11950	should
But straight forbade it, (thus 'twas taught		work
By those of Paris, doctors fraught		
With learning in divinity)		
Though well might they excused be		
Of begging, even though they should		
Ask alms for daily livelihood,		
Seeing that they true shepherds were		
To many a soul beneath their care.		
And when their Lord was crucified,		
Again industriously they tried	11960	
To win their needs by labour true		
Of each man's hands ; and after due		
And needful sustenance they'd ta'en,		
Unto the poor they gave amain		
Of their abundance. Mansions they		
Reared not, but dwelt in cots of clay.		

It well behoves each able man	
That he with work quotidian	
By might of arm should gain his bread	
(Unless he be by wealth bestead,)	11970
Though of religion he be fain,	
For God accounts no good work vain.	
This rule it is which binds men all,	
Save in some cases I recall,	
The which will I relate whene'er	
Time serves, and you have will to hear.	
Yet more, a man should sell his good,	
And labour for a livelihood	
If he, forsooth, would perfect be ;	
This hath the Scripture taught to me.	11980

Mendi- But one who idly haunts the board
cancy un- Of other men will God reward.
lawful Censured should be such men as dare
 Labour forego on plea of prayer.
 Justly a man may put aside
 God's worship, striving to provide
 By honest work for daily need,
 For of a truth all men must feed
 And clothe themselves, and while they keep
 Vigil of labour, prayer may sleep. 11990
 And thus 'tis lawful that we shirk
 The hours of prayer, the while we work,
 And this with Scripture doth agree,
 Which teacheth nought but verity.

And likewise great Justinian did
 Within his ancient code forbid
 That one of able body should
 Seek alms by way of livelihood,
 Since his strong arm his bread should gain.
 'Twere well stout rogues to treat again 12000
 With flogging, or to swing them high,
 Rather than aid their knavery.
 That man neglects his duty who
 Seeketh to gain subsistence through
 Men's alms, unless he can allege
 Some special grant or privilege;
 But doubt I much if legally
 A man thus privileged could be,
 Unless some cozenage he bring
 To help him, and deceive the king 12010
 All unawares. Yet no design
 Have I against the right divine

Saint
Paul's in-
junction

Of kings, nor dare to rashly say
That they may not extend their sway
Whereso they will ; but in the law
Methinks 'twould be a grievous flaw
Should it permit that doles and alms,
Which should but reach the trembling
palms

Of those who cannot earn their bread
Through sickness, age, or dreariness, 12020
Were snatched away from them by might
And power of those who trample right ;
Surely for them were hell made hot,
If Adam's Maker lieth not.

But God's commandment, mind ye well,
It is a righteous man should sell
His goods, and therewith help the poor,
But this command oped not the door
To mendicancy, that was not
His meaning, as right well we wot, 12030
But that each man his hand should trim
To work while meekly following him.

To his disciples gave Saint Paul
Injunction strict that one and all
Should labour with their hands, nor be
Disgraced by base mendicity,
Saying : To labour set ye then,
Nor ask an alms of other men ;
And greatly feared he lest some sold
The gospel through the lust of gold. 12040

And if a man to give doth choose
Because he dareth not refuse
Another's asking, pricked with shame,
Or fearing lest he get the name

Saint Of niggard, or forsooth, doth give,
 Paul Only that he in peace may live ;
 laboured Although his worldly goods he lose,
 No profit from such alms ensues.
 When worthy men to hear St. Paul
 Flocked round, they offered him their all 12050
 For love of God ; but he straightway
 Refused, nor deigned his hands to stay
 From useful work, whereby he gained
 So much as all his need sustained.

Love.

But say then, in what way can live
 A strong man who desires to give
 Himself to God when he hath sold
 His goods, as in the gospel told,
 And made all over to the poor,
 Yet, bound to prayer, would work no more : 12060
 May he do so ?

False-Seeming.

Yea.

Love.

Tell me how.

False-Seeming.

This doth Saint Austin clearly show.
 If men to God their lives have wed
 Within an abbey garnishèd
 With lands, where white and black monks are,
 Or worthy canons regular,

Knights of the Temple or St. John,
 (Further examples need I none)
 Serving their Lord in praise and prayer,
 No mendicancy finds he there.
 Some monks do daily labour, but
 Are nowise from God's service shut
 Therefor.

What
 men may
 beg

12070

The mendicants' estate
 Gave rise to long and sharp debate
 In days that I remember well.
 If so it please you, will I tell
 How that a man may beg at need
 When he no otherwise can feed
 Or pasture him, this, bit by bit,
 I'll show, and none can gainsay it,
 Unless some sophist strove to tangle
 The truth with false and tiresome jangle.
 By none the case were better cleared
 Than me, who all the field have eared.

12080

LXIII

False-Seeming doth the case relate
 Of mendicants and their estate.

I'LL next set forth each special case
 Of all the mendicantine race:
 And first of those poor cattle who
 Too dull of wit are born to do
 Aught for a living, they may go
 And beg where'er they will, I trow,
 Until some useful craft they learn
 Whereby they meat and drink may earn

12090

Lawful Without reproach of loselry,
mendi- How mean soe'er that craft may be.
cancy Then some through sickness or old age,
 Or tender years, may not engage
 In labour, they no touch of shame
 Need feel if alms or doles they claim. 12100
 And then again some men we see,
 Who in their time too jollily
 Have lived, and now beside the way
 Must seek poor pittance day by day;
 Such men are suffered graciously
 To beg lest they of hunger die.
 Or if a man should go about
 To search some craft or science out,
 But all his industry and skill
 The work eludes, do what he will, 12110
 And no man doth employment give
 Whereby he earns the means to live,
 Then by mendicity may he
 Contend with dire necessity.
 Or some poor peasant carle, who drives
 The plough, and bowed by labour strives,
 His brow bedewed with sweat, to gain
 Sufficiency, but all in vain,
 Should not be blamed although he went
 Begging around to supplement 12120
 His scanty wage.
 Or those who spend
 Their lives and fortunes to defend
 The faith by force of arms, in heat
 Or cold, or in the justice seat,
 And then in old age find them poor,
 'Tis well they be allowed to cure

Their misery dire by alms, till they
 By handicraft their needs may stay.
 But doing so they must not shirk
 Hard labour, and seek ghostly work; 12130
 But I, by this, no figure mean,
 But true hand work.

William
 St.
 Amour

And thus I ween
 In these examples that I give,
 With reason, men may beg to live,
 But in rare other case, I wot,
 If good Saint-Amour lieth not,
 Who of the matter held dispute
 With men, deep read, of wit acute,
 At Paris, most profound divines;
 God starve me of good meats and wines 12140
 Unless his book in accord be
 With Paris University;
 Yea, and with all the world beside,
 Which hailed his preaching far and wide,
 And ne'er shall any who refuse
 His doctrine find with God excuse.
 Let those who scoff at him scoff still,
 And grumblers grumble as they will,
 For my part, I shall ever hold
 His name in honour, and with bold 12150
 Stout words support him, though thereby
 I lose my life, or cruelly
 Be cast in gaol like holy Paul,
 Or else be banished far from all
 My friends like William Saint-Amour,
 Who was, not many years before
 I write, by Dame Hypocrisy,
 My dam, exiled, all envious she.

Labour My mother drove him forth, forsooth,
 hateful to Most foully, for that he the truth 12160
 some Upheld, and showed, all bald and bare,
 Hypocrisy, with subtle care
 Within his latest book, and said,
 'Twere well that I no longer sped
 My life by begging, but should set
 My hands to labour, would I get
 My livelihood.

 He surely had
 Deemed me for either drunk or mad,
 For labour pleases me no whit,
 Nor have I any need for it. 12170
 I find a more congenial way
 Of life, to patter beads and pray,
 And all my ribaldry to hide
 Beneath my mother's mantle wide.

The God of Love.

Thou devil! dar'st thou then display
 Thy vileness thus in light of day?

False-Seeming.

What mean you?

Love.

Scoundrel, hast thou got
 No fear of God?

False-Seeming.

 Most surely not.
 No man to greatness can attain
 In these days if he count not vain. 12180

God's holy fear.

**Mis-
creants
thrive**

If men eschew
All evil and uprightly do,
Nought will they win of worldly good,
But must eftsoons for livelihood
Beg alms of others and drink deep
Of sorrow their poor lives to keep :
Such lot do I in horror hold.
But see what goodly heaps of gold,
Have usurers in their treasuries
And other folk akin to these ; 12190
Base-coining knaves, and limitours,
Provosts, catchpoles, and gold-chained mayors,
Who fat on fraud and rapine grow,
While the poor people bend alow
Before them. They, like wolves, devour
And rob all folk beneath their power ;
For each and all of these in turn
Despoil the poor of that they earn,
And most ingeniously contrive
To pluck their victims while alive. 12200
The stronger rob the weaker ever,
And, 'neath my simple cloak, so clever
Am I, that cozeners by the dozen
Who cozen others do I cozen
Lightly, and robbers and robbed alike
I rob, yet none know when I strike.
By my chicanery I rake
Together treasure none can take
From out my hands, grand palaces,
I build that I my fantasies 12210
May please, and gather friends around
My tables, where rich meats abound.

Privi- With jollity my heart grows warm
 leges of When gold and silver thickly swarm
 friars Within my coffers, which ne'er fail;
 Count ye my schemes of no avail?
 To heap is ever my intent,
 And much my gain exceeds my rent.
 And though I beaten were or slain,
 Fear not I'd soon look in again.

12220

Love.

You seem a saintly one!

False-Seeming.

Quite true,
 For dowered am I with orders due:
 Curate to all the world am I,
 And all men hail me joyfully,
 For all their souls have I in cure,
 And none without my aid endure.
 Full oft I preach and counsel give,
 Yet by no handicraft I live;
 But from the Pope a bull I've got,
 For he, good man, suspects me not.
 With restless diligence I press,
 And seek out chances to confess
 An emperor, baron, count, or king,
 But nought I love the houseling
 Of needy folk; not my affair
 Are they but on occasion rare.
 Nought care I for their mean distresses:
 But emperors and great princesses,

12230

The wives of noble palatines,	
Rich abbesses and sleek beguines,	Profitable
Fat bailies' spouses, knight-wed dames,	12240 penitents
Spruce burghesses, whom nothing shames,	
And nuns and highborn damselfair,	
Richly attired or mother-bare,	
To me it matters not one pin,	
Gladly I shrive their souls of sin.	
Then diligently I inquire	
Of lord and lady, maid and squire,	
What goods they have, what lives they	
lead,	
And, shriving them, I take good heed	12250
To point out that their parish priest	
Is dull and doltish as a beast	
Compared with me and my confreres,	
(A jovial crew that nothing scares),	
To whom the secrets I reveal	
Of all these geese, nor aught conceal,	
And they likewise disclose to me	
Whate'er they've learned, right merrily.	
And that you may these rascals know,	
Who go about deceiving so	12260
The people, I may duly quote	
The gospel holy Matthew wrote.	
In chapter twenty-three we read:	
In Moses' chair now sit indeed	
(The chair is by the glossing seen	
The Ancient Testament to mean).	
Blind scribes and stiff-necked Pharisees	
(Cursed hypocrites our Lord called these)	
Who say: Do that we preach to you,	
But practise not the things we do.	12270

Friars Right ready are the knaves with speech,
like to But slow to follow that they teach ;
Pharisees Burdens on poor men's backs will they
 With cheery heart and lightsome lay,
 But scorn to help them e'en so much
 As might they with a finger's touch.

Love.

Why not ?

False-Seeming.

Will lacks, and so they don't.
 They know that wretched folk are wont,
 O'erburdened, oft to sink beneath
 The load, and trouble shun like death ; 12280
 And if some worthy work they do,
 Be sure 'tis well within the view
 Of others. Their phylacteries
 And hems they broaden to men's eyes,
 And at the tables highest seats
 They choose, anigh the choicest meats,
 While in the synagogues with pride
 They thrust poor humble men aside,
 And dearly love in open street
 Salutes to win from all they meet, 12290
 Nor are they anywise ashamed
 To hear themselves as 'Master' named.
 Yet these things Scripture hath forbid,
 And suchlike ways and customs chid.

Behold another potent plan
 We use against all those who ban

Friars
hang to-
gether

Our order, and contemn our laws :
 Against them make we common cause ;
 He whom one hates, with hate profound
 We all detest, together bound 12300
 By equal ties, and if we see
 The way by which successfully
 Our foe hopes land or rent to gain,
 And honourable state maintain,
 We strive to know the means and mode
 By which he travelleth the road
 Thereto, and straightway set about
 Scandals, which cause his friends to doubt
 His honour and good faith, and thus
 The steps whereby he climbs, by us 12310
 Are cut away, and he adrift
 Is cast, as best he may to shift,
 Alone and destitute of friends,
 And thus do we attain our ends,
 Yet nought our foe perceives by whom
 It is that on him falls his doom.
 For if he knew to whom he owed
 His downfall, surely would it goad
 Him on to his revenge and he
 Would turn on us ferociously. 12320

If one of us have done some good
 We amplify its magnitude,
 Although, pardee, 'tis oft but feigned ;
 Or if that one of us hath deigned
 To vaunt some good he ne'er hath done
 To this or that, as we were one
 With him we cry aloud that we
 Helped such good work right royally,

Friars are In hope the love and confidence
 meddle- To gain of wealthy men. Pretence. 12330
 some We make and thereby parchments get
 Wherein our virtues forth are set
 In suchwise that the world will bless
 And praise our names for holiness.
 The direst poverty we feign,
 But howsoever we complain,
 We yet are those who, having nought,
 Have more, forsooth, than poor men
 ought.

Then am I great at agencies,
 Old feuds arrange, and marriages, 12340
 Executorships I take on me,
 And further deeds of warrantry,
 Inquests as pursuivant I make,
 Whereat some honest men might quake.
 'Tis pleasure, wherewith nought compares
 To mix in other men's affairs.
 And lastly should you be concerned
 In things to which my hand I've turned,
 Speak forth—no sooner said than done,
 With your commands my will shall run. 12350
 But who my chastisement should try,
 Would find he'd done but foolishly;
 For little I love the man who'd show
 To me the path I'm bound to go,
 And though to others I may give
 Correction, none will I receive.

For forests have I little taste,
 Or hermit's huts, or deserts waste,

I leave Saint John, the Baptist hight,		Servant of Anti- christ
His couches green, and sandhills white,	12860	
His dwelling was too far away,		
In towns and burghs I liefer stay,		
And build fair palaces and halls		
And safely dwell behind strong walls.		
I oft declare that I renounce		
The world, yet would not lose an ounce		
Thereof; good Lord! the world to me		
Is, as to fish, the brimming sea.		

Servant of Antichrist am I,	
Of whom saith Scripture truthfully,	12870
That, while of holiness he wears	
The cloak, within his heart he bears	
Iniquity. Like lambkins we	
Appear outside, but inwardly	
Are ravening wolves; we overrun	
The earth, and under every sun	
Bring strife, and fain would hold command	
O'er lives of men in every land.	
And if within a city wall	
I find some wretch unnatural	12880
(And 'tis reported that Milan	
At one time lay beneath this ban),	
Or one who as a usurer sits,	
And sells long terms and post obits,	
Fulfilled of all rapacity;	
Or steeped in luxury one be,	
Or prelate living jovial life,	
Or priest who leman hath as wife;	
Provost or officer in chief,	
Who is but a disloyal thief,	12890

What friars love Or some vile wretch who keeps a stew,
 Or procuress, to hell-fire due,
 Or ribald wretch, who, worn and spent
 With vice, but waits due chastisement :
 Though all the saints he should invoke,
 He nowise can forefend my stroke ;
 Except by some delicious dish,
 Eel, salmon, pike, or other fish,
 Tarts, custards, delicate cream cheese
 (Which pleasantly our gullets grease), 12400
 Sweet apple, and soft melting pear,
 Fat goose and sucking-pig's rich fare ;
 Or other delicacies tasty
 As highly savoured roebuck pasty,
 Or capon fat, sweet dainty bit,
 To please me, round his neck I'll fit
 A cord and drag him to the stake
 E'en though his howls the city shake,
 Or in deep cell will have him cast
 To languish till his life be past. 12410
 Unless he deigns to feed us well,
 We'll make his life a very hell,
 For if one earn our hate, his crimes
 He overpays a hundred times.

But if he hath the wit on high
 To build a castle speedily,
 (No matter of what sort of stone,
 Or if with square and compass done,
 Or whether it be of turf or wood,
 So that the walls are stout and good), 12420
 And plentifully garnish it
 With wares that jolly life befit,

Dotes and
bribery

And on the battlement contrive
 An engine formed to cast and drive
 As well behind, as eke before,
 Such precious stones from out his store
 As thou heard at full related,
 And pleasantly enumerated,
 Good wines in barrele, casks and tuns,
 And heavy bags, not scanty ones, 12480
 Stuffed well with bezants, crowns, and marks,
 Then nought he need to heed our barks
 Or fear our bites. But doth he not
 Possess such stores 'twere well I wot
 Their worth he gave us, nor with lies,
 Excuses vain, or fallacies,
 Attempt our cozening, or we'll bring
 Against him such a grievous string
 Of crimes that if not burned alive,
 He will but wretchedly survive, 12440
 Beneath a penance of a kind
 That heavier tax than doles he'll find.

It is not by external show
 Of weed you may these traitors know,
 But whoso from their toils would be
 Preserved, must mark their jugglery;
 For Christ's most holy faith were marred
 But for the careful watch and ward
 Of Paris University,
 E'en as I now relate to ye. 12450
 Twelve hundred years and fifty-five
 Had fled since Christ stood forth alive
 On earth for men, when first was seen
 (None will naysay my words, I ween)

The new gospel The prime exemplar of a book
 So vile that by the devil's crook
 It well were written, and about
 'T was set for clerks to copy out
 And circulate when duly dight;
 The everlasting Gospel hight 12460
 This trash and friars avouched its merit,
 As writ by God's most Holy Spirit.
 Right worthy was it to be burned,
 But many a crown the scholars earned
 Before the Church of Notre Dame,
 For men and women oiled the palm,
 Of those who set themselves to write
 Out fair, that vile misleading light.
 Therein one finds all clearly done
 This blasphemous comparison : 12470
 "E'en as before the sun doth fail
 The moon, and show but faint and pale,
 And as she nowise can compete
 With him in brilliancy or heat,
 And as a kernel to its shell
 (Nay do not smile at what I tell,
 For this have I seen writ, I swear)
 So doth this wondrous book compare
 With Christ's Four Gospels, and surpass
 Their value utterly."—Alas! 12480
 I wish me dead, if even than these
 You find not bolder similes.

The University till then
 Had been asleep, but roused it when
 This blasphemy assailed its ears,
 Wakened at once by wrath and fears.

Straightway, its arms and armour dight,
 It sallied forth with will to fight
 This hydra, and deliver o'er
 The book to judgment; but before 12490
 It could with the dread monster close,
 The knaves, from out whose brain it rose,
 Secured and hid it suddenly,
 For well they knew that ne'er could be
 Sustained, the lies and follies writ
 Therein. What since became of it
 None know, for those of whom 'twas born
 Have hid it until time be worn,
 Hoping perchance, some future day,
 Its blasphemies to gloze away. 12500

Anti-
 christ
 looked
 for

And now we Antichrist abide,
 With will to range us on his side
 Whene'er he comes, who do not so
 Small chance of life will have I trow.
 For soon shall we an army raise
 Against them, by our devious ways,
 And none who in their folly strive
 To curb us shall be left alive,
 Whether they by the sword are slain,
 Or meet their death through worsen pain. 12610
 And whither deem ye then must lead
 These words which in this book we read?
 "The while that Peter towers on high
 It needs that John alow must lie."
 But this perceive ye is the husk,
 Within, the sense lies, all a-dusk,
 And thence will I the marrow draw
 To show these men's unholy law.

Peter and Peter, our holy Father is,
 John The Pope, and secular clerks, ywis, 12520
 Defenders of the law of Christ.
 And John, the Friars, and those enticed
 Within their toils, who boldly say,
 The 'Eternal Gospel' is the way
 By which men may ascend to heaven,
 And by the Holy Ghost 'tis given.
 The power of John these recreants teach
 To be the gospel that they preach
 To call back sinners gone astray
 From out the path of God's highway. 12530
 And many a wicked devilry
 Straightly commanded may one see
 Within this book of froth and foam,
 Against the holy law of Rome;
 For Antichrist doth dwell within
 The covers of this book of sin.
 Men are exhorted there to slay
 All those who Peter's rule obey;
 But howsoever they assail
 His law, hell gates shall not prevail. 12540
 Against it, but it still shall stand,
 A beacon unto every land,
 And those who hold it fast shall be
 God's people everlastingly;
 While their law, miscalled John's, shall
 fall
 Deserted and accurst of all.
 But of this matter will I stay
 My words—too much there is to say.
 But if that book had taken root,
 Most marvellously well 'twould suit 12550

My practice, for in any case
 With hosts of people find I grace. The
 father
 of lies

My father, who as emperor
 Rules all the world, is barrator
 And prince of lies; the empress is
 My mother; and through them, ywis,
 Whate'er the Holy Ghost may do,
 Our lineage all the earth doth strew.
 And that is only as should be,
 For ever at our will do we 12560
 So thoroughly cozen men that none
 Perceive the way our tricks are done,
 Or, e'en perceiving, dare not speak,
 Lest we on them our vengeance wreak.
 But those men God comes not anear
 Who hold my brethren in more fear
 Than Him; the Faith's weak champions they
 Who dare not such vile crimes naysay,
 But, coward-like, the risks refuse,
 When they foul treason might accuse. 12570
 God will not list their cry for grace,
 But from them turn one day His face,
 And lay on them sharp chastisement.
 But nothing fear we to be shent,
 Since we of men are so esteemed,
 And of such worth and honour deemed,
 That howsoe'er censorious
 We be, no man dare censure us.
 To whom but us should people pay
 Honour, who never cease to pray 12580
 In sight of men conspicuously,
 Whate'er our secret practice be?

Beguins But is this greater foolishness,
described Esteem you, than that men should bless
 High chivalry, and call those great
 Who don fair weed and keep grand
 state?
 But if it prove that well agreed
 Is noble life with lordly weed,
 Should it not greatly be deplored
 That bodies fair, with virtue stored, 12590
 Belong not to the hypocrites?
 A curse such fools right well befits!
 Beloved of us, as light of bats!
 But Beguins crowned with flapping hats,
 O'er longdrawn bloodless faces blank,
 And gowns unwashed to wrap their lank
 Lean figures (to which vermin are
 No strangers, for in truth from far
 They're odorous), while foul crumpled hose
 Surmount their ugly sandalled shoes, 12600
 Which much resemble traps for quails:
 Through such as these no wise prince fails
 To govern, whether in war or peace,
 Himself and land, and good increase
 Of honour thence shall surely grow
 To him and his. Right well I know
 That neath such show they hide foul sin,
 But none the less men's reverence win
 Therefore with them I cast my lot
 To lie, trick, swindle and what not. 12610
 Yet were it neither just nor wise
 A wretched garment to despise,
 Unless it be a cloak for pride.
 Nor should our love be turned aside

From one whose dress is spoiled by flaws.
 But God esteemeth not two straws
 The word of one who saith that he
 Hath left the world, yet luxury
 Doth wallow in. The hypocrite
 Who cries that he the world hath quit, 12620
 And yet indulgeth all he can
 The flesh, like any world-wise man,
 Nor aught of pleasure doth refuse;
 Should we his cant and lies excuse?
 Resembleth he the dog who fain
 Unto his vomit turns again.
 But unto you I dare not lie;
 Though had I not unerringly
 Perceived that you saw clearly through
 My falsity, I straight should you 12630
 Have plied with cozenage, for I ne'er,
 Seeing a chance, a victim spare.
 I know my rôle, and this I tell,
 A traitor am I, guard you well.

False-
 Seeming
 concludes

The Author.

The God bestowed on this strange tale
 A smile, nor did the barons fail
 To laugh, and cried: A subtle youth,
 And one in whom to trust, forsooth!

The God of Love.

False-Seeming, then said Love, I pray,
 Since thou so great a part shalt play 12640
 Within my court, for there shalt thou
 Be king of ribalds, tell me now,
 Wilt thou to me be loyal and true?

False-Seeming.

False-Seeming's leman Yea, by the gods I swear to you;
That ne'er your ancestors nor sire
Had slave whose love was more entire.

Love.

Nay! That thy nature would deny.

False-Seeming.

E'en take your chance thereof and try;
And if some caution you demand,
No surer were you though your hand 12650
Held warrant, written oath, or pledge.
With confidence I dare allege
That though a wolf you beat within
An inch of life, he still his skin
Retains, and therefrom issueth not;
And 'tis the same with me I wot:
Though 'neath a simple vestment I
Am hid, I practise treachery.
Suppose you I for virtue care
Because the outward guise looks fair 12660
Neath which I do the devil's work?
No crime, by God, I blink or shirk;
And if I coy and simple seem,
Have I then changed my life d'ye deem?
Nay, thereto make I no pretence.
My dear, Constrained-Abstinence,
Hath need of all my carefulness;
She had been long since dead, I guess,
Had I not been at hand to stay
Her weary steps on life's hard way; 12670
Suffer us twain to work our will.

Love.

So be it, thy desire fulfil.

The host
makes
ready

The Author.

And so the rascal held his place.
He had a very traitor's face,
Without, pure white, within, black hell :
Before Love on his knees he fell
And worshipped him with plenteous thanks.
Cried Love then, looking round his
ranks :
Forward at once ! let every man
Arm him forthwith as best he can. 12680

Then made him ready for the fight
Each one, with arms and armour dight,
And forth they sallied one and all,
Loud shouting, towards the castle wall,
Right manfully resolved that they
Would dearly sell their lives that day,
Or from the battlements would cry
In token of glad victory.
Then in four battles they divide,
Of which each marcheth towards the
side 12690
To it assigned, and thus the gates
Assail they, though before each waits
A stalwart guard prepared to fight
Nor yield to aught save death's dark night ;
Not weakly, sick, or slothful they,
But strong, and eager for the fray.

LXIV

False-Seeming as a pilgrim goes,
 Disguised, to Evil-Tongue; and shows
 Constrained-Abstinence likewise
 Herself to him in saintly guise.

12700

Envoys
 to Evil-
 Tongue

BEHOLD you now neath what pretence
 False-Seeming came with Abstinence
 'Gainst Evil-Tongue. The wily twain
 Held counsel how they best might gain
 Their ends—in open guise to go,
 Or hid beneath some cozening show;
 And after much debate agreed,
 That better 'twould their errand speed
 If they began the war to wage
 Disguised as folk on pilgrimage, 12710
 With air of holy innocence.
 Forthwith Constrained-Abstinence
 Appeared as a demure Beguine,
 Attired in robe of cameline,
 With fair white kerchief round her head,
 The while with saintly look she read
 Her psalter. At her waist was hung
 A paternoster, thereto strung
 By girdle-cord of purest white.
 She had not bought it, but was dight 12720
 Therewith most kindly by a friar,
 Her spiritual guide and sire,
 And she from him gat more behoof
 Than any neath the convent's roof,
 While he too loved to visit her
 As holy guide and sermoner.

E'en though False-Seeming might be near,
 Still would he her confession hear,
 And such attention gave thereto
 That oft one hat would hide the two. 12730

Con-
 strained-
 Absti-
 nence pic-
 tured

A personable dame, pardee,
 Though somewhat pale of visage she,
 Resembling (bitch that lust-heat grips,)
 Death's horse in the Apocalypse,
 Which symbolises well the race
 Of hypocrites with gruesome face;
 For aye this horse hath painted been
 Of pale and deadly hue I ween,
 And as of jaundice well-nigh dead
 Was Abstinence encoloured. 12740

She looked as though ashamed she were
 Of those vile attributes she bare.
 The pilgrim-staff she leaned upon
 Which she from Fraud as gift had won,
 With dreariness was tinted o'er,
 And stuffed the wallet was she bore
 With care and trouble.

In attire

False-Seeming dressed him of a friar.
 And e'en as though for her he yearned
 Towards Abstinence his face was turned, 12750
 Humble he looked and meek of cheer,
 And nought of pride he let appear,
 But aped a novice, mild and young,
 While round his neck a bible hung.
 All squireless goes he, but doth clutch,
 As 'twere through weakness, treason's crutch,
 And in his sleeve-fold doth conceal
 A razor keen of finest steel;

Evil- Tongue's dwelling A villainous and cruel blade
 That had in Cut-throat's forge been made. 12760
 So hand in hand they limp along,
 And thus approach foul Evil-Tongue,
 Who stood his castle gate beside,
 And all who fared thereby espied.
 The pilgrims notes he come anigh,
 Bearing themselves most holily.

LXV

False-Seeming, linked with Abstinence,
 To aid the Lover, makes pretence
 Of guesting with foul Evil-Tongue,
 Whose lash hath many a good man stung. 12770

THEN Abstinence saluteth first,
 With humble gest, this man accurst
 And next False-Seeming bends him low,
 With courteous reverential bow,
 And he saluteth them again;
 For, all unruffled, he amain
 Seemed Abstinence beneath her feint
 To know, yet saw not her constraint,
 But innocently deemed that she
 Was even that she seemed to be; 12780
 And took the garb which tricked her out
 All in good faith, unchecked by doubt,
 But 'tis forsooth her customed way
 Ever such juggling tricks to play;
 And if she e'er sincere hath been,
 Her virtue was short-lived, I ween.

Dis-
guised
pilgrims

False-Seeming eyed he o'er right well,
 Yet nought could he his falseness tell,
 For wondrously was he disguised,
 Nor lightly might be recognised ; 12790
 And whosoe'er the knave had known
 Before this garb were o'er him thrown,
 Had sworn by God the Father he
 The same one were who formerly
 Bold Robin, in the dance, had been,
 And now as Jacobin is seen.
 But then, deny it whoso can,
 Each Jacobin's an honest man.
 That holy order great disgrace
 Would suffer, if therein found place 12800
 A charlatan. And Carmelites,
 And Cordeliers and holy wights
 Of other orders, whether they be
 Big-bellied churls or lean, pardee,
 As wolves, not one, where'er he wone,
 But for a saint by dress is known,
 But ne'er we seeming should permit
 To o'erride sense or govern it.
 If you such subtlety possess
 As lightly shatters sophistries, 12810
 Whate'er the argument appear
 Upon the face of it, look near
 And closely for some fallacy
 Lest you thereby deceived be.

When now the pilgrims twain were come
 Where Evil-Tongue had made his home,
 Their harness fain were they to flit
 From off them and beside him sit.

Evil-Tongue.

Enter-
tainment
sought

Quoth he : " Say sirs, whence hail ye then,
And what news stir the world of men, 12820
And by what happy circumstance
Ye hither come, as 'twere by chance."

Constrained-Abstinence.

Constrained-Abstinence replied :
Fair sir, we seek this countryside
As pilgrims, loyal of heart and true,
Who fain their penitence would do :
Afoot we've gone the livelong day
Along the weary dust-strewn way.
Hither are we together sent
By God, to folk impenitent, 12830
And hope our exhortations may
Restore some sinners gone astray ;
No other fish we strive to catch,
And in God's name, by whose dispatch
We sallied forth, we beg to be
Here harboured, and most willingly,
An't please you, will make good our score
By fitting tale of ghostly lore,
If you such coin are fain to take.

The Author.

Then Evil-Tongue in answer spake : 12840

Evil-Tongue.

My house, quoth he, e'en such as 'tis,
Is yours, no further seek than this,
And preach whatso ye will, cast fear
Aside, I give a ready ear.

False-Seeming.

Sweet thanks, fair sir.

The Author.

Forthwith to spin
Her tale doth Abstinence begin.

Con-
strained-
Absti-
nence
holds
forth

LXVI

This tells how Abstinence reproves
The sin that Evil-Tongue most loves.

FAIR sir, the first and best among
The Christian virtues is, one's tongue 12850
To curb from falseness, and refrain
From speech injurious, rude, and vain.
No other thing I trow on earth
So proves a man of wit and worth.
A hundred times 'tis better far
To practise silence than to mar
One's mouth with evil words and those
Who listen to them, but disclose
Their baseness. 'Tis, fair sir, too true
That this vile crime disgraceth you 12860
Sadly. You lately told a lie
Which did most grievous injury
Unto a loving youth who came
Hither some days past, laying blame
On him because you said that he
Desired and purposed wrongfully
Fair-Welcome to seduce: this I
Denounce in God's name as a lie,

The For now no more doth he come here,
 crime of And yet Fair-Welcome, racked with
 slander fear,

12870

Must lie in prison, who, natheless,
 Had in him nought but willingness
 To please you daily, nor e'er sought
 To injure you by word or thought,
 But dareth now no more amuse
 Himself as gentle gallants use.
 Of solace is he quite bereft
 Since that, through fear of you, hath
 left

The youth whom joyance hither drew.
 What was it then that prompted you
 To wrong him thus except your lewd
 Despite which many a lie hath brewed?

12880

Accursèd be your venomous tongue,
 Which to no other chime is rung
 But scolding, wrath, and spiteful rage,
 And no desire doth e'er engage
 But noble men to vilify
 By secret stab or barefaced lie,
 Affirming rumours scarce begun
 As crimes accomplished, past, and
 done.

12890

But I maintain, the tongue aloof
 Should hold from all but clearest proof,
 And count it worst of crimes to say
 That which may rob or filch away
 A man's good name; all this right
 well
 You know, O shameless child of hell

Evil-
Tongue
lectured

The Lover lightly setteth by
Your japes, and careth not one fly
If lies you speak or otherwise,
In no degree it moves or tries
His spirit, he but comes and goes,
Indifferent as the wind that blows,
Hither resorting now and then
By chance, the same as other men.

12900

But to speak frankly, great surprise
It is to me to note your eyes
Ever awatch beside the gate,
From early morn till night grows
late,

Your lance in rest, as you'd defy
Each man who fared afoot hereby.

12910

Unceasing vigil do you keep,
Neglecting rest and needful sleep,
Yet ne'er will Jealousy plenish you
What to your restless care is due ;
But sad Fair-Welcome 'tis to see

Prisoned for no delinquency
Or crime : he in confinement wears
His life away 'mid sighs and tears.

Would God you in the world had done
Naught worse than this unhappy one !

12920

'Twould be, an't please you, naught but
just,

If you from out your post were thrust,
And thrown in prison bound with
chains,

For well will you deserve hell's pains
If you repent not ere you die.

Evil-
Tongue
indignant

Evil-Tongue.

Certes, he cried, you basely lie,
Cursed be the hour that saw you win
This spot ; did I then take you in
That you should dare insult me so ?
But your ill fortune 'twas I trow 12930
To deem a simpleton dwelt here.
Be off ! find lodgment elsewhere.
Ye hither come to call me liar !
Two sorcerers ! who would work me
 dire
And cruel wrong, pour on me shame,
And all my ways and doings blame,
Is this the sermoning ye make ?
My soul may all the devils take,
And God's curse be upon me spilt
If, but ten days ere yet were built 12940
These walls, the varlet came not here,
With seeming mild and simple cheer,
And stole a kiss from off the Rose,
Though if he further went, God knows
Why was it given to my good care
Save that this crime notorious were ?
Pardee, I'll sound it far and wide,
And none shall dare aver I've lied.
A trumpet blast so loud I'll blow
That every carl and quean shall know 12950
How he once dared my hedge to break.

The Author.

False-Seeming then stood forth and spake :

LXVII

False-Seeming lightly giveth mate
To Evil-Tongue, with well-filed prate.

The
Lover
excused

FAIR sir, not always gospel clear
And pure folks whisper in one's ear
About the streets—pray list you while.
I prove these tales but lies most vile.
It scarcely needs that I remind
One so astute, that nought inclined
Are folk to love their neighbours who
Find fault with all they say or do,
If they should chance to hear of it,
However dull or small of wit.
I've read it as a well-known thing
That men are fond of visiting
The spots where those they love abide.
Now this man loveth you beside.
All others, as his dearest friend,
For whom both goods and life he'd spend,
Nor fails he to, whene'er ye meet,
Salute you in the public street,
And show you most profound respect,
Yet trow I that no ill effect
His friendship brings you, nor doth he
Enweary you as oft may be
The way with others. If the Rose
His heart so parts for, I suppose
He constantly would here be seen
And by him it had stolen been;
Though risk he ran alive to burn
Towards the loved object still he'd turn.

Evil- But reached his passion that degree?
 Tongue's Nay! nay! Then clear it seems that he,
 deserts Nor yet Fair-Welcome (whom you've wrought
 Most cruelly against) e'er sought
 To snatch the Rose; but had they tried
 Lightly the twain had you defied.

And wot you well that if this youth
 (Who smarts beneath your slanderous tooth) 12990
 Within his heart desire did feel
 The Rosebud which you guard to steal,
 He scarce had vaunted you his friend,
 But rather would his labour spend
 Your stronghold to reduce to dust;
 For were your accusation just,
 And he thereof the news had learned,
 His indignation had you earned.
 Nor thereof could there be much doubt,
 Seeing that foretimes in and out 13000
 He went, where now by stern and hard
 Denial is his ingress barred.
 O man of cruel speech, right well
 Do you deserve the fires of hell,
 Since thus your spite doth one pursue
 Who ne'er wrought harm or ill to you.

The Author.

False-Seeming thus vile Evil-Tongue
 Reproved, who owned him in the wrong;
 So straight the case against him went
 That soon he vowed him penitent, 13010
 And said:

Evil-Tongue.

'Fore God, perhaps 'tis true,
 False-Seeming, slave am I to you
 And Abstinence, I own for wise;
 As seem ye of one mind, advise
 Me straightly; what to do were best?

**Evil-
 Tongue
 penitent**

False-Seeming.

First shall you be by me confessed
 Of crimes wherein you have misspent
 Your life, as humble penitent;
 I of the Order am full priest,
 And of confessors mightiest 13020
 Throughout the whole vast universe,
 Wielding God's power to bless and curse.
 No paltry curate am I, bound
 By oaths to tread the churches round,
 But, by our Lady, far more care
 Have I how souls beneath me fare
 Than those poor caitiff parish priests
 Who spend their days 'twixt fasts and
 feasts;
 Their powers are nought compared to mine.
 No priest or prelate, I opine, 13080
 Is half so learned or well read
 As I, poor sinners to bestead.
 A doctorate of divinity
 Long years since was conferred on me.
 By great and small am I allowed
 Worthy 'fore all to hold the proud
 Distinction to be counted first
 Among confessors. If you thirst

Evil-Tongue murdered
 For absolution, just confess
 Your sins, and I with readiness 13040
 Will shrive you, and when once you've got
 My shrift—thank God, your sins are not,

LXVIII

How by a razor—not a sword—
 Met Evil-Tongue his just reward,
 Therewith False-Seeming cut his tongue
 From out his mouth—his knell was rung.

THEN Evil-Tongue with humbleness
 Would on his bended knees confess
 His crime, and shrive him of his fault;
 False-Seeming made no weakling halt, 13050
 But seized his throat, and forthwith stayed
 His cackle, once for all, with blade
 Of razor, and his tongue cut out,
 From whence fell many a bloody gout,
 And next the pair make haste to pitch
 His body in the castle ditch,
 And then the unguarded door they break,
 And o'er the threshold passage make,
 And find the Norman soldiers sunk
 In senseless slumber, deadly drunk, 13060
 The wine they down their throats had
 cast,
 Cast them upon the floor at last,
 And as they lay, the wretches all,
 Ere they had time for help to call,
 Were strangled in their drunken sleep,
 Henceforth strict fast from lies they'll keep.

LXIX

False-Seeming, who to lovers shows
 Sweet comfort, with his leman goes
 Across the threshold, with him he
 Doth Largess lead and Courtesy. 18070

The door
 opened

LARGESS and Courtesy their way
 Make through the gate, without delay,
 And silently together stand,
 Awhile, this strong quadruple band.
 The harridan, who watches o'er
 Fair-Welcome, is by all the four
 Seen to descend and move about
 The court-yard, void of fear or doubt;
 Bearing upon her head a simple
 All-covering hood above her wimple. 18080
 Upon her set they all in haste,
 And she, perceiving 'twere but waste
 Of pains to strive against the four,
 Exclaimed aloud.

The Duenna.

Upon what score
 Do ye, of look so debonair,
 Within this castle's precincts fare?
 I'm not your prisoner, say then why
 Ye hither come thus suddenly.

The Four answer.

Our prisoner! nay then, dearest dame;
 'Twas not to seize you that we came, 18090

The But solely for the pure delight
 Duenna Of seeing you, if so we might,
 flattered And offering on our bended knees
 Our bounden service; an't you please
 Take all we own and you shall be
 Secure, through us, from treachery;
 And, if it fain you, lady sweet,
 To whom both deeds and words unmeet
 Are strangers, we desire to ask
 A boon that can but lightly task 18100
 Your kindness, 'tis that you allow
 Fair-Welcome, who doth languish now
 In durance, hither to descend
 A pleasant hour with us to spend.
 Or at the least, we pray you, deign
 That he the Lover's heart may fain
 With some few words, for each one's
 voice
 The other's spirit would rejoice
 Past measure, and 'twould cost you nought.
 Nay, by this grace, you will have bought 18110
 Fair-Welcome's homage, and may do
 With him whate'er seems good to you,
 Torture, ill-treat him, hang or sell,
 Or gain a friend who loves you well.
 Behold his jewels at command,
 A morse, and rings to deck your hand,
 And if you're kind to him, be sure,
 Ere long he'll give you a parure
 Of diamonds; frank, free, and true
 Of heart he'll show himself to you, 18120
 Nor need you fear he e'er will chide,
 For in his inmost heart doth hide

The deepest love, yet most discreet
And secret is he. Lady sweet,
Give entry to this best of men,
And he through you shall live again.
And now we pray that you this fair
Fresh chaplet wrought of flowerets rare
Will to Fair-Welcome give, dear dame,
As offering in the Lover's name,
'Twill comfort him a thousand fold
More than a hundred marks of gold.

The
Duenna's
fears

The Duenna.

God help me! I would gladly aid,
Your purpose, cried she, but afraid
Am I lest Jealousy should know
Thereof, and thence would ruin grow
To me and mine, and much I fear
Lest Evil-Tongue should waken her.
He ever is engaged to spy
Whate'er we do, by Jealousy;
Unlet or hindered doth he shout,
And chaunt each thing he knows about,
And when his knowledge he hath spent,
No scruple feels he to invent
Lies by the hundred, 'twere among
My chiefest joys to see him hung.
But if to Jealousy he told
This thing, she'd do worse things than
scold.

The Four make answer.

No more of Evil-Tongue have dread,
Cried out the four; he lies stark dead,

The And never more will see or hear.
Duenna Within the ditch, a fitting bier,
gives With gaping throat he's thrown.
way

Unless
 Some sorcerer or sorceress
 Revive him he'll missay no more,
 For nothing short of devil's lore,
 Or miracles, through venoms dire,
 Again can light in him the fire
 Of life : his spite and rage are spent.

The Duenna replies.

In that case gladly I'll consent 18160
 To do the thing for which you pray.
 But let the swain make no delay,
 And if I grant to him access
 He must behave with gentleness.
 Let him obey my summons then,
 The moment I inform him when
 The time is come. But nothing he
 Must do that would unseemly be
 If life and goods he values, nor
 Be seen in passing through the door. 18170
 Let him command, I'll do his will.

The Four reply.

All that you say will he fulfil,
 They cried.

The Author.

Thanks had she from each one,
 And thus their work was so far done.

But howsoever this might be,
False-Seeming, restless as the sea,
Spake to himself in muttering voice :

False-
Seeming
sums up
the case

False-Seeming.

Since he repenteth not his choice,
If he for whom we undertook
This business, unto me would look 18180
For guidance, 'twould have taxed your art,
Good dame, to keep the friends apart.
If I know aught of suchlike things,
And understand manoeuvrings.
With fitting place, and time to match,
No matter how the fold they watch,
The wolf knows well his aim to cloak,
And in the night-watch gives his stroke.
Some day you'll to the minster pay
A visit, e'en as yesterday ; 18190
And Jealousy his chance will crown,
Taking her ways beyond the town ;
Then will the time be ripe that he
Should issue forth all furtively.
Proceeding, silent and alone,
By secret ways, to few men known,
Unless, perchance, some kindly friend
As sentinel his aid should lend,
To guide him through the shades of night,
Foregoing torch or lantern light, 18200
And such times as the moon rules high,
For many a lover wofully
Therethrough hath failed. And as the spot
To him familiar is, I wot,

The He through a window space may make
 Lover's His entry, failing not to take
 hopes A rope whereby he may descend
 rise Into the garden and attend
 Fair-Welcome's coming, who should flee
 From forth his prison hastily 18210
 To meet the Lover, who hath been
 Estranged from him through hate and spleen.
 And then, when once you're locked in sleep,
 Fair-Welcome towards the door should creep,
 Half open it, and so his friend
 Will in a moment gain his end ;
 Plucking the Rose, if only he
 The other guards cheats equally.

The Lover.

But as for me, who stood hard by,
 I deemed the matter certainly 18220
 Accomplished if the dame gave aid,
 And felt thereof nowise afraid.
 Or if I could not compass this,
 I then might use some artifice
 Such as False-Seeming should devise ;
 For him I hold as wondrous wise.

The Author.

The harpidan makes little stay,
 But to Fair-Welcome takes her way,
 Who in the prison, 'gainst his gree,
 Abideth most impatiently. 18230
 Straight goes she till she stands before
 The tower, and quickly hastens o'er

Fair-
Welcome
mystified

The threshold, and with joy ascends
The stairs, and then her way she wends,
With trembling limbs, from room to room,
But vainly seeketh in their gloom
Fair-Welcome, who, all worn and spent,
Was leaning 'gainst the battlement.
She noted how his hope grew dim,
And trimmed her speech to comfort him. 18240

The Duenna.

How now, fair son, quoth she, much pain
Is mine to see your spirit wane ;
Say then what grief doth trouble you,
And I an end will put thereto
If so I may. Confide in me.

The Author.

Fair-Welcome wondered what might be
The gist of this, but did not dare
Believe her, though she spoke him fair ;
And as he strove to think about
This thing, fulfilled was he of doubt ; 18250
He did not dare to show offence,
Yet felt in her no confidence,
And though his spirit was atremble,
He deemed it wiser to dissemble
His mind, however much might he
Doubt the old cat's sincerity ;
Yet feels at heart suspicion dire,
Lest treason doth her speech inspire.
Misease within him lurks e'en while
His visage bears a merry smile, 18260
And cheerful air of unconcern.

Fair-Welcome.

The Dear dame, quoth he, for your return
chaplet I've watched with fond and loving heart,
 For whensoever you depart,
 Howe'er you deem of it, my soul
 Within me sinks oppressed with dole.
 O tenderly, beloved one, say
 Why have you stayed so long away?

The Duenna.

Wherefore? pardee, I'll quickly dight
 The reason to your great delight, 18270

LXX

The crone, desirous to console
 Fair-Welcome's grief and bitter dole;
 The Lover's story doth relate,
 Who is for him disconsolate.

I F only you are brave and wise;
 For through my hands, by great surprise,
 The noblest gallant known on earth,
 Of fairest wit and greatest worth,
 And who with grace saluteth you
 Each time I see him passing through, 18280
 The street, doth this fair chaplet send,
 As token from a loving friend.
 Most gladly, saith he, would he see
 Your face, and die right willingly,
 Nor care to know another day
 Of health, if only he might pay

His court to you, and do your will,
 All other good he counts but ill.
 He swears by God and good saint Foy,
 That unto him the greatest joy 18290
 On earth would be to gain one smile
 Or word from you, therefor exile
 He'd count as nought though he should be
 To Pavia sent all nakedly.
 Reckless is he of all beside,
 If only he may near you bide.

Whence
 comes it?

The Author.

Fair-Welcome straight desires to know
 What kindly hand would fain bestow
 On him the chaplet, for no will
 Hath he to take the gift, until 18300
 He knows the quarter whither sent
 Hath been this graceful compliment.
 Forthwith the harridan reveals
 The tale at full, nor aught conceals.

The Duenna.

'Tis from that youth, you know right well,
 Of whom you oft have heard me tell,
 And surely 'twas for his dear sake
 That Evil-Tongue foul war did make
 Against you—ah! vile child of vice!
 He's gone—but not to paradise. 18310
 Full many a man hath he defamed;
 But now the fiends his soul have claimed.
 His death from fear of slander frees
 All men, none care for him two peas.

The And e'en should he again revive,
 Lover's And reappear on earth alive,
 merits He could not injure you one whit,
 For I know more than he of it.
 Believe me then, this chaplet take,
 And wear it for the Lover's sake. 18320
 He loves you well, oh doubt it not,
 With love that hath nor stain nor blot.
 And if he had an afterthought
 Thereon, he dared to tell me nought.
 Would he some thoughtless folly try,
 That may you easily deny;
 He who doth wrong must drink the
 brew,
 But trust in him, I counsel you.
 No fool is he, but staid and wise,
 And would nought wrong or base devise, 18330
 Therefore he hath my earnest love.
 Fear not that he so vile will prove,
 As dare to make to you a prayer
 But what the fiercest light will bear.
 Most loyal of all men is he,
 As all who keep his company
 Would gladly witness and confess.
 The very flower of gentleness
 Is he, nay, woman never bare
 A child of soul more passing fair, 18340
 And no man living ever heard
 Against him harsh or cruel word
 But from the lips of Evil-Tongue;
 But what he said and what he sung
 Are now by all true men forgot,
 While he himself is left to rot.

More than the half of what he said
 Have I forgotten, by my head,
 And do but know 'twas false and bad,
 It seemed as he an anvil had
 For forging lies.

The
 Lover's
 gener-
 osity

18350

Had it but been
 Known to the Lover, well I ween
 That he had slain him, for none can
 Compare with this most noble man
 For knighthood. In his bounteous deeds
 Of largess he by far exceeds
 King Arthur, nay, his gifts are grander
 Than those of far-famed Alexander.
 Did he but own unbounded store
 Of gold, like those famed men of yore,
 His bounties far would overgo
 Their gifts a hundred times I trow.
 Yea, did he wealth of goods possess
 To keep pace with his generousness,
 Most bounteous were he of all men.
 I pray you take this chaplet then,
 Its flowers are sweet as dittany.

18360

The Author.

I fear 'twould bring ill hap to me,
 Fair-Welcome cried, whose very frame
 Trembled with fear, while went and came
 The colour to his cheeks.

18370

She thrust
 The gift on him, as needs he must
 Accept it, though his hand away
 He turned, and said : Forgive me, pray,

The If I so fair a gift refuse,
chaplet And my ungracious act excuse.
refused

Yet fain would he the garland take,
 Whate'er might follow for its sake.

Fair-Welcome.

Right fair the chaplet is, quoth he,
 But rather I, by far would see,
 The clothes in which I stand afire
 Than take that which misfortune dire
 Most surely must bring down on me;
 What shall we say to Jealousy?
 I doubt me nowise that she'll tear
 The flowers in fragments off my hair,
 And then, foul traitress, will outright
 Destroy me, or in cruel spite,
 Knowing from whom the prize I got,
 Thrust me in closer gaul to rot,
 With suffering more severe than e'er
 Before hath been my lot to bear.
 And if I flee her cruel face,
 Where can I find safe hiding-place?
 Alas! my foe would soon contrive
 To take, and bury me alive,
 For many a one with hue and cry
 Would follow me persistently—
 I'll not receive it!

13380

13390

The Duenna.

Yes, you will,
 Yet suffer thence nor blame nor ill.

13400

Fair-Welcome.

But if she asks whence comes the prize?

The
chaplet
accepted

The Duenna.

Oh! I can forge you twenty lies.

Fair-Welcome.

But if she question me amain,
How shall I answer her again?
If in her rage she cruelly
Rebuke me, how shall I reply?
I can but put her off, forsooth,
With some fair plausible untruth.
And I, if she thereof should know,
Pain worse than death must undergo.

13410

The Duenna.

What shall you say? If you have not
A better tale, 'twere well I wot
To say you had it straight from me,
That would above suspicion be,
And nought of blame would you receive
For taking that I chose to give.

LXXI

Induced by what the hag hath said,
Fair-Welcome setteth on his head
The garland, and doth take therein
A pledge to sell his very skin.

13420

The Author.

FAIR-WELCOME saith no more, but sets
The chaplet of sweet flowerets

The Above his flowing golden hair,
 Duenna's And hears his keeper laughing swear
 tale By body and soul, and skin and bones,
 That no man fairer chaplet owns.
 And often doth Fair-Welcome place
 Himself before the mirror's face,
 In heart rejoiced and gratified.
 The dame then, seeing none beside 18480
 Themselves are there, *en tête à tête*
 Anear him seats her, all elate,
 And thus begins to sermon him :

The Duenna.

Fair-Welcome, dear, no cherubim
 Is fair, and sweet, and good as you.
 My joyous days are all worn through,
 While yours are barely yet begun,
 Your woof of life as yet unspun.
 Alas ! my strength is on the wane,
 And needs must I my limbs sustain 18440
 Ere long on helpful crutch or staff,
 While you with joy-brimmed heart may laugh
 Careless of what your fate may be.
 Yet must you pass, assuredly,
 Sooner or later, through the fire,
 Which all men feel of love's desire,
 And in that wave must plunge you, which
 Queen Venus dights for poor and rich.
 Prepare you, then, beloved one,
 Ere over you love's waters run, 18450
 By these wise counsellings I give ;
 For he doth perilously live

Who breasts love's waves, yet knows them not, Love's
 But if my creed you once have got. heyday
 By heart, you shall arrive at last
 Safely in port, all dangers past.

Believe me, if, when young as you,
 I'd known love's art as now I do,
 And of its ways had been aware
 (For I, in youth, was passing fair), 18400
 You would not hear me groan and sigh
 As I consider mournfully
 My outworn visage, and repine
 At every pucker, seam and line,
 When of my beauty lost I think,
 Whereof gay lovers fain would drink
 Long draughts to quench their lovesick heat:
 (Good Lord! it makes my pulses beat!)
 For then was I of high renown,
 Alike in countryside and town, 18470
 For fairness, and of gallants proud
 And rich there never lacked a crowd
 Around my dwelling. Many a score
 Of blows came rattling 'gainst my door,
 When I disdained with answering word
 To let them know their calls were heard,
 Because it happed forsooth that I
 Already had good company.
 Hereout grew oft a wild uproar,
 And monstrous wroth was I therefor. 18480
 The porch, 'neath stout and sturdy stroke,
 Would yield sometimes, and then awoke
 A fierce mellee, and lives and limbs
 Were lost to please my wayward whims,

Lovers' For sharply raged fierce contests then.
 contests If learnèd Albus, of all men
 The wisest in his reckoning,
 Should his ten wondrous figures bring
 To bear thereon, I doubt if well
 By multiplying he could tell. 13490
 The number of the deadly fights
 Wherein my gallants strove o' nights.
 Right fair of face was I, and sound
 Of body, and of sterlings round
 Had many a thousand, glistering white,
 But like a dunce my business dight.
 I was, in truth, a fair young fool,
 Of no experience in love's school.
 Nought of love's theory I knew,
 But learnèd in its practice grew; 13500
 And all throughout my life have I
 Its battles fought unflinchingly.
 And now to you may I impart
 The mysteries of that sweet art,
 For blame were mine should I forego
 To teach young folk the lore I
 know.

'Tis no great marvel if love's pleasure
 You neither know to mete or measure,
 Since you are but a nestling still,
 With callow wings and yellow bill; 13510
 While I so wrought have in the field
 Of love that unto none I yield
 In knowledge, but might lightly dare
 To fill a grave professor's chair.
 'Tis but a fool who would despise
 And mock old age, by time grown wise,

For wit and practice there are found,
 And many who have trod the round
 Of life have proved, beyond a doubt,
 Those good, when all is else worn out 18520
 On which they have their substance spent;
 Save for that twain their lives were shent.
 When I had wit through practice won,
 A thing with no small labour done,
 Full many a noble man did I
 Trick and beguile most skilfully;
 But also, often was deceived
 Ere yet full wit had I achieved.
 Unhappy wretch! 'twas all too late,
 Youth failed and left me desolate. 18580

Times are
 changed

And now beheld I that my door,
 Which on its hinges heretofore
 Swung day and night, stood idly to,
 From hour to hour none passed therethrough,
 Until I thought: 'Alas! poor soul,
 Thy life is changed to grief and dole!'
 When thus I saw my dwelling left
 Deserted, nigh in twain was cleft
 My heart, and I betook me thence,
 Shamed and abashed my every sense. 18540
 Such misery scarce could I endure,
 What balsam my deep wounds could cure,
 When gay-clad gallants in the street,
 Who lately fawned before my feet,
 And spent their breath to sing my praise,
 Now passed me in the public ways
 Unheedingly, with heads tossed high,
 As I were struck with leprosy?

Bitter- They'd pass me by with hop and skip
 sweet As one not worth an apple pip : 13550
 remem- And some, to whom I'd favour shown,
 brance Now voted me a wrinkled crone.
 It seemed as each would put on me
 Some new refined indignity.

Upon the other hand no man,
 How fine soe'er of feeling, can,
 Dear friend, believe the woes I felt,
 Or how mine eyes in tears would melt,
 When rose the picture in my mind
 Of old good days when kisses kind 13560
 Were showered upon me 'mid delights
 Of joyous days and passioned nights—
 Sweet words to sweeter actions wed.
 Alas ! for ever all are fled,
 Past over to return no more.
 Far better had a prison door
 Closed on me than that I were born,
 So soon. Ah God ! what scathing scorn
 Have fair gifts lost brought down on me,
 And consciousness they ne'er can be 13570
 Reclaimed hath sent a poisoned dart
 Of anguish through my wasted heart.
 I ask again, why was I born
 So soon ? unhappy wretch forlorn !
 Is there, but you, one single one
 To whom I can complain, dear son ?
 In nowise could my vengeance reach
 My foes so well as if I teach
 To you my doctrine for this end ;
 Thereon my breath I well may spend, 13580

With well-proved precepts how to be
 A scourge to those who scourgèd me ;
 And you right apt will be thereto
 Recalling all I say to you,
 Since you by happy chance have got
 So young a mind as faileth not
 To keep in memory the wit
 That old experience plants in it.
 For Plato said, long years agone,
 That, things which men in youth had known
 Stay fixed within the memory fast, 13591
 Though many a year be overpast.

A
 woman's
 revenge

Ah, dearest son, belovèd youth,
 If strong and young as you forsooth
 I were, the laws by Draco made
 My fierce revenge should cast in shade :
 Such vengeance on my foes I'd take,
 Before I could mine anger slake,
 As never yet was known ere now
 In all the world's great age I trow. 13600
 Those ribalds who have passed me by
 With mocks and jeers, insultingly,
 And have disdained my glance to meet,
 With open scorn in public street,
 Good Lord ! but they should dearly pay
 Whene'er arrived the reckoning day,
 For that contemptuous, scathing pride
 Wherewith they have my spirit tried.
 For, using the experience I
 Have learned through God's good clemency,
 Know you the fashion they should fare ? 13611
 In my turn would I pluck them bare ;

Regrets And then, as grapes within a press
are vain Are trod, I'd tread them ; penniless
 Should they be left, and foul worms feed
 Upon them in their direful need,
 Whilst on a dunghill should they lie
 Naked, in filth and misery.
 And those who, in my prosperous days,
 Were foremost in my love and praise, 18620
 Would I most cruelly entreat,
 And spurn like dogs beneath my feet,
 Aye, grind them to the very earth,
 And pill them till they were not worth
 A clove of garlick—it would fain
 My heart to see their need and pain,
 And bring them to such dire distress
 That they should on my footsteps press
 Stamping with rage.

Regrets are vain ;
 Time flown can ne'er return again, 18630
 Nor could I, of all those who bowed
 Before me ere my face was ploughed
 With wrinkles, keep on one my hold,
 My menace was a tale that's told,
 But, by the ribalds, I thereof
 Was warned erewhile with many a scoff.
 Believe you, much I wept therefor,
 Aye, and shall weep for evermore,
 Yet, when thereon I musing think,
 Long draughts of joy supreme I drink 18640
 From memory's well. Oh, dear delights !
 Whereof the very thought excites
 A thrill through every limb, as though
 The merry life of long ago

I lived once more. My body seems
 Rejuvenate, as in sweet dreams
 Sometimes appears. Now, by the rood,
 I swear it does me untold good
 To muse on youth's sweet joys, though I
 By men was cozened cruelly :
 No idle life a damsel leads
 Who makes her pleasures serve her needs.

Joys
 remem-
 bered

18650

Then to this country-side I came,
 And service took beneath the dame
 Who holds you here, and gives me
 charge

That hence you wander not at large.
 The Lord, who guards us all from ill,
 Grant that my duty I fulfil,
 And doubt I not this well may be,
 If you will walk but prudently.

18660

The charge, forsooth, were one of rare
 And special peril, seen how fair
 Nature hath made you, if your wit
 Did not your body's beauty fit :
 But you have prowess, sense, and grace ;
 And since that now both time and
 place

Serve us so well, nor need we fear
 To suffer from intruders here,
 'Tis well that you should list from me
 Good counsel, but you need not be
 Surprised to find my words but few.

18670

No will have I to press on you
 The theme of love and thereon preach,
 But since that goal you'll someday reach,

The Duenna's tale Suffer that I point out the way
 And paths thereof, where many a day
 I wandered ere my beauty went
 And left me wearied, worn and spent.

The Lover.

Then ceased the dame and gave a sigh,
 In case Fair-Welcome made reply. 13680
 But little rest of tongue she took,
 Noting his fixed attentive look,
 Prepared to listen and say nought;
 And so within herself she thought:
 A proverb 'tis: Who saith not nay,
 May well be credited with yea;
 Thus far he's listened, and no doubt,
 If I proceed, will hear me out.

Then once more did the crone begin
 Her wearisome foul tale to spin, 13690
 Deeming that she by wordy trick
 Might cozen me to try and lick
 Honey from thorns, and hoping he
 Might his mere friend consider me,
 Without true love, but he amain
 Told me the tale he heard again;
 And had he ta'en her word for truth
 I needs had been betrayed forsooth,
 But whatsoe'er the hag might do
 Or say, Fair-Welcome proved him true; 13700
 I had his solemn oath and word
 And that my heart had reassured.

The Duenna.

O dear sweet son, towards whom I yearn,
 'Tis my desire that you should learn
 Love's wiles, to save you from deceit.
 When you upon life's journey meet
 With Cupid, let my counsels guide
 Your steps, for no man ever tried
 That path untaught, but hath perforce
 Been stripped of all, till last his horse
 He needs must sell; I charge you hear
 My counsel which your way will clear,
 If you but heed the lore I tell,
 Who know love's art and mystery well.

Value of
 experi-
 ence

13710

LXXII

Herein the harridan prepares
 Fair-Welcome's mind for love affairs,
 And shows how evil women may,
 In love, both go and lead astray.

FAIR son, whoso of love is fain,
 That bitter-sweet, that pleasant pain, 13720
 Must Cupid's ten commandments know,
 Yet keep him at arm's length I trow.
 All these to you would I declare,
 Perceived I not how great a share
 Of each has nature deigned to bless
 You with, in her sweet kindness,
 Yea to the hilt that you can need.
 Ten are there, but fools only, heed
 The latter two, wise men dispense
 Therewith, not valuing them two pence. 13730

Cupid's
com-
mand-
ments

The former eight attend you well,
But he were under folly's spell
Who wasted on the other two
His time—'tis what a dolt would do.
Too great a burden 'tis to lay
Upon a lover when you say,
Though his large heart would all embrace,

With one alone must it enlace.
The son of Venus counsels this,
But sorely will he do amiss
Who follows his advice, and dear
Shall pay, as will at last appear.
In love, fair son, remain you free,
Fix not on one especially :
Suffer your heart at will to roam,
Nor lend nor give it to one home,
But let it be your constant boast
'That, his it is who pays the most,
Yet see the buyer doth not get
A bargain though his gold you sweat.
Above all, give it not away,
Better, burn, hang, or drown one may.
Remember, when you give, to twist
Your fingers fast with folded fist,
But taking, open wide your hand,
Fools only give, pray understand,
Except it be by way of lure,
Some fourfold profit to ensure,
Or in return fair gift to get :
Whereby good guerdon one may net ;
Such gifts as these will I allow,
For good it is to give, I trow,

18740

18750

18760

When one can make the gifts bear fruit ;
 Then largess doth with profit suit.
 Such giving no man need repent,
 Thereto I freely give consent.

Cupid's
 bow

As to that bow of rarest price
 And shafts of subtle artifice,
 You know their use and management
 Better than Love himself who spent 18770
 His life thereon, no greater craft
 Hath he the bow to bend, and shaft
 To speed, than you ; though oft you know
 Nothing of where those shafts may go.
 For when a shaft at random speeds,
 Some one of whom the archer heeds
 No jot, may by mere chance be hit,
 But you are known to be so fit
 And skilful when the bow you draw,
 That scarce you need to list my saw. 18780
 You may, God helping, chance to wound
 Some one whose conquest may be found
 Much to your profit. Need is none
 That I should lecture you upon
 The different deckings and attire
 Which often help a heart to fire,
 Nor what therein your choice should be.
 I should discourse but uselessly
 If you recall that song of old
 That from my lips hath often rolled, 18790
 As we together sat alone,
 Of passionate Pygmalion.
 You theace of dress much more may learn
 Than plough-beasts know of sods they turn.

Rich men Instruction in the art of dress,
exploited Is not, with you, my business.

And if all this doth not suffice
You presently shall hear advice,
If so you will, where you may find
Example of the clearest kind.
But would you in the meantime make,
Choice of a friend for friendship's sake,
Bestow your love, my dearest son,
On him who for yourself alone
Doth love you, but not recklessly;
Towards others let affection be
With purpose savoured, I will find
You many a one with purse well
lined.

13800

'Tis well to make some rich man friend,
Who feareth not his wealth to spend,
For him who knows to spoil and pill.
Fair-Welcome well might work his will
With such an one; he need but make
Believe that he for friend would take
None other for a heap of gold,
And swear that would he but have
sold

13810

The chance to some one else to kiss
The Rose, that treasury of bliss,
In gold and jewels might he swim,
But so his heart is true to him,
That none but he shall come anear
To share the prize he holds so dear.
Thousands may hear the same tale spun:
'Fair sir, you are the favoured one,

13820

May God's curse fall on me if I
Permit another to come nigh
The Rose.'

Lovers'
oaths

All reckless may he be
Of broken oaths and perjury;
Lovers' false oaths the Gods amuse,
Who all such crimes with smiles excuse. 13880
Great Jove and all the Gods loud laughed
At lovers' lies the while they quaffed
Their nectar, nor did they disdain
False oaths their wished-for ends to gain.
When Jupiter would reassure
Queen Juno, and her doubtings cure,
By the dark stream of Styx he sware,
Yet proved him perjured then and there.
Lovers the same course may pursue,
Nor feel one touch of shame thereto, 13840
But swear by altar, saints, and fane—
The Gods example gave amain.
The Lord forgive me, but none e'er
Should credit oaths that lovers swear;
For young folks' hearts are vain and
light,
Changing as oft as day and night,
And old men's too, for that, pardee!
Will swear false oaths right royally.

A proverb 'tis, known far and wide,
That, who doth o'er the fair preside 13850
Should first his own advantage mind;
And if one miller will not grind
Your corn, forthwith you go elsewhere.
The mouse who must perforce repair

One To one hole only, needs must be
 lover not In peril when 'tis his to flee.
 enough And so a damsel fair, ywis,
 When mistress of the field she is,
 And may at will her suitors fain,
 Good right hath she their gold to gain, 18860
 Nay, she would be a fool indeed
 Who failed her interest to speed
 Through giving all her love to one.
 I swear by Saint Lifard of Meun
 The fool doth all her 'vantage lose
 Who one from out the crowd doth choose.
 A captive she consents to be
 And falleth most deservedly
 To grief and misery a prey,
 For that on one she cast away 18870
 Her heart. If he abandon her,
 Where shall she find a comforter?
 For if a woman holdeth fast
 To one, his love will soon be past,
 And in the end, poor wretch, she's left
 Of friends, of goods, of hope, bereft.

LXXIII

This tells how Dido, mighty Queen
 Of Carthage, racked with sorrow keen
 For that great love she suffered through
 Æneas, with a sword-thrust slew 13890
 Herself, and how fair Phillis won
 A cruel death through Demophon.

DIDO, great queen of Carthage, strove
 Vainly to keep Æneas' love,

Who owed to her whate'er he had,
 For she received him when the sad
 City of Troy in flames he fled,
 And reached her shores to misery wed.
 His comrades dealt she no small share
 Of honour, for the love she bare 18890
 To him, and bade his ships refit,
 With many a storm, bulged, torn, and split ;
 And in her passion vowed that he
 Lord of her realm and self should be ;
 In turn, great oaths Æneas swore
 His heart was hers for evermore,
 And soul and body would he give
 To her, and in her love would live.

Alas ! small joy her kindness sped ;
 Ere long, the faithless lover fled 18900
 O'er the bright sea without one word
 To her, who died whenso she heard
 His treachery, for she straight withdrew
 Into her chamber, and pierced through
 Her loving heart with selfsame sword
 He erst had borne, her love and lord.

Unhappy Dido, who in mind
 Still kept her traitorous love unkind,
 Seized the bright blade, and as she stood
 Naked, the point with hardihood 18910
 Thrust 'neath her breasts, twin hills of
 snow,
 And fell thereon to end her woe.
 O grievous sight, O sad to see !
 Full hard of heart that man must be,

Legend Who could behold, with heart unmoved,
of fair How thus her constancy was proved
women Towards the treacherous man through whom
 Her joyous life met death's grim doom.

And Phillis fair, who did await
 Her Demophon, disconsolate, 18920
 And, for he came not, with a cord
 Sought death, since false she proved his word.

Of Paris and CEnone hear—
 She, body and soul, forgetting fear,
 Gave up to him ; with what return ?
 Alas ! her love he did but spurn.
 Small letters on the trees he cut
 To tell her of his flitting ; but
 Her love reflected not his heart ;
 He less esteemed it than a tart. 18930
 These letters were right skilfully
 Engraven on a poplar tree,
 And said, till Xanthus sought again
 His source, he faithful would remain ;
 Alas ! though that did ne'er occur,
 For Helen he deserted her.

Was not Medea, beauteous maid,
 By Jason treacherously betrayed,
 Who perjured him, though she, to save
 His life, both home and honour gave, 18940
 When the fierce bulls with breath of fire
 Would work on him destruction dire ?
 She braved the flames with subtle charms,
 Subdued the beasts and saved from harms.

**Medea's
revenge**

Her lover ; then the dragon dread
 Her song soothed till he slumberèd,
 Nor from that sleep awaked he more
 Till Jason gained the golden store.
 And when earth's warriors, wild and fierce,
 Would fain his heart with swordpoint pierce,
 Her sorcery and magic skill 18951
 Did so that host with madness fill
 That, when amid them Jason threw
 A stone, no man his fellow knew
 But all in desperate combat fought
 Till each from each his death-blow bought,
 And so the Golden Fleece she wan
 For that well-loved, but false-heart man.
 That comfort he might have, forsooth,
 His father Æson unto youth 18960
 Restored she, and the sole reward
 She asked him was, that he would toward
 Her love return his love again.
 Alas ! fond hope ! misplaced and vain.
 His false heart soon forgot the good
 She wrought, in loving hardihood,
 And in the ending set above
 Her head a new and younger love.
 Hearing hereof she could not brook
 Her wretchedness, but madly took 18970
 Her children, (in her sore distress
 Blind to a mother's tenderness,)
 And strangled them, more ruthless she
 Than stepdames oft have proved to be.

A thousand more such tales could I
 Relate, but time too swift doth fly.

A These ribalds all play double parts,
woman's And to a thousand give their hearts.
arts And wherefore should not women do
 The same, and love as freely too ? 13980
 She's but a fool, who fixes on
 One man, and clings to him alone.
 A woman should have hosts of friends,
 And play them all, to serve her ends,
 'Gainst one another. If no grace
 She hath, 'tis well she set her face
 To gain it, and should be most high
 And haughty unto those who try
 To please her best, and towards those be
 Most kind, who treat her distantly. 13990

Fair sports and songs 'tis hers to know,
 And strife and reprimands forego.
 If she be plain, by dainty dress,
 Should she repair ill-favouredness ;
 And should it hap, to her dismay,
 Her thick blond tresses fall away,
 Or even though they have not dropped
 By nature, they have needs been cropped
 By reason of some malady,
 And thus her beauty wasted be ; 14000
 Or if some ribald, anger led,
 Hath torn the hair from off her head,
 With rage so cruel as to leave
 No locks she can in braidings weave ;
 Then, with a view to clothe her pate,
 Hair must she get of one who late
 Hath died, or yellow silk must tie
 Beneath neat fillets skilfully.

Above her ears she'll bear such horns
 As neither stags or unicorns
 Could boast if they should dare to plight
 Themselves with her in deadly fight.
 Or if she have the need to dye
 Her hair, she should most carefully
 Choose the right plants; leaves, bark, and root,
 Will each the varied purpose suit.

Beauty's
 14010 devices

And lest her bloom of cheek grow pale,
 Whereat her spirit well might fail,
 She should within her chamber keep
 Sweet unguents, that she thence may reap 14020
 A secret freshness; yet have care
 They are not known by sight or flair
 To lovers, or 'twould breed despite.
 If she hath neck and bosom white,
 Then let her cut her bodice low,
 Her fair and dazzling skin to show,
 Two palms behind and eke before,
 There's no device attracts men more.
 If she hath shoulders set too high
 Judges of form to satisfy 14080
 At balls and routs, fine lawn I guess
 Would lessen their unseemliness.
 If hands she hath nor fine nor fair,
 But corned and blistered here and there,
 'Twere well, that with a bodkin she
 Should dress and tend them carefully,
 Or better still, with gloves should hide
 Defects—no man need pry inside.
 And if her breasts too ample grow,
 A swathe-cloth should she bind below 14040

To hide defects | To bear them up, and hold them tight
 Against her chest. When thus she's dight
 She'll find that she can move with ease,
 And lightly dance, if so she please.

And, if a dainty, well-bred quean,
 Her Venus chamber keeps she clean ;
 No spider webs will there be found,
 And things unseemly from the ground
 She'll sweep, dust, burn, and clear away,
 E'en as a thrifty housewife may. 14050
 Is her leg ugly? ne'er 'tis bare.
 Too large her foot? 'tis shod with care.
 More wily she than e'er neglect
 To hide with skill the least defect.
 If she be cursed with noisome breath,
 It doth not worry her to death,
 But heed she taketh not to speak
 To any till her fast she break,
 And careful is her mouth ne'er goes
 Too closely towards her lover's nose. 14060
 When laughter doth provoke her, so
 She laughs that two sweet dimples show
 About her mouth, on either side,
 The which she never opes right wide
 In laughing, but conceals beneath
 A well-set smile, her doubtful teeth.
 A woman if she laugh or smile
 Should keep her mouth close shut the while,
 For if too wide she open it
 It looks as though her cheeks were slit; 14070
 And if her teeth are nothing grand,
 But crossed and out of order stand,

'Tis just as well that they remain
 Fast hid, would she not win disdain.
 Women should learn to cry with grace,
 But they so oft find time and place
 For tears, I need not teach them how
 To weep, that soon enough they trow,
 For every woman in her eye
 Stores tears, and one and all can cry 14080
 At will. A man should not disturb
 Himself thereat, but check and curb
 His pity, even though he sees
 The tears fall fast as rain from trees.
 When women cry at will, 'tis not
 That they some cruel grief have got,
 But mere vexation and chagrin
 That some vile trick they're baffled in.
 A woman's tears are but a trap,
 Oft-times they flow for no ill hap, 14090
 But with desire that she may nought
 By word or deed betray her thought.

Of
 women's
 tears

She should behave her when at table
 In manner fit and convenable;
 But should, ere yet she takes her place,
 'Fore all the household show her face,
 To let those present understand
 That she much business hath in hand.
 Hither and thither should she flit
 And be the last of all to sit, 14100
 Making the company await
 While scanneth she each dish and plate;
 And when at last down sitteth she,
 On each and all her eye should be.

Manners Before the guests should she divide
at table The bread and see each one supplied.
 Then let her know the heart to win
 Of some one guest by putting in
 His platter dainty morsels, or
 A wing or leg of fowl before
 Him sets she, or with choicest slice
 Of pork or beef will she entice
 His appetite, or savoury fish,
 If of the day that be the dish.
 No stint she makes, if he permits,
 To ply his taste with choicest bits.

14110

'Tis well she take especial care
 That in the sauce her fingers ne'er
 She dip beyond the joint, nor soil
 Her lips with garlick, sops, or oil,
 Nor heap up gobbets and then charge
 Her mouth with pieces overlarge,
 And only with the finger point
 Should touch the bit she'd fain anoint
 With sauce, white, yellow, brown, or
 green,
 And lift it towards her mouth between
 Finger and thumb with care and skill,
 That she no sauce or morsel spill
 About her breast-cloth.

14120

Then her cup
 She should so gracefully lift up
 Towards her mouth that not a gout
 By any chance doth fall about
 Her vesture, or for glutton rude,
 By such unseemly habitude,

14180

Might she be deemed.

Nor should she set

Lips to her cup while food is yet
Within her mouth.

Drink
moder-
ately

And first should she

Her upper lip wipe delicately,
Lest, having drunk, a grease-formed goath
Were seen upon the wine to float. 14140

She should not take one long-breathed
draught,

Whether from cup or hanap quaffed,
But gently taste with sipping soft
Now and again, but not too oft,
Though thirst impels, at large should drink,

Lest those around perchance should think
Or say, if she the cup should clutch

With eager haste : She drinks too much ;
Therefore should she the tempting tide

Resist, nor grip the goblet's side 14150

Like some of that fat matron crew,
So gluttonous and boorish, who

Pour wine adown their cavernous throats
Enough to fill a horseman's boots,

Till lastly are their gullets full,
And all their senses drowned and dull.

She should avoid all such excess
As leadeth on to drunkenness,

For drunken folk no secrets keep,

And if a woman drinketh deep 14160

She leaves herself without defence,

And jangles much with little sense.

To any man she falls a prey

When thus her wits she casts away.

Time She should not at the table close
goes Her eyes in sleep, nor even doze,
quickly For many a strange untoward thing
 Hath happed to dames thus slumbering ;
 Such places are not made for sleep,
 'Tis wiser far good watch to keep, 14170
 For often folk mishaps have known
 Thus sleeping : many have tumbled down
 Supine, or prone, or on the side,
 And grievous hurt sustained, or died :
 She should, who feels disposed to wink,
 Of Palinurus' ending think,
 Who governed well Æneas' helm
 Until he fell within the realm
 Of Morpheus, then straight toppled he
 From off the ship, and in the sea 14180
 Was drowned before his comrades' eyes,
 Who mourned his watery obsequies.

Woman should gather roses ere
 Time's ceaseless foot o'ertaketh her,
 For if too long she make delay,
 Her chance of love may pass away,
 And well it is she seek it while
 Health, strength, and youth around her
 smile.

To pluck the fruits of love in youth
 Is each wise woman's rule forsooth, 14190
 For when age creepeth o'er us, hence
 Go also the sweet joys of sense,
 And ill doth she her days employ
 Who lets life pass without love's joy.
 And if my counsel she despise,
 Not knowing how 'tis just and wise,

Too late, alas! will she repent
 When age is come, and beauty spent.
 But wifful women will believe
 My words, and thankfully receive 14200
 My counsels and my rules will foster
 With care, and many a paternoster
 Say for my soul's health when I die
 For teaching them so worthily.
 Well know I that these golden rules
 Shall long be taught in noblest schools.

Make
 known
 love's
 precepts

Fair son, if long you see earth's light,
 Most clearly I perceive you'll write
 My laws and precepts in a book,
 And many a time therein will look, 14210
 Please God, when hence from me you're gone
 And, duly pondering thereupon,
 In knowledge shall outrival me,
 And, e'en as I, a teacher be,
 Despite the highest chancellors,
 In halls, in chambers and boudoirs,
 In copse, and garden-close and field
 Or nooks by friendly curtains sealed.
 And let your scholars learn my lore,
 In wardrobe-room and threshing-floor, 14220
 In stables or out-offices,
 Failing of better spots than these,
 And there my precepts should be read,
 When you their force have mastered.
 Abroad a woman oft should go,
 For all the less that she doth show
 Herself, the fewer men will press
 Around to seek her loveliness,

Woman's And sooner she'll be left in lurch.
 attire 'Twere well she haunt the minster church, 14230
 And visitations oft attend,
 And marriages, and duly wend
 In high processions; fêtes and plays
 Should she frequent on holidays,
 For in such places, rathe and late,
 Venus and Cupid celebrate
 High mass. But erst should she in
 glass,
 Upon her tiring, judgment pass,
 And when she deems it quite the thing
 Should sally forth philandering, 14240
 With dignified and high regard,
 Not over meek, nor yet too hard,
 Pleasant of look, with modest eye,
 Nor over-forward, nor too shy.
 Her shoulders and her hips should move
 So gracefully that all approve
 Her progress as of beauty's queen.
 Upon her well-shaped feet I ween,
 Most carefully-made boots she'll set,
 Whereof the joints so well are met, 14250
 That, not a plait or crease will show,
 But on her legs they'd seem to grow;
 And if her costly garment trail
 Along the road, she will not fail
 Both fore and aft with studied care
 To raise it, as she'd catch the air,
 Or, as she knows right well to do,
 She just uplifts her gown a few
 Short inches, quicker pace to suit,
 Disclosing thus her winsome foot, 14260

With hope that all the passers by
Its mignon form and turn may spy.

Woman's
attire

In case she doth a mantle wear,
She should upon her shoulders bear
It so, that it but little hides
The contour of her shapely sides.
And also that she better may
Her body's shape, and clothes, display,
(Which neither thick nor thin should be,
But pearled, and broidered gallantly 14270
With silver, and an alms-purse tied,
In view of all, against her side,)
Her mantle upwards towards her head
Should she with straightened arms outspread,
Whether the way be foul or clean,
After the fashion she has seen
A peacock spread his tail; she may
So sport the mantle, whether grey
Or green it chance to be, that thus
She shows her figure amorous 14280
To all the gallants that she meets
As sails she through the crowded streets.

Should Nature have forgot to trace
The line of beauty in her face,
Her golden locks she will, if wise,
Display to dazzle suitors' eyes
In comely plaits about her neck.
Nothing doth women better deck
And crown, than glory of the hair.

Women should imitate with care 14290

A The tactics of the wolf; when she
 woman's A sheep would seize with certainty,
 policy That she of one may make her sure
 A hundred must her fangs endure.
 A woman, likewise, should her net
 So spread as many a man to get
 Within her toils; but seen she nought
 Can tell which 'tis that may be caught,
 With view at very least to fix
 One man, on all should play her tricks. 14300
 It scarce can happen otherwise,
 But that among the fools she tries
 By thousands, she must find some one
 To do all that she would have done.
 Nay, many, for 'tis truly said
 Art lends to nature potent aid.

And if she several hooketh in,
 Who equally her grace would win,
 Most carefully should she arrange
 The meeting hours to interchange, 14810
 For if two happed to come together,
 Good chance there were of stormy weather,
 And danger is, they seeing through
 Her scheme, she fail of both the two,
 Shamed and abased, and what e'en worse
 She'd count, lose hold on each one's purse.
 But not to any should she give
 The chance to keep enough to live,
 But unto such condition bring
 Her lovers, that of everything 14820
 Stripped bare, they'd have no choice but die
 In hunger, debt, and misery.

Of every penny let her reive them,
 For 'tis her loss if aught she leave them.
 From poor and needy men should she
 Have special care to keep her free ;
 Ovid or Homer void of cash
 Would not be worth a cat's eyelash.

Beware
 of tra-
 vellers

A traveller should she never give
 Her heart to, for as he doth live 14830
 Now here, now there, e'en so will he
 Affection shift as easily
 As he his body doth. If wise
 My counsel will she so far prize
 As let no guest her fancy take,
 But if, while sojourning, he make
 Of jewels, gold, or gems fair offer,
 Let her secure them, locked in coffer,
 And then may she fulfil his pleasure,
 Whether in haste or at her leisure. 14840
 Above all else should she beware
 She set her love on that man ne'er
 Who in his beauty taketh pride ;
 Such imbeciles the Gods deride
 And scorn, for thus saith Ptolemy,
 A master of all science he :
 " Such man hath nought of love in him,
 With selfish pride his heart's abrim,
 The love that he to one declares,
 In turn he to another swears, 14850
 And many a woman treateth ill,
 For all he meets he'll spoil and pill : "
 And many a damsel have I heard
 Cry shame on such an one's false word.

A Should some loud promiser appear,
woman's Whether a trickster or sincere,
wiles And seek to gain her love with great
 And solemn vows his life and fate
 To link with hers,—so be it ; but
 Let her be wary not to put
 Herself within his power, unless
 He doth a well-filled purse possess.
 And if love-letters one indite,
 Let her weigh closely if he write
 With false intention, or his mood
 Of heart be honest, pure, and good ;
 Then let her forward a reply—
 After a pause—coy, short, and shy ;
 Delay but brings a lover on,
 Yet that were lightly overdone,
 And when a lover's suit is pressed,
 'Tis wise that she awhile protest.
 Reluctance, not the whole refuse,
 But coyly smirk and half excuse,
 Now hold him off, now draw him near,
 In balance kept 'twixt hope and fear.

14360

14370

As he more vehement doth grow,
 More hesitation should she show,
 Seeing that she his heart doth hold
 Tightly as in a serpent's fold,
 Resisting by all means she can,
 Assured reluctance doth but fan
 His flame, then by degrees her fear
 Subsides, and she should soothe and cheer
 His heart with many a tender word,
 And so they come to sweet accord.

14380

Lightly
won
lightly
held

And then will she his heart beguile,
By God and all the saints the while
Swearing that only he at last
Hath all her scruples overpast,
And cries: "Fulfilled is now your hope,
But, by the faith I owe the Pope,
I yield to you for love alone,
Through presents had you never won
My virgin heart; the man lives not
Who e'er through gifts my love had got,
You only have full favour found
Of all the host that fluttered round.
Ah! wicked one, who knew to pitch
The note that might my soul bewitch."
And then, the dotard to deceive,
Sweet clips and kisses should she give.
But, if she follows my advice,
She boldly will demand her price,
And is a fool unless she win
All that he hath outside his skin,
For she the best beloved will be
Who strips a man most ruthlessly.
The more that women make men pay,
The more, far more, beloved are they;
For that which lightly is obtained,
Is never looked upon when gained
Above the value of a straw,
A thing of nought, a mere gewgaw.
But if a worthless thing cost much,
That a man holds with hardfist clutch.

14890

14400

14410

To fleece a gull may many aid:
Her valets, and her chambermaid,

Assistant Her sister, nurse, and many another,
harpies And e'en with equal zest her mother 14420
 Will need anointing in the palms
 To quiet conscientious qualms ;
 Robes, mantles, gloves, and such delights,
 They'll pounce upon like ravening kites.
 When once the victim's in their grip,
 With utter ruthlessness they'll strip
 Their prey, till scarce doth he possess
 A rag to hide his nakedness.
 Jewels and gold he'll give as though
 Nuts were they off a hazel bough. 14430
 Soon comes the banquet to an end,
 When many mouths assistance lend,
 And then they cry aloud : " Good sir,
 'Twere well you should your purse-strings
 stir
 To give our lady something new
 Of vesture ; doth it trouble you
 So little ? By St. Giles, I know
 One who for her would quickly show
 His bounty, she through him, I ween,
 Might drive her carriage like a queen ! " 14440
 And to the damsel would they say :
 " Wherefore then make you such delay
 To ask more gifts ? Why not more bold ?
 His love to you grows slack and cold."
 And she, though with their words content,
 Should bid that they such speech forewent,
 Vowing she hath no fault to find,
 Unless 'tis that he's overkind.
 But if she note that he's aware
 That ruin in his face doth stare, 14450

And soon must he to beggary fall
 Since in her lap he's cast his all,
 She judges she may spare the task
 More costly gifts from him to ask ;
 Yet should implore him as her friend
 That to relieve her needs he'll lend
 His credit, and on given day
 Swear that the whole will she repay.
 But all return would be by me
 Forbidden most unflinchingly.

She
 pleads
 poverty

14460

Then if among her friends she find
 A second suited to her mind
 (For though she many a friend hath got
 She keeps herself heart-whole I wot),
 To him should she declare amain
 That she her best gown hath been fain
 To leave in pawn, alas, for her !
 While daily to the usurer
 Must she resort, whereat is she
 Distressed and troubled grievously,
 And nought need he expect increase
 Of favour, but if he release
 Her pledges. If 'neath folly's curse
 He lies, and bears a brimming purse,
 He'll dip his hand therein, or take
 Some means to borrow for her sake
 The sum she needs, which is in truth
 No sum whate'er, since she forsooth
 Hath got her best robes locked away
 Secure from dust and light of day,
 Yet impudently bids him look
 On every perch, and search each nook.

14470

14480

The
victim
plucked
bare

If he to trust her word disdain,
And so she gets the gold amain.
For a last squeezing she demands
A silver girdle at his hands,
Or wimple fair, to deck her head,
And gold her follies to bestead.
If he, unable to supply
Such things, yet seeks to satisfy
Her cravings, by expressing sorrow
And bezants vows to bring to-morrow,
To all his promises should she
Her ears shut fast inexorably.

14490

All men are naturally liars—
In dear days past vile flatterers
More oaths towards me have used to leaven
Their lies, than are there saints in heaven.
If no gold pieces he can spin,
At least can he some wine send in
On credit, or if not, he may
Take himself off, elsewhere to play.

14500

Unless a woman's void of sense,
Of shrinking fear she'll make pretence,
Affect to tremble, shake and shiver,
And 'neath quick apprehensions quiver
When she receiveth furtively
Her friend, and let him plainly see
The dangers she for him doth dare,
Saying, were spouse and friends aware
Of that she doth, most surely they,
Surprising them, would make her pay
With life the fond affection she
Bears towards him, while alas! that he

14510

If found there would beyond all doubt
Still living see her heart torn out :
And then he surely will remain
When once within her toils he's ta'en.

Pre-
tended
jealousy

'Tis well she should remember when
Her friend she may expect again ; 14520
And if there's no one on the watch
Let her undo the window latch
(Although the door serves better far),
Swearing the while that lost they are,
And may account themselves as dead
Should they be thus discoverèd,
For neither buckler, club, nor glaive
For one short hour their lives could
save,
Nor secret chambers guarantee
But what they should dismembered be. 14580

And then should she assume an air
Of anger mingled with despair.
And fall on him with great disdain,
Demanding why doth he remain
So long away—she doubteth not
The reason is that he hath got
Some other he prefers to her ;
Younger perchance, and merrier,
To whom, forsooth, his time he gives,
While she, alas ! neglected lives : 14640
Ah ! well may she with anguish burn
Who loves, but wins not love's return.
And when he hears her thus complain
'Twill work like fire within his brain,

Venus And forthwith will he deem that she
and Loves him with mad intensity,
Vulcan And is of him as jealous as
 In olden days God Vulcan was
 Of Venus, whom he found at play
 With Mars, when Phœbus brought the day, 14550
 [Trapped in the brazen net he'd wrought.
 On his own head contempt he brought
 When thus he proved himself betrayed;
 And openwise a cuckold made.

LXXIV

How Vulcan once espied his wife
 Engaged with Mars in amorous strife,
 When cunningly he threw a snare
 Around the fond but guilty pair.

WHENE'ER Dan Vulcan, dunderhead,
 Had spied the amorous twain in bed, 14560
 Around the couch a net he threw
 (Which was an foolish thing to do;
 For little wotteth he of life
 Who thinks he only hath his wife),
 And then the gods did he convoke,
 Who crowded round with gibe and joke,
 Beholding how the pair were ta'en.
 But many 'mong the host, with pain,
 Beheld dame Venus' sore distress,
 While marvelling at her loveliness; 14570
 Nor heard unmoved her bitter cries
 At suffering such indignities

Before her peers in open day.
 Yet 'twas no marvel, one would say,
 That Venus unto Mars should give
 Herself—for could she care to live
 With Vulcan, black from head to foot,
 Hands, face, and throat begrimed with soot?
 Such things in Venus' breast must rouse
 Disgust, though Vulcan were her spouse. 14580
 Nay, even though she had been paired
 With Absalom the golden-haired,
 Or lovely Paris, Priam's son,
 She scarce had been content with one,
 For ever would that beauteous queen
 Do what all women love I ween.

Women
 free as
 men

Women as free as men are born ;
 It is the law alone hath torn
 Their charter, and that freedom riven
 From out their hands by Nature given. 14590
 For Nature is not such a fool
 As order, by unbending rule,
 Margot to keep to Robichon,
 Nor yet for him the only one
 To be Marie or fair Perrette,
 Jane, Agnes, or sweet Mariette,
 But as, dear son, I scarce need teach,
 Made each for all and all for each,
 And every one for all alike,
 E'en as the taste and fancy strike. 14600
 So that (although by marriage law
 They are assigned like things of straw),
 To satisfy Dame Nature's call,
 To which they hearken one and all,

What And strifes and murders to avoid,
Horace Whereto they well might be decoyed,
saith Ever have women, foul or fair,
 Whether the name of maid they bear,
 Or wife, done all within their power
 To win back freedom as their dower ; 14610
 Though at great hazards they maintain
 Their rights, and evils thick as rain
 Have happed both now and formerly.
 Ten, nay, a hundred easily,
 Could I of instances set forth ;
 But let them pass as nowise worth
 My pains to tell or yours to hear,
 You'd weary ere the end came near.

If any man beheld a dame,
 In primal days, who lit a flame 14620
 Within his heart, he thought no
 wrong
 To seize her, until one more strong
 Should rob him of her, or he changed.
 His mind and somewhat further ranged.
 But hence arose contention great,
 And homes were oft left desolate ;
 And so by wise men were laid down
 The laws as those of marriage known.

If you possess both will and wit
 To heark what Roman Horace writ, 14630
 Give me your ear while I set forth
 The wisdom of that man of worth ;
 A woman, free of shame, may quote
 Whate'er so great an author wrote :

Foretime, in Helen's days, broke out
 Full many a hard-fought battle rout
 For woman's love, and many died
 Who in that strife their valiance tried;
 And who shall say how many more
 Than those set down in ancient lore? 14640
 Not first was Helen, nor will she
 Be last of those, unhappily,
 Through whom have risen and will rise
 Wars among men, whose hearts and eyes
 Women have blinded, till away
 They throw their lives; the latest day
 Of earth shall see this selfsame thing,
 That hath been since first broke the spring.
 Regard dame Nature, and then hear
 Her strength and wondrous power made clear 14650
 Through many examples which shall be
 Clearly expounded presently.

The cap-
 tive bird

LXXV

Herein examples may you see
 Of Nature's power and subtlety.

THE bird which from the wood is lured,
 Captured, and in gay cage immured,
 Tended with gentle love and care,
 And fed with choice and dainty fare,
 With pleasant song our ear enchants,
 But yet one thing doth lack, it pants 14660
 Once more to flit among the boughs
 And branches which so well it knows
 And where 'twould once more gladly be.
 In vain you nurse it tenderly,

Women Ever it pineth to regain
love That liberty whereof 'tis fain :
liberty Its food it treads beneath its feet,
 And 'gainst the bars its wings doth beat,
 And up and down its prison goes
 From daylight's dawn till twilight's
 close,

14670

Seeking its passage to make good
 Through door or window to the wood.
 And every woman doth possess
 Within her that same restlessness,
 Whatever her condition be,
 Matron or maid ; unceasingly
 { One only thought hath she in mind,
 { Which is, how she may some way find
 { Her ancient liberty to get,
 { Thereon, 'fore all, her heart is set.

14680

And so it is with every wight
 Who hath him in a cloister pight,
 For so he feels repentance' pang
 That almost he for rage would hang
 Himself, he hath but one desire,
 Which burneth up his heart like fire ;
 He pants once more for liberty,
 And vain the struggle findeth he
 With change of frock to change his bent
 For worldly pleasure ;—sacrament
 And holy vows are nought to him,

14690

E'en so a foolish fish doth swim
 Within a net, whose mouth is wide
 For entry, but when once inside,

Shuts on him, and for evermore
 A prisoner stays he, till ashore
 He's cast to die ; but those without
 Crowd round untroubled by a doubt
 But what he hath great plenitude
 Therein of leisure, peace, and food, 14700
 When they perceive him wheel and turn
 As if content, and fain would learn
 How they may likewise live at ease
 With nought to do except appease
 Their hunger, and the livelong day
 They pass in seeking out some way
 By which they too may enter in
 And equal life of joyance win :
 They vex and worry them to get
 An entry to that envied net, 14710
 But once within, they must remain,
 Escape past hope, repentance vain,
 And they therein their lives must spend
 Till friendly death brings welcome end.

The
 netted
 fish

So each bright youth to servitude
 Doth go who takes the monkish hood,
 For neither cowl, nor broad-brimmed hat,
 Nor cloister gown, can smother that
 Which Nature in his heart did plant,
 And, unfulfilled, still leaves a want. 14720
 He's worse than dead, for all his life
 Is racked and torn by mental strife,
 Or else with broken spirit he
 Plays virtue 'gainst necessity.
 Dame Nature lieth not, but still
 His mind with bitter thoughts doth fill

Example of the cat Of freedom lost : Horace this thing
 Saith well, 'tis worth remembering :
 " Though any man should seize a fork,
 To drive dame Nature from her work, 14730
 Beat her, and chase her out of doors,
 She'll quick return to pay old scores."
 What matters it? Do what you will,
 Each living creature must fulfil
 Its nature, and although you drive
 It far, it will return and thrive ;
 Nature despiseth violence,
 And hath of man-made law small sense :
 And thus finds Venus fair excuse
 When she from trammels breaketh loose ; 14740
 And so it is with dames, I trow,
 Who chafe beneath the marriage-vow.
 Nature it is who draws them still
 Towards freedom, or for good or ill,
 And she so strong is that in vain
 Men seek her power to curb and rein.

If one should take, dear son, a cat
 That ne'er had known of mouse or rat,
 And feed him up most tenderly
 With choicest meats, nor let him see 14750
 By any chance or rat or mouse,
 Yet if should run across the house
 Or one or other in his view,
 Like bolt from bow he'll 'scape from you
 And snap it up, for Nature 'tis
 Impelleth him thereto ywis ;
 He'll rather hunt a mouse than sate
 His maw with morsels delicate,

For 'twixt the twain can never be
Treaty of peace and amity.

14760 **Example
of the
horse**

Or if a new-foaled colt you rear,
So that he ne'er beholds a mare
Till he becomes a full-grown steed
For bit and saddle good at need ;
A jennet comes within his sight,
At once he neighs with proud delight,
And speedeth madly o'er the field,
Unless he needs to rein must yield.
Not only black steed seeks a black,
But brown, or grey as soon will back, 14770
Or roan, or any other strain,
Unless he's held by bridle-rein.
He troubles not to spy around,
But gaily takes them as they're found,
And in succession serves them all,
If but the chance to him befall.
So with a little chestnut mare,
Unless she be restrained with care,
She'll seek brown, grey, and black in turns
E'en as desire within her burns ; 14780
The first one that her fancy takes,
Husband of him she straightway makes.
And what of horse and mare, I say,
Whether black, brown, or roan, or grey,
Is likewise true of bull and cow,
And eke of ram and ewe, I trow,
For rest assured that each of these
Of either sex make free to please
And suit themselves, as e'en they may,
With spouse at will from day to day. 14790

Bold So is it, by my soul, I swear,
avowal Fair son, with every human pair,
 Although the law doth claim of right
 To check somewhat the appetite.
 Somewhat! methinks, a deal too much,
 For when folk fall within the clutch
 Of law, it bids that each shall cling
 To each in every mortal thing,
 And husband seek his wife alone,
 And she be his both flesh and bone, 14800
 And both shall each to other give
 Themselves, unchanging while they live;
 Yet each, forsooth, doth long to be
 From all restraint and bondage free.
 And those who view this thing with clear
 Impartial eye will know 'tis fear
 And shame alone that hold folk back,
 Who else would tread in Nature's track,
 And, like the cattle, follow sense:
 Thereof I've had experience 14810
 Myself, for I would give away
 My love to any day by day.
 And had I not been cowed by shame,
 Which curbs the will of many a dame,
 When through the town I marching went
 (Which none could hinder or prevent),
 So decked and dizen'd, all might know
 The part I played, from outward show,
 And saw well-liking varlets cast
 Soft looks upon me as I passed 14820
 (Good Lord! what tremors through me
 ran
 Exchanging glances with a man),

Not one, but all would I embrace,
 Could I but find fit time and place ;
 Giving to each in turn his due
 Had I been equal thereunto ;
 And each had will, as I believe,
 In turn my favours to receive :
 Prelate or monk except I not,
 Nor knight, nor canon, sage or sot,
 Burgess or friar, within my fold
 All would I take, if not too old.
 Religion they'd have cast aside,
 Except they feared to be denied
 When they should court me. If that they
 Had only understood my way
 Of thinking, as of women all,
 Such fear they ne'er had let befall
 Their hearts. Each one, had they
 dared,

All men
 faithless

14830

I trow, had readily declared
 Their wedlock void, that they to me
 Might give themselves all utterly,
 Religion spurning, and despite
 Of oath or honour, faith or right,
 Except perchance, 'twere some poor fool,
 Who ne'er had let his love grow cool
 For her whose heart he'd gained in youth.
 Such one would courteously, forsooth,
 Decline my love and turn to her
 His well-beloved sweet comforter.
 But lovers of that sort are rare.
 By God and Saint Amand I swear,
 If only opportunity
 Of time and place were given to me

14840

14850

Mars and Venus To talk with such an one on love,
 If lies or truth his tongue should move
 And whether he lay or churchman were,
 Or regular or secular,
 Cinctured with girdle grey or red,
 Or hood or hat bedecked his head, 14860
 He should right soon declare his flame,
 Whether in me he saw the same
 To burn, or only deemed a whim
 I had myself to yield to him.
 Nature for ever busies her,
 Desire in all men's hearts to stir,
 Therefore, dear son, should we be slow
 Venus and Mars to blame, I trow.
 And though the Gods in mockery laughed
 To see the pair by Vulcan's craft 14870
 Ensnared, yet many a one full fain
 Had been, could he the place have ta'en
 Of Mars, in Venus' fond embrace,
 While Vulcan, mad with his disgrace,
 Two thousand marks had rather given
 Than cuckold stand before high heaven.
 The pair he thus exposed to shame,
 Reckless of scorn henceforth became,
 And boldly practised that which they
 Strove erst to hide from light of day, 14880
 Shame and decorum cast aside.
 And then the Gods told far and wide
 The tale, till all through heaven 'twas
 known,
 From mouth to mouth mid laughter thrown.
 And Vulcan stormed with rage to think
 The draught he brewed he needs must drink,

Folly of
Jealousy

Since for his folly nought could he
Find balsam, salve, or remedy.
Rather than trap the twain, indeed,
'Twere wiser to have given no heed,
But silently resolve in mind
To be to Venus' failings blind,
So long as she towards him behaved
With kindness, granting all he craved.

14890

From this, let no man e'er forget
That grievous folly 'tis to set
A trap whereby a wife may be
Convicted of inconstancy ;
For if she find her thus exposed,
The door of virtue feels she closed
Behind her, and the unhappy wretch,
Whom evil-eyed suspicions stretch
Upon the rack, when he hath caught
His wife, shall ne'er again know aught
Of peace or happiness, but die
The prey of cruel Jealousy.]

14900

(Continued
from l.
14550)

But she, forsooth, doth merely make
Pretence of jealousy to wake
His anger, and yet cause that he
With love may burn more ardently.

14910

And if he parry not the stroke,
But saith, her anger to provoke,
'Tis true he hath another friend ;
Then she, with view to gain her end,
Should cry : No button doth she care,
What is his other love to her ?

A For knows she all the while that he
woman's Thereto entends not seriously.
sense Then in her turn will she, with mind
 More closely round his heart to wind 14920
 Her toils, pretend some other is
 More suited to her taste, ywis,
 And fain of him would she be quit,
 Exclaiming : 'Tis but right and fit,
 Since I am cuckolded by you,
 That our old love were broken through.
 Is it surprising if I wish
 We both should eat from out one dish ?
 And then shall he be vexed above
 All measure, if so be he love 14930
 Her fondly, reft his chief delight ;
 For no man feels love's flame burn bright
 Within his breast, but's racked with dread,
 Lest horns, perchance, adorn his head.

Then, as if some wild beast gave chase,
 The chambermaid, with fear-struck face,
 Runs in, and cries : Alas ! we're lost,
 The master hath this moment crossed
 The fore-court ! When the damsel hears
 This cry, her face wild terror wears, 14940
 While she her gallant thrusteth in
 To some dark cupboard, chest, or bin,
 Whence, when the proper time arrive,
 She lets him out, more dead than 'live.
 And he, who anxiously doth wait
 Until she comes to liberate
 Him once again, by dire despair
 And fear is torn while crouching there.

A lover
tricked

Then, if it prove some new-lit flame,
To whom, incautiously, the dame,
Hath given untimely rendezvous,
She'll quick determine what to do ;
And while she keeps the one close
hid,

14950

The later comer will she bid
Welcome in some small chamber near,
And grant the grace he seeks of her,
But let him know he must away
Forthwith, howe'er he beg to stay,
And though with rage and grief he cry,
Boldly to him will she reply :

14960

Hence ! hence ! delay behoveth not,
For I within the house have got
My husband and my cousin kin,
And were you found by them herein,
I swear, by God and Saint Germain,
I ne'er should see your face again ;
Another time I'll gladly make
You welcome till the morning break,
But stay not now, nor hesitate,
My presence all those folk await.

14970

The house of him she needs must clear,
For till he goes she's racked with fear.
And then must she return in haste
To where the other one doth waste
His hour in terror, lest that he
Be dragged forth ignominiously ;
And freeing him from where he's hid,
For consolation doth she bid
Him welcome to her loving arms,
As solace for his past alarms ;

14980

Danger But, ere permitting all he will,
heightens Into his mind doth she instil
pleasure A sense of what great risks she's run,
And fearsome dangers undergone,
While she of madness doth accuse
Herself, who thus by artful ruse
Deceives her husband, e'en while she
Doth wrong herself exceedingly.

And, by her father's soul she swears
That this adventure which she dares 14990
To pleasure him doth cost too dear,
Although, God wot, they've less to fear
Within her room than those who go
To sport in fields 'neath vines arow,
But pleasure all the more 'tis spiced
With danger is more highly prized.
And whensoever they come to lie
Together in their secrecy,
'Tis well that she exclude the light
From every casement, lest he might 15000
Upon her body spy some spot
Or blemish, when right well I wot
Forth from her chamber would he go
As bolt or arrow shot from bow.
[*Pass eighteen lines, they nought avail
To make, but rather mar the tale.*]
And should they twixt themselves agree
That, opportune 'twould sometimes be
For her in turn to make repair
To where he dwells, she'll take good care 15010
So to arrange that somewhat late
She comes, for if she makes him wait

False
fears

Awhile, she doth but fan the fire
 Of anxious unfulfilled desire.
 The game of love, I scarce need say,
 But winneth zest by short delay,
 And little joy the heart doth reap
 From pleasure it may win good cheap.
 But when she comes within the house
 And finds reception amorous, 15020
 She then should vow, with signs of fear,
 How that her jealous spouse anear
 Hath watched her, and she dreads to think
 What bitter draught she needs must drink,
 So soon as she again doth come
 Beneath his tyrant hand at home.
 But howsoe'er she plain and sigh,
 Whether she speak the truth or lie,
 A parlous fear should she dissemble,
 And, dreading nought, seem all atremble, 15030
 For this will much the joy enhance
 Betwixt them of soft dalliance.

But if to him she cannot fare
 Nor bid him to her home doth dare,
 So close a watch her jealous spouse
 Maintains both in and out the house,
 To free her she must cause to wink
 His wakeful eyes 'neath well-spiced drink,
 And if he fail to nod 'neath wine,
 Herbs should she with his drink combine, 15040
 Or mix with food (but in such wise
 That nought of danger thence arise),
 And then shall he so soundly sleep
 As neither watch nor ward to keep,

The And she at leisure may fulfil,
bagnio Unlet or hindered, all her will.
 If lackeys hath she, let her heed
 That this and that one forth she speed
 While coin, if wisely on them spent,
 Will greatly help her fond intent. 15050
 Or if she fears lest they should know
 Her secret, make them drunk also.
 Or to her husband may she say :
 " I feel quite out of health to-day,
 Some fever, gout, or inward grief,
 Affecteth me past all belief ;
 Our baths are useless, I must hie
 Me towards the bagnio presently ;
 A vapour bath alone can give
 Me ease, if you would have me live." 15060
 Though for a while the wretch delay
 Consent, at last she gets her way ;
 For when he hath with sorry face
 Pondered thereon, with wry grimace
 He yields though of his shame afraid.
 Then goes she with her chambermaid,
 Or else some friendly neighbour, who
 Knows well what 'tis her will to do,
 Or some companion hath perchance
 With whom she carries on love's dance. 15070
 Then to the bagnio will she speed,
 Though to the baths she gives small
 heed,
 Or else perhaps the bathhouse shuns
 And to her swain's embraces runs.
 Unless indeed between them 'twere
 Agreed that they a bath should share,

For should he knowledge gain that she
Comes there, there also will he be.

Love-
potions
useless

No man a woman can protect
Who for herself hath no respect. 15080
Yea, e'en was Argus overmatched
Though with his hundred eyes he watched,
Whereof one moiety he kept
Wide open while the other slept,
For therefore Mercury was sped
By Jove to shear off Argus' head,
Fair Io to revenge I trow,
Whom he transformed had to a cow.
Futile his watch—a heavy yoke
Bears he who meddles with such folk. 15090

But let a woman note this well :
Whatever clerks or laymen tell
Let her no idle tales believe
(Which none but fools as truth receive)
Of sorcerers and enchanters dire,
Or witches dancing round the fire,
E'en though they might surpass the fancy
Of Helenus in necromancy
And second-sight; nor let her think
That she by potions and charmed drink 15100
Can draw some lover to her side
Who from his faith hath wandered wide.

Ne'er could Medea win again
False Jason, he of Glauce fain ;
Nor could wise Circe's magic art
Control Ulysses' wandering heart.

A Most careful should a woman be,
 woman's Though she a man loves tenderly,
 gifts Gifts to forbear of value great :
 A pillow soft and delicate, 15110
 A purse, a handkerchief, or hood,
 Not costly, though fair made and good,
 A silken lace, a belt to clasp
 His waist with inexpensive hasp.
 Or pretty pocket-knife of steel,
 Or scarf fine wove, and soft to feel,
 Such as are made by cloistered nuns.
 But give not to those holy ones
 Your love, for women secular
 In such affairs are safer far. 15120
 More free are they to do whate'er
 They fancy, and on hand they bear
 Their friends or spouses as they please,
 But costly both are those and these ;
 Yet deem I, should I judge the twain,
 That nuns cost most with no more gain.
 But women's gifts will men of sense
 Receive with doubt and diffidence,
 For all too often are they nought
 But traps whereby fond fools are caught ; 15130
 ↘ And 'gainst their nature women sin,
 Who seek 'by gifts men's love to win.

Largess is better left to men ;
 Women but compass mischief when
 They give great gifts ; I've noticed oft
 The devil made our hearts too soft.
 But nought it matters—few are they
 Of women who give much away.

The gifts that I have named to you,
 Fair son, are such as well will do 15140
 The fools to cozen, cheat, and gull,
 Of which, good Lord, the world's brimfull.
 All that is given to you, hold fast,
 Remembering youth will soon be past,
 For on us creepeth, day by day,
 Old age which none can let or stay.
 Take care to garnish well your purse,
 For thus may you avoid the curse
 That surely falls on all folk left
 In age's cave, of goods bereft. 15150
 Get wealth, for men of starveling need
 Are valued not one mustard seed.
 Alas! poor fool! that I did not
 Practise what now I preach, God wot!

Forget
 not old
 age

All the fair gifts that came to me
 From those who loved me follily,
 As readily I gave again
 To men of whom my heart was fain,
 And gifts have brought me in old age
 To eat the bread of vassalage; 15160
 The flight of time ne'er troubled me,
 And hence, alas! my misery.
 Of poverty had I no dread,
 But as time came e'en so it sped,
 All that I gat I freely spent,
 'Twas lightly won and lightly went;
 Yea, by my soul I might have been,
 If prudent, wealthy as a queen,
 For many a rich man at my feet
 Had I, when gentle, young, and sweet, 15170

**Infatua-
tion** And held them fast within my snare.
 By God and St. Thibaud I swear
 That all I had amassed I gave
 Unto a false and traitorous knave,
 Who pleased me above all, though he
 Put me to shame most cruelly :
 My love, I many another called,
 But he 'fore all my heart enthralled ;
 Alas ! though tender, true, and keen
 My love, he prized me not a bean. 15180
 Ah ! then to what disgrace I fell !
 The villain made my life a hell,
 Entreated me with foul disgrace,
 And called me strumpet 'fore my
 face.

A woman am I and no more,
 And woman's judgment-wit is poor.
 The man who loved me, loved I not,
 But him who did my features blot
 With blows, and beat me with his fist,
 Adored I, and that foul hand kissed. 15190
 The more he beat me, all the more
 My heart felt to its very core
 Fond love of him. So well his peace
 He made, that soon another lease
 Of love I gave him, though my back
 And bosom beat he blue and black
 With ugly bruises, and no trace
 Of beauty left he on my face,
 Till I to him for mercy cried,
 And then when he repentant sighed 15200
 (Of loving favours once more fain),
 The wretch, who held my life amain

Within his power, so deftly spake,
 That I permitted him to make
 His peace within my arms, for he
 The game of love knew perfectly.
 Ah! villain, traitor, perjured thief,
 How fond my love! how keen my
 grief!

A wastrel

I cared to live for him alone,
 And at his beck had freely gone
 Across the seas; yea had he sped
 To London, I had followed.

15210

So loved I him, so loved he me,
 That each shamed each right recklessly,
 And he in riotous display
 All that I gave him cast away,
 In taverns lording it at dice,
 Deep sunk in every wildest vice,
 And scorning any craft to learn
 Whereby he might fair living earn,
 Nor saw why he thereof should heed
 While I supplied his wasteful need,
 And well I knew the means whereby
 To feed his lawless luxury.

15220

For all the world my tenants were,
 And what I gained with many a care
 And deep disgrace, I showered on him,
 While he indulged each caitiff whim.
 No thought had he to pass the time
 In aught but riot, vice, and crime,
 And was of mouth so tender, it
 Loved not to feel the needful bit.
 But a drear season dawned at last,
 The day of light-won gifts was past,

15280

Walk We begged our bread devoid of home,
warily Our goods not worth a hackle-comb.
 No husband had I ever wed,
 But hither came as I have said,
 Torn, worn, and scratched with many a
 briar.

Most earnestly do I desire,
 Fair son, that you should learn of me
 Wisely to walk and warily,
 And thus my sad experience
 May to your youth be shield and fence.
 For when your Rose is withered quite,
 And raven locks exchanged for white,
 Then will you lack the gifts that snow
 On every side around you now.

15240

The Author.

Thus the Duenna preached and prosed,
 To which Fair-Welcome nought opposed, 15250
 But gladly gave the sermon ear,
 Feeling of her less dread and fear
 Than he had done in time gone by ;
 For now it seemed, assuredly,
 That but for Jealousy's ill-will
 And those three porters who fulfil
 Her hestings (three at least alive
 Who still with mad endeavour strive
 To hold the fort), but light it were
 To take the stronghold unaware,
 But yet he doubts that scarce can be,
 While it is watched so studiously.

15260

Evil-
Tongue
unre-
gretted

The death of Evil-Tongue doth not
Cause unto them much grief, I wot :
For he within the place had made
Few friends, but each in turn betrayed
And slandered to foul Jealousy,
Past master of all falsehood, he.
Not one among the whole of them
Had given a wretched garlick stem 15270
To save his life, except that dame
Perchance, whom I of late did name.
Upon her ear more sweetly fell
His slanders than a chapel bell,
And, her foul wretchedness, delight
Found, when his shalm piped hate and
spite.

From her he hid no evil thing,
That he could through long memory bring
To light, if it might mischief do
And foul misfortune thence ensue. 15280
But counted 'mong his worst of crimes
It was, that he would oftentimes
Declare for truth tales false and vile,
The which he would invent the while ;
Or add to simple stories true
A fringe, which mean and base he knew,
And thus, confounding wrong with right,
Please Jealousy's foul appetite,
For of a truth he all his life
Pastured on envy, hate, and strife. 15290
For him no mass was said or sung,
When in the moat his corse was flung,
Nor did his friends his loss deplore,
For when their strength they reckoned o'er,

Fair- They judged they might the place defend,
 Wel- Although five thousand men should spend
 come's Their force thereon courageously.
 reply

The Three Porters.

Certes, cried they, but weak were we
 If we should fail the fort to hold
 Without this thief, this lying scold, 15300
 This traitor false, this felon dire,
 God grant the master of hell fire
 May harass and torment his soul !
 On all men wrought he grief and dole.

The Author.

Though these proud words the porters sped,
 Truth was it, whatsoe'er they said,
 Great loss to them was Evil-Tongue.

When the Duenna had outsung
 Her tale, Fair-Welcome took the word,
 And spake as one who having heard 15310
 Discourse, knows how to gloss thereon.

Fair-Welcome.

Madam, great honour have you done
 To me in teaching me your art,
 And therefor thank you from my heart,
 But when you spake to me of love,
 That bitter-sweet disease, above
 My power it was to understand
 Your meaning, but at second-hand,

Nor long I more thereof to learn.
 When you describe how I might earn
 Great wealth, thereto I can but say
 I have enough, and fain the way
 Would keep of gentle courtesy,
 Which sweet and grateful is to me.
 But devilish arts to magic due
 Despise I, whether false or true.
 As to the youth on whom such high
 Praises you deign to multiply,
 And in whose manners, ways, and
 face,

Admit
 Fair-
 Welcome

15820

The fairest virtues find a place,
 God grant that still in him they thrive.
 Nor him, nor any man alive
 I envy, nor indeed hath he
 Hold on my love to high degree,
 For though the chaplet that he sent
 I took, thereby no more I meant
 Of love than men mean when we hear
 Them say: "God save you," or "Good
 cheer ;"

15830

Or e'en as neighbours passing by:
 "God bless you, friend," politely cry.
 Honour I give to him above
 Most men, but no exceeding love ;
 Yet since he sent this chaplet fair,
 And I accepted it, I swear
 Nought else had pleased me half as
 much.

15840

And since that his desire is such
 To see me, let him come e'en now
 And great will be my joy, I vow,

Jealousy To see his face ; but time must he
 outwitted Choose when his foe, Dame Jealousy, 15850
 Goes hence, for greatly should I fear
 Mishap if she should find him here,
 And sorely dread that she may lack
 Some thing or other, and turn back,
 Though forth she pass, for oftentimes she
 Returns all unexpectedly ;
 Then straight, with temper more than warm,
 About my head she'd raise a storm.
 Such hatred in her breast doth burn
 Against me, that should she return 15860
 By chance, and find the lover here,
 Though of all blame I might be clear,
 My blood, past doubt by her, were shed,
 And I alive dismembered.

The Author.

Then the Duenna readily :

The Duenna.

Nay, leave the care thereof to me ;
 Although that he were in the house,
 With Jealousy the despitous,
 So help me God and St. Remy,
 More easily an ant's egg she 15870
 Should find within a truss of hay,
 Than one I hide from light of day
 Herein, for every nook I know
 Where I may fugitives bestow.

Fair-Welcome.

To see him enter were I fain,
Quoth he, but trust he may refrain
From outrage or unseemliness.

**The
Duenna
consents**

The Duenna.

By body of God! thou dost express
Thyself, fair son, in wondrous wise :
A jewel art thou in mine eyes.

15380

The Lover.

They ceased—no more was left to say,
And each one sped a different way,
Fair-Welcome to his chamber hied,
While the duenna must provide
For matters of the house. But when
Time, place, and season suited, then
The hag, with will the work to do
For which she gave her promise to
Fair-Welcome, down the stair of stone
Ran quickly, seeing him alone,
From out the tower, nor weary felt
Until she came to where I dwelt,
Hasting to tell me how I might
Get of Fair-Welcome speech and sight.
Then spake she as one wearied out.

15390

The Duenna.

If I should bring to you, past doubt,
News that your heart to joyance lifts,
May I then claim of you fair gifts ?

The Lover.

The Fair gifts! aye, verily, good store,
entry Rich robe and mantle fitted for
granted A queen, and hood with fur bedight,
And dainty boots, and hosen white,
If you but aid my cause;—then said
The hag that, well it were I sped
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15400

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